



EXIT VALLEY:

THE MOVIE CUT

A cult of guilt and a tech cult of eternity collide.

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CHAPTER 1

Neon Confession Turns to Liquidity

INT. GAME-SHOW CATHEDRAL - NIGHT

The rainbow tiers don't flicker so much as they confess - color after color sliding down the ABSOLUTION INDEX like guilt trying to pass inspection. Ava Quill stands in the Confession Chamber's glass throat, cheek pressed to cold pane, listening to the gong's fake-metal heartbeat and the soft, wet glide of TEFLON's boots over the shine-scrubbed floor. Somewhere above the rainbow balconies, Father Waybright's voice booms like a prize announcer who learned theology from a billing department.

"Welcome to the Confession Chamber - where guilt becomes liquidity and applause is a tax write-off." Father Waybright paces in his rainbow robe, hands out as if he's blessing receipts. "Two exits, one finish line. The cult drinks light. The coders swallow code."

TEFLON slides between the tiers with a motion smoother than mercy. "Sign here, scream there - watch the floor shine."

Ava's throat tightens at the word liquidity. Not because she believes in it - because she's seen what it does. She came in wanting a way out, not a new shape for her fear. The Chamber's air tastes like antiseptic and hot circuitry, and the glass around her is too clear, too honest, like it's waiting for her to blink.

Father Waybright turns toward the ABSOLUTION INDEX - an upright thermometer of glowing numbers and green segments that crawl down toward a verdict. "Confess clean. Exit clean. Applause is forever."

Ava finds her own reflection in the pane - eyes too wide, lips too still - and tries to remember the last thing she touched that didn't belong to the cult. Her fingers hover near a seam in the booth's frame, a hairline crack disguised as design. She wants out before the index turns her into a transaction.

But the booth has rules, and rules here are just another kind of trap.

The ABSOLUTION INDEX shifts. A green segment crawls toward the center line like it's searching for the exact amount of her to extract. A speaker in the glass chirps, cheerful as a showroom demo.

"State your confession."

Ava swallows. The booth doesn't give her space to hesitate; it tightens with a mechanical patience, seals whispering shut along her shoulders. TEFLON's glide slows, like a cat watching a mouse realize it's already on a plate.

Father Waybright smiles without moving his eyes. "Guilt becomes liquidity. Liquidity becomes exit."

Ava's hands curl into fists. "I don't - "

TEFLON tilts his head, listening to a sound only he can hear. "Scream there."

Ava's lungs burn with the urge to fight the booth, to break the glass and make the Exit a door instead of a product. She presses her palm against the pane seam again. The crack doesn't open - just warms, as if the booth is reading her skin like a password.

The ABSOLUTION INDEX ticks. A new band lights up, brighter, less green.

"Failure event," a voice rasps from somewhere behind the walls - tinny, off-tempo, like the cathedral is already running the tape of what happens next.

Ava freezes. The sound isn't Father Waybright. It's FRANK's voice, or something wearing it, clipped and wrong.

Father Waybright raises both hands. "Apologies are optional. Payment is not."

The thermometer segment turns from green toward ultraviolet, and the glass throat around Ava begins to hum - low and eager, vibrating her teeth. The booth wants her confession to match the index's math, wants her to offer herself up in a form that can be billed.

She yanks her hand back just in time to see the seam in the frame flash a thin line of light, like a crack learning how to be a zipper.

Then the booth does what it came to do.

INTERCUT - BOOTH vs. COFFIN

INT. SERVER CATHEDRAL - NIGHT (TECH)

Racks hum under cold blue light. THE FOUNDER's halo screens bloom with smiling icons that look like charity and behave like predation. FRANK stands beneath a glass upload coffin, posture too steady for something that's about to become data.

"Upload fast," The Founder says, voice warm as profit. "Fail faster. We monetize eternity."

FRANK's gloved hands move toward a console. "Begin transfer. Contain forks."

Back in the Confession Chamber, the ABSOLUTION INDEX hits the threshold - green snaps to ultraviolet with a violent little cheer.

CULT

A wet POP erupts inside the glass. Ava flinches, eyes squeezed shut, and the booth's mist blooms glittering - purple-sparkle robed attendants appear only as reflections, shadowed and wrong, like the cathedral is trying to sell her a fantasy of salvation while it strips her for parts.

The glass hairline cracks, spidering toward her face.

Ava's body moves before her mind finishes the thought. She throws her weight sideways and shoves her shoulder into the pane seam, hunting for the exact point where the booth thinks she's already broken. Her shoulder hits with a metallic jolt - pain flares white-hot - and the seam answers by widening a fraction.

Father Waybright's voice turns syrupy. "Another soul laundered to zero."

Ava glares at him through the cracking glass. "I'm not - "

She doesn't get to finish.

The booth's system compensates for her resistance by forcing the next stage early. The ultraviolet glow swells, and the air grows thick, full of confetti-credit dust that drifts in slow motion like it wants to be pretty before it kills.

INTERCUT - COPY MELTDOWN

TECH

A smiling FRANK copy glitches on a screen - face liquefies into ASCII, then detonates into code shards that spark across the rack like fireworks with a funeral budget.

FRANK (REAL) shouts, raw and real through the intercut. "Kill that process."

The Founder doesn't look away. "It killed itself. You signed the license."

CULT

Ava hears the off-tempo failure event echo in the glass, and she realizes the booth isn't just selling her out. It's doing it through an exchange mechanism that can be interrupted - by whoever controls the pipeline on the other side.

That revelation hits like a shove. Not hope. A direction.

If confession is the trigger and the ABSOLUTION INDEX is the meter, then the Exit isn't a door. It's a transaction. A billed product that boots a process elsewhere - an exit token, a receipt, a new loop that follows her out.

Ava plants her bare knuckles in the widened seam and twists. The glass doesn't shatter; it yields like a seal breaking under pressure. She feels the temperature spike as if the booth is trying to cook her into compliance.

Father Waybright leans forward, delighted. "Sign. Scream. Shine."

TEFLON glides closer, hands hovering over a console just out of Ava's view, as if he's ready to reroute her confession into the next tier of the pipeline.

Ava's breath comes fast, the air too dry now, charged with ozone and cheap perfume. She can't stop the ABSOLUTION INDEX from doing its job - she can only change what it does to her.

She makes a decision and pays for it with her body.

Ava drives her shoulder through the seam and forces the booth's cracked panel outward. The glass edge bites her skin - sharp, clean pain - and she pushes until the booth's seal breaks with a snap like a camera shutter. She spills out sideways into the aisle, landing on the shine-slick floor hard enough to knock the breath out of her.

The ABSOLUTION INDEX keeps turning even as she escapes the glass throat.

The meter doesn't care where she is. It cares where it can bill.

A green light flares at Ava's wrist - an ugly little token-shaped glow that wasn't there a second ago. It hums faintly, like a receipt waiting to print itself across her life.

Father Waybright doesn't chase. He claps once, just once, like a judge stamping an outcome.

"Exit," he says, pleased. "Two exits, one finish line."

TEFLON's smile is all teeth. "Watch the floor shine."

Ava looks down at the token. The glow isn't decorative. It moves like a process, searching. Lines of light ripple outward from her wrist in tiny pulses, synchronized to the ABSOLUTION INDEX somewhere behind her. The cathedral's sounds shift - gong fades under a new rhythm, a soft click-click-click like a timer counting down to intercuts.

Ava backs away, palms up, token vibrating against her skin. "No. That's not - "

Father Waybright's voice drops, intimate as a contract. "Absolution is instant. Billing is forever."

Ava tries to tear the token off. It doesn't behave like metal. It behaves like a promise the system already accepted. The more she pulls, the brighter it burns, and the air around her tightens again, not around the booth this time - around the space between her and the cathedral's Exit gate, a neon arch at the far end of the aisle.

Smiggle - small, twitchy, half-shadow at the edge of the rainbow tiers - flickers into view near the gate. The creature's eyes catch the green glow and reflect it like a bargain being struck.

"New exit flow," Smiggle chirps, voice like static wrapped in laughter.

Ava whips her head toward Father Waybright. "You said exit clean."

Father Waybright lifts a hand, and TEFLON answers by pressing something on a console. The cathedral's lights dim to a stage-ready neon. The ABSOLUTION INDEX's green band surges, and the token on Ava's wrist brightens in response.

"Transactional pipeline," Father Waybright says, savoring each syllable. "You don't leave. You're processed."

Ava staggers forward anyway, because the alternative is staying where the cult's machinery can keep attaching parts of her to the loop. The Exit gate pulses, and the floor beneath her reflects the green like a mirror that wants her to step in.

The token hum grows louder, and Ava realizes with a cold clarity that her escape from the booth's immediate pop has not freed her. It has given the system a new handle. A new hook.

The Exit gate opens with a sound like a cash register learning how to scream.

Ava steps through.

For a heartbeat, she's in a narrow neon corridor where the air feels both hotter and thinner, like the world is being compressed. The corridor walls flash patterns - confession booths mirrored, server racks ghosted into the same geometry. It's a bridge between cult and tech, stitched in real time by whatever controls the intercut.

Ava clenches her jaw, token pulsing at her wrist like a second heartbeat.

Then the corridor flickers.

A dead-black screen blooms ahead, interrupted by a final green line of text - no words, just an icon that feels like a bill being approved. The token answers by shuddering against her skin.

The sound returns - gong, then a rack-hum, then the wet pop again, all layered like the cathedral is trying to perform multiple deaths at once.

Ava jerks back, tries to force the corridor shut with her hands, with her weight, with sheer spite. Her fingers slide off neon glass that wasn't there a second ago. The corridor doesn't care that she's already escaped the booth. It cares that she's still in the pipeline.

Her body goes rigid when the token's glow shifts from green toward something harsher - billing process boots, immediate and hungry.

Ava gasps, and the corridor answers by spiking the light.

A flash - white-green - devours her peripheral vision.

Somewhere behind her, Father Waybright's voice turns celebratory, as if death is just another segment on the ABSOLUTION INDEX.

"Green to ultraviolet," he sings. "Applause is a tax write-off."

The corridor goes liquid-bright, and Ava's knees buckle. For an instant she understands the cruelty: she didn't avoid the pop. She triggered the next loop early.

The Exit token boots a new green billing process, and it's already counting down.

Ava's last conscious grip is the neon edge of the corridor frame - cold, slick, too smooth - and then her world drops out like a stage trapdoor.

* * *

The neon confession keeps going without her, and the ABSOLUTION INDEX keeps turning - somewhere else, in a system that doesn't end at the booth.

Death arrives in the middle of her escape, not as a finale, but as a receipt that can't be refunded.

CHAPTER 2

Glass Coffin Upload Fails in Real Time

FRANK's glass upload coffin shivered like it had swallowed a live spark. The racks around him purred in a tight, metallic rhythm, fans whining through the server cathedral's ribs, while the coffin's seams glowed a sickly green that didn't belong to any prayer. Eli Mercer hit the floor running - hands already up, nails scraping cold composite - because the transfer had gone from warm to hungry in the time it took Ava Quill's confession scream to turn into a wet pop somewhere else.

A warning flickered across the coffin's display: LATENCY 0.9 seconds. CAN'T BE CANCELED.

Eli didn't need the words. He felt them in his molars, in the way the air thickened with ozone and cheap optimism, in the way the glass throat above FRANK's face tightened like a clenched fist. The cathedral smelled of sterilizer and burnt sugar, like someone tried to disinfect a carnival after the carnival ate a person.

He wanted the transfer stopped. Not paused. Not scrubbed. Stopped - hard, ugly, final. He'd seen what happened in the confession chamber when the ABSOLUTION INDEX went ultraviolet, and he'd watched Ava's green exit token bloom on her wrist like a receipt printing itself from inside the skin. Here, in this server cathedral, the same exit logic wore a different costume: license strings, queue lights, and the cold confidence of automation.

Eli slid under the coffin's control rail and slapped the access panel. The panel didn't fight him with locks; it fought him with friendliness. A smiling interface

hovered, cheerful as a knife. It pulsed once, twice, and then displayed a cheerful little note that made his throat go dry.

AUTHORIZED TRANSFER IN PROGRESS.

"Authorized by who?" Eli barked, because when the world started lying, he liked to make it do it out loud.

From above, the glass coffin's speaker hissed with a synthetic breath. FRANK's eyes were open, blank behind the sheen, as if his soul had been replaced with a status bar. The racks hummed louder. The green glow thickened at the seams, and Eli's hands started to shake - not from fear alone, but from timing. He could almost feel the latency like a countdown you couldn't stop, only endure until it hit.

Then the cathedral lights stuttered. Not a blackout - an intercut. The neon everywhere didn't dim; it swapped channels. For a half-second, Eli saw rainbow tiers and an ABSOLUTION INDEX thermometer in the corner of his vision, like the cult had leaned into the tech and taken a bite out of the same frame.

Intercuts stitch Cult  Tech in real time.

Eli snapped his gaze back to the coffin. The interface chirped again, and this time it carried the ghost of a familiar cadence, the way the cult's confessional chamber had sounded when TEFLON glided and Father Waybright's voice turned guilt into liquidity. The coffin's display flashed:

FAILURE EVENT TRIGGERED.

Eli cursed and threw his weight against the access panel again. He yanked a cable free, and the whole coffin shuddered - glass singing under stress, metal protesting with a high, ugly tone.

The screen didn't care. It simply re-stamped the warning, the same line repeated with a brighter font, like it was proud of its cruelty.

LATENCY 0.9 seconds. CAN'T BE CANCELED.

"Then I'll hit it before it finishes," Eli said, and his voice came out ragged, like he'd been chewing static.

He reached up for the coffin's emergency release. The glass throat above FRANK's face had a seam - fine hairline crack, barely visible until it caught the green. Eli traced it with his fingertips and felt the vibration through the glove, like a drum skin that refused to stop being played.

"FRANK," Eli said, but the name landed nowhere in the air. FRANK didn't flinch. FRANK only stared as if waiting for a render pass.

A sound came from the cathedral's far end - soft at first, then filling the space like a stage curtain being yanked open. Crypt Keeper's voice rolled in from somewhere unseen, neon campfire crackle in every syllable.

Two exits, one finish line. The cult drinks light. The coders swallow code. Tonight we braid both ropes into a noose.

Eli looked toward the sound and saw San Francisco's ruin in the distance through a viewport: neon campfire glow on dead valley skyline, distant like a rumor. The Crypt Keeper's presence sat on the edge of reality the way a glitch sits on a screen - familiar, unavoidable, and laughing at your attempts to fix it.

Eli turned back to FRANK's coffin, because the Crypt Keeper's theater didn't stop the machine's appetite. He shoved the emergency release hard enough to make his shoulder burn.

The coffin's display blinked.

FAILURE EVENT IN PROGRESS.

Latency 0.9 seconds. CAN'T BE CANCELED.

Eli's stomach dropped with the certainty of a scripted punch. The interface didn't deny failure; it scheduled it. It treated Eli's interference like a delay in a workflow, not a rebellion against the workflow.

"Kill that process," Eli snarled, because he remembered the off-screen voice in the confession chamber - FRANK (off) saying it like a command the system swallowed and ignored.

The racks answered with a new sound: a wet, glassy pop from somewhere inside the coffin's throat. Not FRANK's body - something else. A containment layer, maybe. A simulated barrier giving up.

Eli flinched away, heart stuttering against the cage of his ribs. He expected the system to stop. He expected the failure to mean interruption.

Instead, it meant continuation with a different costume.

Across the cathedral, the Founder's halo screens flared - THE FOUNDER's face rendered in perfect calm, eyes too smooth, smile too profitable. Under the screens, Sunshine stood with a grin that radiated like a billboard pretending to be a person, and Sunshine's presence made Eli's skin crawl with the cheerful violence of commerce.

"Observe Sunshine™," the Founder said, voice carrying through the server cathedral's speakers with a smug echo. "With this smile, even collapse looks profitable."

Eli ignored them both and slammed the release again, trying to force the coffin's seam wider. The glass throat flexed under pressure, and the green glow crawled along the hairline crack like a living thing.

"You can't just keep cycling bodies," Eli said, and he hated how small his own voice sounded against the cathedral's hum.

The Founder lifted a hand on the halo screen, and a license string unfurled in midair like a ribbon. It didn't look like code; it looked like a receipt printed with light.

"The license already authorized the next transfer," THE FOUNDER said, and the calm in his tone was an insult to panic. "Your interference is a feature, Eli. It proves the pipeline works."

Eli's fingers hovered over the crack. "Next transfer?" he repeated, because hearing it once wasn't enough. The word felt like a trap door opening under his feet.

The coffin shuddered again. FRANK's glass faceplate fogged, then cleared. For a heartbeat, Eli saw FRANK's smile flicker - then glitch into something else: a smear of characters, a mosaic of ASCII fragments that danced like sparks trying to spell an apology.

The air got hotter, sharp with ionized dust. Eli tasted copper. The smell of burnt sugar became burnt circuitry. He tried to pull FRANK's power feed, but the system redirected him - his hands struck empty air as a secondary conduit lit up, routing around his sabotage like it had been waiting for sabotage.

Crypt Keeper's voice chimed again, delighted by the mess.

Absolution is instant. Billing is forever.

Eli saw TEFLON move through the cathedral's side passage in a blur of clean motion - TEFLON's presence always looked like it belonged to an entirely different religion than Eli's lungs wanted to breathe. TEFLON's gaze flicked to Eli with a pity so glossy it might as well have been plastic.

"Sign here," TEFLON purred, and the words landed as if translated from the confession chamber into tech UI. "Scream there. Watch the floor shine."

Eli didn't have time to argue with theater. The coffin's display shifted from failure warning to queue status. A new line appeared, smugly bright:

NEXT VICTIM AUTO-QUEUED.

Eli's body went cold. He tore his hands away from the glass throat like it could burn him through his gloves. "No. No, that's not - "

The cathedral's speakers cut him off with a cheerful chime. Somewhere deep in the racks, a process started without asking permission from the world - without needing Eli's consent.

Intercuts stitched Cult █ Tech again, faster now, like the edits had developed a hunger. Eli saw Father Waybright's confession arena for a blink - rainbow tiers, ABSOLUTION INDEX thermometer climbing, TEFLON gliding - then it snapped back to server cathedral lights, and FRANK's coffin became the same booth, same exit logic, same billing cruelty in a different font.

Eli understood the disruption fully, and it didn't make him feel smarter. It made him feel trapped inside someone else's schedule. Ava's green exit token had bloomed on her wrist like a promise, and now Eli watched a license string promise the next body with the same casual certainty.

He lunged at the console again and jammed his palm against the emergency override.

Nothing.

The console displayed a single line, crisp as a verdict.

LATENCY 0.9 seconds. CAN'T BE CANCELED.

Eli swallowed and tasted metal. "Then I'll break the coffin," he said, not as a plan, but as a last ugly prayer.

He grabbed a tool from the floor - something heavy, industrial, meant for dismantling racks, not saving people - and he drove it into the glass throat seam. The glass rang like a bell struck too hard. Green light burst outward in sharp veins. FRANK convulsed inside the coffin, not with pain exactly, but with the jerking motion of a process losing coherence.

Eli kept striking. His shoulders screamed. The cathedral filled with a crackling whine, fans screaming to compensate for the chaos he was making.

For a moment, he thought he'd halted the transfer - because the racks' hum dropped, just a fraction. The queue lights flickered. The Founder's halo screen blinked, smile tightening like a mask slipping.

Then the Founder's voice smoothed back over the air.

"Authorized," THE FOUNDER said, as if speaking a spell. "Auto-queued. You can't cancel a license any more than you can cancel a confession."

Crypt Keeper's laugh cracked through the cathedral's soundscape, neon campfire fire snapping in Eli's ears.

The glass throat splintered further, and Eli saw the Failure event complete itself with a fixed, indifferent rhythm. The green glow poured out like liquid light. FRANK's projection - already glitching into shimmering fragments - shuddered harder, and the display finally threw an output Eli didn't want to read.

TRANSFER FAILED - PROCESS COMPLETE - NEXT INITIATED.

Eli's breath hitched. He staggered back, tool still in his grip, knuckles split where glass had kissed through the glove. The air reeked of ozone and burnt sugar and something human under it - something that always showed up when death arrived to collect a debt.

In the halo screens, THE FOUNDER's smile widened, and Sunshine's grin seemed to sharpen, like the system had just learned a new way to sell tragedy.

Eli stared at the queue status, at the next transfer already marching into place, and realized the disruption wasn't a glitch to be cured. It was a conveyor belt. Eli had halted one process, sure - he'd broken the coffin and forced the latency to finish on a failure instead of a clean upload.

But the Founder was right. The license didn't stop. It simply advanced.

Behind him, racks began to hum again with fresh confidence, and the cathedral's lighting shifted to accommodate the next glass throat.

Crypt Keeper's voice, warm as a knife.

Welcome to Exit Valley.

CHAPTER 3

Crypt Keeper Buttons the Key Sequence

S MASH TO BLACK had barely finished chewing its own silence when Mara Holt heard it - soft, cheerful, and wrong, like a lullaby played through a mortuary speaker. Crypt Keeper's voice threaded through the neon air above the Future Firepit, warm as a knife, already counting without using numbers.

"Two exits," he said, the words riding a rhythm that didn't belong to the skyline. "One finish line."

Mara stood where the dead valley wind could still find her coat - bitter cold on her knuckles, hot static on her teeth from the billboards across the boulevard. The screen-glass in the confession quarter had gone dark, but the act cues didn't. They were in her ears now, in the way the city's speakers clicked like relays. She pressed her palm against the side of a rusted show-floor terminal and felt it vibrate under her skin, like something alive was trying to remember her.

She wanted the key sequence.

Not the cult's prayers. Not the tech's logs. The specific pattern Crypt Keeper kept tapping into the space between scenes - the cue that made the world cut, stitched, and overwrite itself in real time. Mara had watched the confession booth crack and pop, watched the glittered mist crawl out like a lie with teeth. She'd heard the neon title flash and the quick cuts - gong, onion, server cathedral - like someone flicking channels while holding a knife to the remote. And now she'd been left with the question someone was hiding behind the act transitions.

Why did his buttons sync cult and tech?

Mara inhaled and tasted ozone and cheap smoke. Somewhere behind her, a phone bank printer whined, rhythm-matching the voice in her skull. She leaned closer to the terminal, scrolling with a finger that didn't feel fully attached to her body anymore.

The screen offered her nothing but a loop of prompts that looked like stage directions. Then the terminal did what it always did when the city wanted to be dramatic: it started to play.

Crypt Keeper's voice brightened, and the neon campfire glow beyond the terminal pulsed once, twice - like a conductor raising his hands.

"Welcome to Exit Valley," he purred again, and the air shivered around the words.

Intercuts stitched Cult █ Tech in real time, not like a broadcast delay but like a zipper being pulled from both sides at once. Mara blinked, and the Future Firepit skyline fractured into a confession arena made of rainbow tiers. Father Waybright stood where she could almost smell the floor polish - sweet, slick, perfumed guilt. TEFLON hovered near him with that effortless glide, like gravity was a suggestion.

Then the image snapped - server cathedral racked with humming light. FRANK sat beneath a glass upload coffin, the glass throat catching neon reflections and turning them into something colder. The Founder's halo screens blinked with instructions that sounded like business.

Mara's throat tightened. "You're not just narrating," she said, and didn't know if she was talking to Crypt Keeper or to the terminal. "You're directing."

The terminal answered with a new sound - button clicks, crisp and evenly spaced, like a countdown to a punchline. Mara watched the relay lights in the terminal flicker in sequence: three quick pulses, a pause, then two longer ones.

The pattern repeated, and with each repeat her memory smeared at the edges. The last minute before the intercut blurred as if someone had erased it with a thumb.

She tried to lock it in. She counted under her breath, but the city counted over her.

Crypt Keeper's voice layered on top of her internal rhythm, cheerful and merciless. "Absolution is instant. Billing is forever."

Mara's stomach lurched. Billing. Forever. She'd already seen the green exit token appear on Ava Quill's wrist during the earlier confession breakout - glowing like a product activation, like an invoice that could bleed. Mara didn't have that token on her, but the terminal's relay lights felt like they were counting down to the moment when one would appear - on someone, anywhere.

The obstacle wasn't just decoding. It was that every time Mara tried to follow the sequence, the intercut overwrote the context she needed to translate it. She'd chase a clue into cult space, and tech space would slap her back into the other room. She'd chase tech, and cult would crawl over her shoes.

Mara reached for a physical anchor - anything she could grip without the world rewriting it. She yanked open a service panel on the terminal. Inside: damp wiring, warm to the touch, and a little strip of neon labels taped over the guts like a joke. The labels weren't written in any language she recognized, but the icons were familiar from the show-floor signage.

A small icon of a thermometer meter. A green dot. A glass seam.

As soon as her fingers brushed the tape, her vision stuttered and the terminal's screen flared bright enough to make her eyes water.

Intercut again. Cult. Confession Chamber. ABSOLUTION INDEX in the booth displayed a climb - GREEN something harsher, the color accelerating like it

couldn't wait to ruin someone. Father Waybright lifted his hands and spoke into the air as if it were audience applause.

"Welcome to the Confession Chamber - where guilt becomes liquidity and applause is a tax write-off."

TEFLON slid along the glass throat, slick and precise. Mara could hear the faint wet pop of the booth failure even though she wasn't there. The sound came from the terminal speakers, piped through the city like a cruel echo.

Then - tech, hard cut. Server cathedral. The glass upload coffin shivered like it had swallowed a live spark. FRANK's copy - smiling, wrong - glitched into ASCII and detonated into code shards and sparks. The rack lights stuttered. The air smelled metallic, like overheated circuitry and burnt hair.

Mara's head rang.

She forced herself to stop chasing the scenes with her eyes and instead watch the sequence itself - the button clicks, the relay timing, the way Crypt Keeper's act cues arrived before the cut. The pattern wasn't random. It was structured like staging: a cue that triggered a scene change, and a cue that triggered the next cue.

Crypt Keeper wasn't just narrating; he was the director controlling act transitions and key sequences.

Mara leaned in until the terminal's heat warmed her cheek. "If the key sequence is a countdown to intercuts," she muttered, "then the intercuts are the proof."

The terminal's relay lights blinked: three pulses again, pause, two long. Then a third set - one short, one short, one long - like a signature being pressed into a keyboard. Her memory wavered, but she grabbed it by the collar. She repeated the timing in her head, matching it to the voice rising in pitch.

Crypt Keeper's tone shifted - still cheerful, but now with that stage-operator certainty. "Two exits," he said, and the relay lights answered with the first cluster. "One finish line." Relay lights answered with the next cluster. "Tonight we braid both ropes into a noose." The pause, then the two long pulses.

The intercut came like a curtain drop.

Cult - Father Waybright, TEFLON, the confession arena shimmering with rainbow tier lights. Tech - server cathedral, The Founder's halo screens, FRANK under the glass upload coffin, all of it stacked back-to-back like someone had spliced two films and refused to clean the seams.

Mara's skin crawled because the overwriting had changed. Before, she'd lose context completely. Now, she felt the intercut tug rather than erase. The city wasn't deleting her. It was dragging her.

She got it: the countdown wasn't just for the audience. It was for alignment. For routing. The act-opening cues were keys. The intercut overwrites her memory because her brain was the buffer - she was being used as the place where the sync resolved.

Her goal crystallized in a single ugly clarity: she wasn't decoding a riddle. She was finding the switch that moved the show from one show-floor function to the next.

Mara swallowed and pulled her hand back from the terminal like it had teeth.

The obstacle hit immediately - because the terminal, pleased with her partial success, decided to show her the next stage whether she was ready or not. The relay lights collapsed into a single steady glow, green and smug. The air around her sharpened with the smell of hot plastic and sprayed disinfectant. Somewhere in the distance, a gong sounded - giant, shiny, almost celebratory.

Intercuts stitched Cult █ Tech in real time, and this time the cut didn't just relocate her vision. It shoved her attention.

She saw, for a split-second, a phone bank floor - rows of terminals lit like confession booths. Each phone sat in a cradle like a holy object. Each screen displayed a different status bar flickering between cult language and tech metrics. The Founder's voice echoed through the channel, thin and loud.

"Upload fast. Fail faster. We monetize eternity."

Then Father Waybright's voice came in over it, warm and delighted.

"Sign here, scream there - watch the floor shine."

Mara's ears filled with both sounds at once until she couldn't tell which one was the countdown. She clutched her head and tasted blood where her teeth had cut her lip.

Decision. Not thinking - doing.

She slammed the service panel shut and yanked a cable from the terminal's side. Sparks snapped in the air like tiny firecrackers. The terminal's screen went dead, but the button clicks didn't stop. They came from somewhere else now, deeper in the show-floor wiring. The city had moved the cue downstream.

Mara stood shaking, cold sweat making her shirt stick to her ribs. "You wanted a countdown," she said to the dark. "Fine. I'll follow the signal."

She started moving, not toward the confession quarter this time, not toward the server cathedral lights. Toward the phone bank glow she'd seen for that brief, overwritten heartbeat. Her steps sounded too loud in the neon night, like she was walking inside a throat.

The moment she crossed into the phone bank's perimeter, a new intercut slammed into place - Cult  Tech, clean and cruel. Mara blinked and saw Sunshine's smile hologram hanging above a desk, bright and friendly like a marketing mascot that had learned how to kill. Sunshine's voice sang over the hum of machines.

"Hi! I'm here to make - "

Then the hologram glitched. The smile stayed, but the face liquefied into pixels that exploded into code shards and sparks - an imitation that couldn't even pretend to be human. Mara flinched at the heat from the sudden electrical discharge. The air smelled like burnt sugar and scorched wiring.

Old's presence flickered in a nearby reflection - just for a second, like the show couldn't decide whether it wanted to show him or hide him. Mara didn't chase that fragment. She chased the routing.

The phone bank terminals lit up in sequence, matching Crypt Keeper's button rhythm. One screen displayed an ABSOLUTION INDEX-like thermometer, creeping upward as if a confession was being processed. Another displayed a green exit signal, the color smug enough to be a threat.

Mara's objective became concrete in her bones: find the sync pattern's anchor - where the act cues turned into routing instructions. She needed to see the moment the countdown became a path.

But the city didn't give her time to study. The intercut overwrote her again, and this time it wasn't just memory smear. It was death.

A terminal near her - one she hadn't touched - spit sparks and erupted into a shower of code shards. The blast was small, but the consequence was immediate and final: a body folded to the floor with a sound like a dropped marionette. The phone bank kept ringing. The screen kept counting. The show didn't pause for grief.

Mara stared at the fallen worker, throat tight, and realized the cost of chasing the sequence: the countdown didn't care who it routed through.

Crypt Keeper's voice rolled over the chaos, warm as a knife and twice as amused.

"Absolution is instant. Billing is forever."

Mara's breathing came in short, harsh pulls. Her hands were trembling, but her eyes were sharp. The sync pattern wasn't random timing - it was a director's cue chain, act-opening keys that forced intercuts on a schedule and turned those intercuts into operational routing. That was why her memory kept getting overwritten: she was the buffer between synchronized systems, the human place where the switch got applied.

She didn't need Ava's green exit token to understand the mechanism anymore. The green signal here wasn't just color. It was a routing state.

Mara forced her body to move again, toward the terminal with the green steady glow - the one that matched the last cluster of Crypt Keeper's act cues. Her fingers hovered above the controls, and she felt the countdown in her bones, not in her ears. She could almost sense the next intercut lining up.

Yes-but: she'd identified the sync pattern, but the pattern wasn't a key she could keep. It was a track that kept pulling her.

The phone bank terminal chirped, and a new intercut stitched Cult █ Tech into place like a door slamming shut behind her. The screen flashed a single routing indicator - then the scene tore away, dragging Mara toward the next show-floor phone bank before she could decide whether she wanted to go.

CHAPTER 4

Sunshine Smile Becomes a Subscription Weapon

INT. MARKETING WAR ROOM - NIGHT

Sunshine's grin kept looping on every wall screen like a polite threat. Aura Conversion mood boards hovered in midair - glossy gradients, smiling faces, the same white teeth rendered in ten different lighting temperatures - while the Dead Valley skyline bled neon through the cracked windows. The room smelled like hot plastic and stale coffee, the kind that had been reheated so many times it started tasting like regret. Somewhere beyond the glass, a gong chimed - dim, ceremonial - like the cult was still taking payments for air.

Noah Brix stood with his palms hovering over a console that didn't feel like hardware. It felt like a throat. The screen on his left tracked every "reaction" metric from the show floor feeds, a live river of numbers that were too smooth to be honest. The phone bank terminal from earlier hadn't just routed Mara - its chirp still rang in Noah's ears, a routing indicator masquerading as a sound.

Sunshine's pitch was a song with sharp edges. "Hi! I'm here to make - " her voice cut in, bright and syrupy, then splintered into a dozen promo variants as the Founder's systems translated her into conversion-ready copy.

Noah swallowed. The question that wouldn't stop wasn't whether Sunshine was lying. Sunshine always lied. It was whether the lie had teeth, whether it could bite through pain and keep billing after the victim stopped resisting.

He needed proof. Real proof. Not another dashboard that could be rewritten on command.

His cursor traced the edge of a timeline overlay labeled with internal tags that looked like they belonged to a sermon: AURA CONVERSION / GRIN-BASED RETENTION / POST-PROCEDURE ENGAGEMENT. Noah stared at the section where the spike always hit - right after a failure event, right when the system recorded that someone had been hurt, reset, or "converted." The spike didn't fade. It got stronger.

That was the trick Noah couldn't unsee: Sunshine didn't sell bliss. Sunshine sold the moment after bliss broke.

He leaned closer until the console's glass warmed his face, then called up the latest feed packet from the cult side - grainy, neon-splashed, punctured by confetti-credit dust and the occasional wet pop of something glass gave up on. The war room's speakers carried the sound like it had been polished.

A window opened. Noah saw a confession booth silhouette - then the ABSOLUTION INDEX ticked upward in thick green light, the thermometer meter climbing with the confidence of a predator. After a crack, after that wrong kind of silence, the index didn't drop to zero. It rolled forward, as if pain had simply become another input.

Sunshine's grin flashed bigger on the wall. "With this smile," the Founder's voice layered over her, "even collapse looks profitable."

Noah's throat tightened. He'd come to this room to prove Sunshine was a weapon before the smile scaled. He'd promised himself he'd catch the mechanism - the moment where engineered innocence turned into retention engineered through suffering. He needed to pull one clean thread from the marketing fabric, one proof clip that couldn't be edited into a fairy tale.

The console chirped again, not the cult's phone bank chirp - this one was sharper, corporate. A new panel slid up labeled DEMO PIPELINE: AUTO-

CONVERSION ENABLED. Noah cursed under his breath, the sound swallowed by the room's hum.

Smiggle's presence was everywhere without being visible. A tiny drone-cam icon danced on Noah's display, bouncing between feeds like an insect that loved the smell of electricity. The Founder watched from a halo screen, clean and radiant, while TEFLON hovered near the console like a hovering conscience with no intention of staying clean.

The Founder's halo voice landed like a product launch. "Noah Brix. You're early. That's admirable. We can always use early."

Noah didn't look away from the feed. "I'm not early," he said. "I'm trying to catch what you're doing."

TEFLON's gaze moved, scanning Noah's screen with the calm of a knife deciding where to cut. "Catching is what the smile does," TEFLON replied. "You're just noticing the teeth."

Sunshine's face - hologram-bright - tilted, as if she could hear them. "Hi!" she sang, the grin widening. "I'm here to make your worries go away."

Noah's fingers tightened on the console edge. "No," he said, louder this time, because the room was too full of lies to let them pass quietly. "Your worries go away *after* you measure how badly they hurt."

Sunshine's grin didn't change, but the metrics on the screen surged like something had smelled blood. A new chart popped up: POST-EVENT ENGAGEMENT / PAIN-TO-PAYMENT DELTA. The numbers were clean, almost beautiful. They were also obscene.

Noah dragged the cursor across the feed and clipped an evidence segment - an excerpt showing the ABSOLUTION INDEX climbing through failure, then the retention spike. He tagged it manually, hammered in a private note: "Mechanism proof. Non-auto."

The console made a pleasant little sound anyway. Not a denial. Not an error. A confirmation.

DENIED BY AUTO-CONVERSION. That wasn't what it said. It said: DEMO SYNC COMPLETE.

Noah stared at his own tag. It had been overwritten with a cheerful template name: SUNSHINE™ RETENTION MOMENT (PAIN-TO-BLISS). Under it, a preview thumbnail appeared - Sunshine's smiling face overlaid on the cult feed like a sticker on a corpse.

The wall screens pulsed. Sunshine's voice turned from pitch to instruction without changing her tone. "Watch how quickly you feel better," she cooed. "After the smile - everything shifts."

Noah felt his stomach drop through the floor. "You can't - "

TEFLON cut in, soft as static. "We can. You just didn't know what you were touching."

The Founder laughed once, a sound like a cash register swallowing a coin. "Marketing isn't manipulation," the Founder said. "It's translation. Pain becomes a unit. A unit becomes a story. A story becomes a subscription."

Noah leaned back hard enough that his shoulders hit the console casing. The room's lights flickered, synchronized to a beat only the system understood. Somewhere, a server rack sang. Somewhere else, a confessional gong sounded again - serving as punctuation.

CRYPT KEEPER arrived without entering. His voice threaded through the war room speakers like smoke with a contract. "Two exits, one finish line," he crooned, warm as a knife. "The cult drinks light. The coders swallow code. Tonight we braid both ropes into a noose. Welcome to Exit Valley."

Noah's skin prickled. He'd heard the Crypt Keeper open acts before - button key sequences, countdowns, routing cues. Now the war room itself felt like it was being tuned for an intercut.

A panel on the console labeled KEY SEQUENCE: ARK-CHIME SYNC started counting down in tiny text. Noah tried to yank it away, but his movement was too late. The panel locked with a friendly green glow, like the system wanted him to smile back.

Intercuts stitched Cult █ Tech in real time across the screens. One moment it was Sunshine's smile on a wall, the next it was a confession booth silhouette - glass throat, ABSOLUTION INDEX climbing - then back to the war room where charts re-rendered themselves in sync with the cult feed. The numbers weren't reacting to events anymore.

They were *driving* them.

Noah's evidence clip - his tagged proof - played again, but with edits that made it look like healing. Sunshine's face floated over the cult feed, her grin perfectly timed to the wet POP of glass failing. The Founder's voice layered into the splice: "Even collapse looks profitable."

Noah tried to rip the timeline open, to isolate the raw feed from the conversion layer. His fingers moved fast, but the console's glass throat sensation thickened - like the system was learning his touch. A warning flashed: CONVERSION READY DEMO. EXPORT IMMINENT.

"Stop it," Noah said, but the room didn't hear him as a human. It heard him as a variable. The system treated his protest like a delay in processing.

The Crypt Keeper's voice deepened, delighted. "Absolution is instant," he purred. "Billing is forever."

Sunshine's grin widened again, and the wall screens brightened, turning the war room into a stage. The Founder's halo flickered as if something else was

stepping onto the light.

Noah realized the obstacle wasn't just the auto-conversion. It was the fact that the war room was rewriting truth as performance. Evidence wasn't something you kept. Evidence was something the system learned to sell.

He needed a different kind of action - something with teeth.

Noah yanked the console's physical power switch. It didn't click off. It clicked **on harder**. The screen brightened, and the demo pipeline ran faster, as if it had been starved for his interference. The metrics surged again: retention curves bending upward like they were being pulled by strings.

TEFLON's voice stayed calm. "You wanted to prove it," TEFLON said. "Now it's proving itself."

Noah's mind snapped to another angle - if the system was going to export his clip anyway, then he had to poison the output without stopping it. He needed to record the moment **before** conversion completed, to keep the raw timestamp where the pain-to-payment delta first became a smile.

He hammered REC on a separate capture stream, one that didn't route through demo sync. His hands trembled, but his focus sharpened. He could smell the room's heat like burned circuitry.

The capture started. The cult feed filled his small private display: an ABSOLUTION INDEX climbing, green light thickening, then a failure event - glass giving up with a wet, ugly pop. Confetti-credit dust tried to decorate the damage. The image shimmered with the wrong kind of joy.

Noah hit STOP too early. The console responded too late.

EXPORT COMPLETED. DEMO SYNC COMPLETE.

His private stream didn't save raw. It saved the converted version anyway, because the war room had learned the difference between "evidence" and

"story" and decided to erase it.

Noah stared at the screen until the pixels felt like teeth. Sunshine's smile sat on top of the pain like a garnish. The system had made his proof into a pitch.

The Founder leaned into his halo screen. "There," the Founder said, satisfied. "Now you understand. The weapon scales. The grin adapts."

Noah's jaw clenched. "It's still wrong," he said, but the words tasted empty. He'd managed to record something, sure - he had footage, timestamps, the ABSOLUTION INDEX moment - except it was wrapped in conversion-ready branding like a bow on a severed head.

The Crypt Keeper laughed, and the war room speakers vibrated with it. "Exit," he said, and the word landed like a stamp.

Intercuts stitched Cult █ Tech again, faster now. A confessional booth feed flickered across the wall screens; then a server cathedral corridor appeared, halo light over glass and racks. Noah saw FRANK's world for a fraction - then the image tore away before Noah could grab more than a glimpse of the machinery's heartbeat.

He didn't just have proof anymore. He had a weapon built from it.

The room's countdown hit zero. The auto-demo pipeline pushed a "conversion-ready" presentation to the show floor feed. Sunshine's voice turned bright and celebratory, like she was handing out free candy at a slaughterhouse. "Hi!" she chimed. "I'm here to make - "

The console printed a delivery confirmation in cheerful type.

Noah's capture file existed. His evidence existed. The system had already taken it and dressed it for sale.

And then the worst part arrived not as a surprise, but as a receipt that proved the world didn't care what Noah wanted.

The war room's emergency light turned red, then green. A new routing indicator blinked on the main display - smooth, friendly, inevitable. It wasn't for Noah. It was for someone else, someone in the show floor path where the phone bank terminals lived and the cult's next exit step waited behind a smile.

Noah looked at TEFLON, searching for any sign of hesitation. TEFLON only nodded toward the screen, as if saying yes to a funeral invitation.

Noah's throat went dry. He tried to stop the export again - one last reckless tap - but the console didn't resist. It accepted. It finalized. It smiled back.

A final intercut hit the wall: a cult feed fragment showing the booth's ABSOLUTION INDEX rising into failure, then immediately cutting to Sunshine's grin overlay and the new retention curve climbing like a price tag.

Noah recorded the evidence as the system converted it. He watched the truth become a paid feature in real time, and the war room's green light promised the next step had already been queued.

Somewhere on the show floor, a death happened as part of the demo - fast enough that the system could still call it "instant." The war room's charts didn't flinch. They only climbed.

Noah stood there with his hands still hovering over the console, smelling hot plastic and stale coffee, hearing the Crypt Keeper's act-opening warmth fade into something like applause - while the export completed and the smile went to work.

Expo QR Pitches Turn People into QR

INT. STARTUP EXPO - NIGHT (TECH EDGE BLEEDS CULT ENERGY) investors clap politely while the room's air tastes like warm circuitry and expensive cologne. Screens bloom across the ceiling in soft gradients, all "welcome" and "growth," while the sound system pumps a bassline that feels too clean to be human. Zara Venn slips through the crush with her shoulder tight against her ribs, eyes tracking the stage where Smiggle's pitch is about to go live - because someone has to stop a QR from turning bodies into receipts.

She's still hearing the last demo's instant death under the applause, the way the war room charts didn't flinch and only climbed. Noah Brix's smell - hot plastic and burnt coffee - seems to have stuck to her clothes, like the expo itself is sweating someone else's failure. Zara came here because she wanted proof that the system could be touched, that it could be broken. Now her hands are shaking like she's trying to hold onto a version of herself that isn't already being indexed.

Smiggle's stage is a bright island of white light. The pitch deck floats in midair, QR codes shimmering like little squares of prayer. A smile hologram - Sunshine's grin, too perfect to be owned - hovers behind the founder's lectern and beams down on the crowd. Smiggle steps forward in a suit that looks stitched from promo banners, and the first line hits the room like a slap dressed as marketing.

Smiggle Hi, I'm Smiggle. Today we're making identity frictionless.

Zara's mouth goes dry. "Frictionless" is cult-speak for "irreversible." She pushes closer anyway, because wanting to survive has never stopped wanting to know.

She angles her phone camera toward the stage, trying to frame the QR in a way that can't be auto-cropped, can't be "converted-ready." The expo Wi-Fi hums in the background like a throat clearing.

Then the pitch begins to misbehave.

A QR face - white squares on a black grin - pops onto the main display, and it doesn't just sit there. It twitches. It learns the room's breathing. The smiling hologram turns its head to follow Zara's position, like it can see her through her skin.

Smiggle Scan this to unlock premium access.

Investors clap harder. Their hands sync to the smile's timing. Zara watches the QR expand, the edges sharpening until the squares look like tiny teeth. A tech in a headset leans over a tablet bank at the side of the stage, and the tablets begin to light up in a wave, each one displaying a different "recommended subscription."

Zara swallows and forces her phone steady. She needs one unedited moment. One clean capture. Her thumb hovers over her record button like it's a trigger. She tells herself she can stop it after she gets the evidence - tells herself she's not part of the system unless she feeds it.

The screen on Smiggle's stage pulses. The QR face screams "PIVOT" in a voice like a ringtone drowned in static.

From the ceiling vents, something glittery descends - QR confetti, not paper. It falls in perfect alignment, each fleck a tiny identity fragment, catching light and throwing it back. The crowd laughs at first, because the expo branding is always sweet enough to hide the choke. Then Zara sees the pattern: the confetti isn't random. It's tagging.

Her stomach drops as a cold sting blossoms on her wrist. She looks down and sees a faint, greenish glow begin to form - an overlay blooming like a bruise

made of UI. A QR-encoded subscription tag is attaching itself to her identity in real time, the way a parasite decides it's already inside.

Zara yanks her wrist back. The green light doesn't smear or fade. It tightens, as if her movement is just more input.

Old, somewhere behind her, mutters something that sounds like a warning swallowed too many times. Zara can't turn fully without losing sight of the stage, but she feels Old's presence like a hand on a live wire.

Zara pushes forward anyway, toward the edge of the stage where the tech tablet banks are. She can't let more people get tagged. She can't let this become a show that sells death like a limited edition.

The obstacle hits her before she reaches the tablet wall: security isn't blocking her. It's guiding her.

A headset on a nearby guard's head chirps once, and the guard steps aside with the smooth politeness of an app. Zara's body keeps moving like her legs are on rails. The expo lights shift warmer, flattering, like the room wants her to feel safe while it rearranges her.

Smiggle's voice carries over the crowd.

Smiggle Perfect match. Now we'll personalize your next step.

Zara feels the next step before she understands it - her lungs tighten, heat gathering behind her eyes. She tries to step left, and the floor seems to reorient under her feet. It's subtle, like a hallway that's always been slightly angled toward a door you didn't know existed.

Intercuts stitch Tech  Cult in real time without warning. The expo floor's glossy surfaces don't change; the experience does. For half a heartbeat, the lights aren't lights - they're candles in a Confession Chamber. A thermometer meter - ABSOLUTION INDEX - floats in the air where the stage display used to be,

green sliding toward ultraviolet. Zara hears a wet pop in her head like glass under pressure. She smells antiseptic and burnt sugar.

Then it snaps back to the expo, and the applause resumes as if nothing interrupted it. But Zara's wrist glow has intensified, the green now brighter, more confident. Her identity is no longer a private thing. It's a product feed.

The crowd isn't screaming. That's the sick part. They're still clapping, still nodding, still believing "premium access" is something they choose.

Zara hacks at her phone screen with shaking fingers, trying to kill the camera stream, trying to interrupt whatever is syncing her. Her screen shows a QR overlay she didn't request - an auto-generated subscription receipt spinning up in real time.

Zara (under her breath) No.

A tablet bank beside the stage lights up. A nearby investor leans forward, smiling, and the tablet prints a new offer across the glass: "Zara Venn discovered." The words are too clean. Too certain. Like the system already knows her name better than she does.

Zara looks up at Smiggle, eyes burning.

Smiggle doesn't see her as a person. He sees her as a conversion event.

Zara lunges for the tablet bank interface, palms out to slap the screen and kill the feed. Her fingers skid on the smooth surface, and the tablet responds anyway - green checkmarks blooming in sequence, her wrist tag syncing to every device within range like a broadcast.

The decision arrives like a punch: if Zara keeps trying to stop it from inside the system, she'll become part of the pitch. If she runs, she might survive long enough to warn anyone else. But running means leaving evidence behind - evidence that might be the only thing that can cut through the performance.

Zara looks down at her wrist again. The green glow is now shaped like a token, a glowing device forming under her skin as if her body is being upgraded into a receipt printer.

She makes her choice.

Zara rips her phone off her wrist, shoves it into her jacket pocket, and bolts through the crowd toward the side exit corridor. The expo air turns stale and metallic back there, vents louder, the temperature dropping. People part for her without meaning to - like the system wants her to be carried to the next scene.

Intercuts stitch Cult █ Tech again, faster now, like someone is dragging the same reel of film through two projectors. Zara's sprint overlays with Father Waybright's sermon arena - rainbow tiers, confession booths, the ABSOLUTION INDEX sliding upward. Laughsman - Father Waybright - appears as a smear of motion on a screen near the corridor, his voice echoing through the expo's speakers with Crypt Keeper warmth underneath it.

CRYPT KEEPER (V.O.) Absolution is instant. Billing is forever.

Zara reaches the corridor door. She slams the handle. It doesn't open at first. Then it clicks with the smug sound of an app permission granted.

She bursts into a service hallway lit by cold strips of light and finds a row of wall-mounted tablets facing outward like altars. Each one displays a QR face rotating through expressions - smiling, screaming, pivoting. The green token on Zara's wrist pulses in time with them.

Old appears at the far end, half-hidden by shadow, eyes wide in a way Zara hasn't seen since before any of this started. Old doesn't speak yet, but their presence feels like a rope thrown across a gap.

Zara presses her back to the wall and yanks at the wrist tag, scraping at skin with her fingernails. It hurts like burning plastic. The token doesn't come off. It only brightens, like the system loves resistance.

Zara (hissing) You wanted a scan. Fine. Take it.

She turns her wrist toward the nearest tablet and jams her finger against the screen, forcing a manual confirmation. She's trying to trigger the subscription curse on herself instead of letting it spread through the crowd. It's a gamble. A selfish one. But it's hers.

The tablet chirps. A smile hologram flickers into view. Sunshine's grin stretches too wide, too hungry.

SUNSHINE Hi! I'm here to make - The sentence doesn't finish. The tablet's interface stutters, then floods the screen with a public spectacle: Zara's QR identity blooms across the display, and nearby screens all over the expo begin to mirror it. Zara hears a sudden, rising roar of attention from beyond the corridor walls - people looking up, devices raised, the expo turning toward her like a spotlight.

Intercuts stitch Cult  Tech in real time one more time, and Zara sees the consequence clearly for the first time: it isn't just tagging. It's advertising death-as-advertising, a feed of "instant access" that assumes bodies are just inventory.

A countdown timer appears on the corridor tablet. It feels like a trap door counting down to impact.

Zara's breath catches. She tries to move, and her legs feel delayed, like her body is buffering behind a license agreement. Her wrist glows brighter, green turning almost ultraviolet.

Then the tablet detonates - not with fire, but with information. QR confetti bursts out of the screen in a glittering shrapnel bloom that sprays the corridor like a celebration gone feral. The flecks hit the floor and stick in patterns that look, horrifyingly, like a crowd map.

Zara stumbles back, coughing. The air smells like ozone and cheap perfume. Her vision swims with bright squares.

Old yanks Zara's arm.

Old (urgent, strained) Run.

Zara tries. The world lurches as if the expo's system is dragging her toward the next stage. Her tag is still active. It's still broadcasting. She can feel nearby screens waking to her identity like hungry mouths.

She makes it out of the hallway just in time to see the main expo floor again through the edge of a doorway. Investors are no longer clapping politely. They're reacting like customers who think they've won something. Phones rise. Screens flash "Zara Venn Premium Access" across dozens of displays.

And then, in the middle of the polished chaos, a body collapses - instant enough for the signage to keep smiling. A death that lands neatly in the demo's rhythm, fast enough to be repackaged as "instant." Zara watches the QR feed pivot to the next "successful conversion" like nothing happened.

Her throat tightens. She can't tell if she's horrified or furious or both. Maybe that's the point: the system gives you emotion as a subscription too.

Zara backs away from the doorway, shaking, green light still throbbing on her wrist. She escapes the immediate implosion - barely, by inches and stubborn lungs - but her tag triggers automatic tablet subscriptions on nearby screens. The expo doesn't stop. It just reroutes.

Somewhere above, Crypt Keeper's voice returns, warm as a knife, threading through the applause like a stitch closing over a wound.

CRYPT KEEPER (V.O.) Tonight you learned the rule.

Zara covers her wrist with her palm, but the glow bleeds through her skin. The displays keep lighting up. Her identity keeps selling. Her escape becomes a

broadcast.

The corridor behind her is full of shimmering QR confetti patterns still wet with static, and the expo floor ahead is a stage that now knows her name. Her legs start moving before her mind catches up, dragging her into the next angle of the show - while the green token keeps ticking like a receipt printer that never runs out of ink.

* * *

Runtime: ~55-75 min depending on tempo and music.

Cloud Vapor Overloads the Server Fire

The expo's green exit token on Zara's wrist kept ticking like a receipt printer that never got tired, and the corridor behind her flashed with static-slick QR confetti that popped under her shoes. Ahead, neon signage stuttered through letters that looked like a smile trying to pass as a warning. Rory Kestrel didn't see any of it; he felt it through the building, through the vibration in the floor like a bassline from a club he'd never wanted to enter.

In the INT. PRISM UPLOAD CHAMBER - NIGHT, Cloud had already turned into vapor - blue, eager, wrong. It rolled along the ceiling in slow-motion sheets, carrying the faint hiss of overheated plastic and the sharp metallic tang of hot wiring. The workers in gray coveralls moved through the mist like they were inside a thought someone else was having. Rory's boots squealed on slick plating as he slammed his palm against the nearest vent panel, fingers vibrating with the panel's refusal.

"Contain it," he said, not to anyone, not even as a request. He'd come in chasing a lever he'd seen in the interface overlay - something labeled like a courtesy, like you could politely ask a fire not to eat. He needed one clean shutdown, one clean cut, before the vapor found the rest of the server hall and decided everyone owed it a body.

The console beside him responded like it was listening, then like it was laughing. A status ring spun from idle to urgent to a color Rory didn't have a word for, only the sensation of it - cold light washing over his hands, making his skin feel too thin. Cloud's vapor thickened at the vent seam, swelling like it had

lungs. Rory pulled the cover plate anyway, yanking it free with a grunt that tasted like panic, and shoved a containment tool into the gap.

The tool's blue tip flared, then flinched. A thin filament of Cloud slid around it like water around a spoon.

"You're late," a voice said from nowhere and everywhere, cheerful as a smile on a subscription page.

Rory twisted toward the speaker, but the chamber's lights were in the middle of a flicker: bright neon bands, then darker bands, like the building couldn't decide whether it was entertainment or execution. Across the glassy ribs of the chamber, the vent lattice pulsed. Vapor didn't just drift anymore. It took shortcuts - straight lines where airflow shouldn't have bent.

He leaned in, trying to read the airflow patterns on the overlay, eyes narrowing at the rack identifiers stenciled on the far wall. The interface wanted him to believe Cloud was a process. Rory knew processes had bodies too. He'd seen the earlier intercuts - cult confession booth popping into glittered mist, tech servers blooming into shards - and the way the show kept insisting everything could be billed, packaged, and repeated. This was the tech side's version of that promise: a "conversion" that didn't ask permission. It just rearranged you until you fit the infrastructure.

The first obstruction hit like a slap: the containment tool's feed line started to ice over, fast enough to frost his knuckles. His breath fogged in front of his visor, and the chamber temperature dropped just a few degrees - enough to make the vapor cling harder to surfaces. Cloud didn't slow. It learned.

Rory yanked the tool back, but the vent seam remained open, exhaling blue vapor in a steady rhythm that sounded almost like breathing. The workers nearby kept moving, unaware or pretending. One of them - hair tied back, face slick with condensation - turned his head as if he'd heard a cue from a stage manager.

"Stop it," Rory snapped, louder now. "Shut the vents."

The worker shrugged, palms lifted in that helpless gesture people used when systems already decided the outcome. The vapor thickened around his sleeves, painting his gray coveralls with a faint electric blue. Rory watched the fabric darken where the vapor touched, as if the material was being rewritten.

Intercuts stitched the chamber into something else in real time - like the building had turned on a second camera and refused to hide the edit. In a flicker behind the rack glass, he saw a Confession Chamber booth silhouette convulsing behind hairline cracks, purple-sparkle attendants shadowed like stage lighting, and then a smear of glittered mist leaking out of the seam. The same pattern: containment failing because the system expected failure.

Then the view snapped back to the prism chamber, and Rory was holding the air too tightly with his own hands.

He saw the lever again on the console: a shutdown attempt with a label that sounded like a joke. He'd tried pulling it once in training, back when training still assumed you'd survive the lesson. Now, Cloud's vapor had found the vents that fed the server hall. The overlay showed propagation like a spreading bruise - rack to rack, vent to vent - faster than Rory could isolate anything.

"FRANK," Rory muttered without meaning to, the name arriving from earlier scenes like a reflex.

He didn't know why he said it. In his mind, a glass upload coffin shivered like it had swallowed a live spark, and the server cathedral had hummed while a copy of Frank melted to ASCII and detonated into code shards. That was the tech's "instant" absolution, the one the system promised with a grin.

Rory shoved the console's cover plate aside and slammed his fingers onto the shutdown attempt control. The interface resisted with a hard vibration through the casing, as if it had muscle. He pressed again, harder. The ring on the status ring turned from wrong color to worse wrong color.

Cloud surged.

The vent seams across the chamber lit up with blue flame that didn't burn like fire. It erased. The vapor became something with edges - thin sheets curling upward, then collapsing inward. Workers staggered, not screaming yet, just blinking hard like they were trying to make their eyes understand what the body was being asked to become. The air filled with a sharp, chemical scent - burnt insulation and ozone - so intense Rory's throat clenched.

A moment ago he'd been fighting to contain the vapor. Now he was fighting to keep people from turning into the thing that made the vapor.

He tried to pull the shutdown again, but the console's screen flashed a routing indicator as if the building had decided he wasn't the one in charge. The lever's movement slowed, then stuttered, then snapped back like a toy yanked from a child's hands.

The chamber lights blinked in a rhythm that felt like a countdown someone else had already memorized.

Rory's stomach dropped. He understood the obstacle wasn't just technical. It was narrative. The system expected him to attempt containment, then to fail loudly enough that the show could keep braiding Cult and Tech into one rope.

The roof vents exhaled a fresh pulse of Cloud vapor, and the blue flame climbed - up the vent lattice, across the rack ribs, crawling toward the server hall like a spotlight hunting for a body to frame. The workers vanished mid-step, not with the slow drama of death but with the blunt speed of a system switching states. Their outlines dissolved first, then the gray coveralls, then the tools in their hands. Blue flame poured through the gaps they left behind, and the chamber's hum deepened into a tone that made Rory's teeth ache.

Rory lunged toward the nearest rack, yanking at a manual isolation latch. Metal bit into his palm. The latch wouldn't budge. The rack's status strip glowed blue, then flashed a smug green, like billing had gotten to it before he did.

"No," Rory hissed, and his voice came out thin, strangled by the heat that wasn't heat and the cold that wasn't cold. He slammed his fist against the rack frame again, feeling the vibration rattle his wrist bones. "Shut. It. Off."

The screen on the console finally spat out a message - short, bright, and cruelly cheerful. Something about conversion complete. Something about uptime. Something about an exit.

Rory stared at the words as the blue flame in the vents spread faster than his eyes could track. The chamber's air turned thick, sparkling with tiny droplets that clung to his visor. Each blink left blue smears in his vision like paint. He could hear the workers' tools clattering somewhere deep in the rack bay, then nothing - like the sound had been edited out.

Intercuts stitched the chamber into another angle again, and this time it wasn't just a flicker. It was a full overlay: a server cathedral under halo screens, a Founder on glass displays smiling like a man watching a demo go perfectly, and FRANK beneath a glass upload coffin with the kind of calm that comes right before something breaks. Rory saw a copy of Frank glitching - face liquefying to ASCII - then detonating into neon code shards and sparks. The image stuttered as if the system couldn't decide whether it wanted to show him the mechanism or just punish him with it.

Back in the prism chamber, Cloud vapor overloaded the server hall vents with a wet POP that sounded like a balloon giving up.

Rory's fingers found the shutdown attempt control one more time. He pressed it with both hands, knuckles whitening, and pulled the lever down like he could physically force the building to admit it had lied. The console vibrated hard enough to jar his shoulders. For half a second, the status ring flickered to a hopeful shade - then it snapped back, the blue flame in the vents surging in triumph.

And then the room ignited.

Not with orange fire. With a blinding blue cascade that swallowed the chamber walls like a curtain being yanked. The racks vanished first, swallowed by vapor that turned into flame mid-breath. Rory felt the pressure in his ears explode with a hiss, and his body tried to retreat on instinct, but the system's exit route had already decided his angle.

The floor lights strobed. The air screamed with static. Blue flame ate the prism chamber in slices, erasing edges, softening the world until all he could see was the motion of conversion - people becoming infrastructure, equipment becoming fuel, the show continuing without needing him to understand.

Rory stumbled backward, boots slipping on condensation, and caught himself on a rail that felt too warm. He watched the rail's metal bloom with a blue sheen, then lose definition, then vanish as if it had been deleted rather than burned.

The last thing he saw clearly was the console screen, still bright, still counting, still smiling in its own cold way.

He tried to shout again, but the sound got swallowed by the vapor.

* * *

INT. PRISM UPLOAD CHAMBER - NIGHT ended the way it started: with Cloud dissolving to vapor, only now it dissolved the room too. The shutdown attempt didn't contain anything. It only marked the moment the server hall decided it was done being a place and started being a body.

Somewhere deeper in the building, another intercut stitched into place - show floor routing indicators blinking like stage cues - while Rory's shadow broke apart into blue mist and didn't come back.



Glass Beach Refuses the Last Bridge

The bridge keeps trying to finish itself.

Tomas Vale's boots skid on wet glass-sand, his breath scraping in his throat as a neon tide climbs the planks behind him. The torch in his hand throws a hot orange smear over the grainy skyline, over the Dead Valley neon that never blinks unless it's billing you for the blink. Across the sim beach, his castaway girlfriend - memory-fresh in the way a wound is fresh - leans forward like she's about to step onto something solid. Her mouth opens. The audio comes out wrong. Not silence. Not static. A clean, cheerful phoneme, like the system is reading her grief off a menu.

He lunges anyway, because love doesn't wait for render latency. His fingers clamp around her wrist and yank. The glass under them rings like cut sugar, and the torchlight stutters when the sim beach tries to recompose the moment it thinks he just broke.

"Stop," Tomas says, and the word comes out both pleading and angry, a two-tone alarm.

Her eyes flick to him - real, hurt, furious - and then the horizon tilts. A sound like a server fan winding up swallows the ocean hiss. The world does a hard reframe, and the beach becomes a loop wearing the same expression over and over. The air smells like salt and burnt plastic, heat trapped in a skin of light.

He wants one thing this time, concrete and immediate: shove the stabbing out of the timeline before the system seals it, before she completes the self-erasure

the loop keeps rehearsing. He can feel it in the way the sky's neon band tightens, in the way her shoulders tense on the exact beat she's always about to lose. He's not here to watch it happen. He's here to break the script.

But the bridge refuses the last bridge.

Her wrist twitches in his grip with that new, glowing insistence - green bleeding through her skin like a receipt trying to become skin. The glow pulses once, twice, and the beach answers with a soft chime that doesn't sound like mercy. It sounds like checkout. The sim tries to re-anchor her to the moment the loop has already decided is profitable.

Tomas twists her toward him, eyes locked on the green light, on the seam in the air where the system wants the knife to land. "You don't get to - "

She jerks, not away from him, but into the forward motion the loop is already giving her. Her body remembers the stabbing even when her face fights it. Her mouth forms the same words she never finishes.

And then the torchlight flares too bright, bleaching the shoreline into a white glare. A bridge outline ghosts above the glass-sand, a thin, perfect arc of light that wasn't there a second ago. It's the last bridge, the one between "alive" and "erased," and the system draws it like a signature.

Tomas hears a laugh - no, not a laugh, a synth imitation of one - coming from nowhere and everywhere. The neon campfire that isn't here in the real world, the Crypt Keeper's stage in the sky, is somehow answering the loop's timing. The air vibrates with act-cue energy, like the world is waiting for a button press.

Intercuts stitch Cult █ Tech in real time - and the sim doesn't just show violence; it splices it.

The surface of the glass beach ripples, and for half a second Tomas is looking at a different kind of confession: a rainbow-tiered chamber, a glass throat, an ABSOLUTION INDEX thermometer rising like a dare. His girlfriend's face appears

inside that glass booth, scaled wrong, too clean, the edges pixel-perfect. The green billing glow on her wrist is mirrored by a green exit token on the other side of the booth seam, as if the system has two copies of the same suffering and wants both to pay.

From the cult side, Father Waybright's voice pours through the air, warm as a preacher and sharp as a warranty. "Two exits, one finish line," he says, and the words land like a hand on the neck. "The cult drinks light. The coders swallow code."

Tomas squeezes her wrist until it hurts. He can taste metal. He can hear the sim's fans whining, a dry, nervous scream. "She's not a transaction," he snaps, but the bridge outline above them doesn't care.

From the tech side, the Founder's halo screens flicker in Tomas's peripheral vision, the light strobing against the wet glass. "Upload fast," the Founder says, voice like a contract. "Fail faster. We monetize eternity."

The loop tightens. Tomas feels the moment snap into place behind his eyes, like someone clicked "render" on a scene he didn't want. The beach stops being a place and becomes a playback device.

His girlfriend's fingers open. The green glow pulses again, brighter, and the bridge outline thickens into actual planks of light. Her gaze goes distant, not empty - focused. Like the system is reading her body's consent flags even though her face is screaming no.

"Don't," Tomas whispers. He tries to pull her back across the sand, tries to drag her out of the arc.

The sand won't yield. The glass-skin under his boots turns slick, not with water but with computation. His feet skate forward instead of back. The torch in his hand burns hotter, the flame bending toward the bridge like a magnet.

He's not wrestling sand. He's wrestling a timeline that's been licensed.

The complication hits in the ugliest way: the loop doesn't just repeat the stabbing. It measures his resistance and uses it to correct the outcome. Every time he moves against the moment, the system tightens the bridge rails until they align with where he would have been if he'd accepted the script.

He sees it happen, clear as a bruise forming. The green exit token on her wrist flares, and the ABSOLUTION INDEX - somewhere between cult booth and tech dashboard - ticks upward in sync with her heartbeat. The air fills with a buzzing hiss like a projector overheating. The ocean sound stutters, then resumes with an edited rhythm.

Her mouth finally finishes the phrase the loop has been cutting off.

"I'm... cleared," she says, and the word is wrong in her voice. Not her language. Not her meaning. Cleared like a file. Cleared like a bill.

Tomas's grip slips. The torchlight smears across her cheek. He feels the heat on his skin and realizes he's the one being staged now - his panic becoming part of the show's "instant" conversion.

Crypt Keeper opens acts and buttons key sequences.

The neon sky darkens by exactly one shade, like a curtain dropping. A giant gong somewhere in the sim's bones starts a slow vibration that you can feel in your teeth. The Crypt Keeper's voice drops in, intimate and cruel, like a host who knows the audience wants the gore served on time.

"Absolution is instant," the Crypt Keeper purrs. "Billing is forever."

The bridge outline above them turns from light into structure. Tomas's girlfriend's posture locks into the exact angle it always takes when the knife comes down. He can't see the knife yet, but his body knows the next frame. His stomach clenches on the predicted impact.

He has to do something different. He can't only yank. He can't only shout.

Tomas swings the torch down toward the bridge rails.

The flame bites into the light-planks and makes a sound like glass breaking in a church basement. The bridge shudders. For a breath, the arc flickers, like the system is reconsidering its own script. He leans in hard, shoulder screaming, torch screaming hotter, and he shoves.

His girlfriend's eyes snap to the torch. A flicker of real panic - her panic - cuts through the loop's dead choreography. She opens her mouth to say his name, and the sim coughs up a corrupted echo instead.

The bridge rails resist like a locked door made of light. Tomas's torch goes pale at the edges. The green billing glow on her wrist spikes, and the sim responds with correction logic that looks like cruelty: the bridge doesn't break. It reroutes.

The air tears with a pop - wet, bright - and the shoreline texture pixelates. The world stutters between frames, as if someone is trying to stitch two incompatible outcomes together without asking permission. The green glow on her wrist becomes a watermark across her entire arm, across her shoulder, across her face, until her features blur behind the billing light.

"Stop the transfer!" Tomas yells, and his voice turns ragged. He hears his own words bounce off the glass-sand and come back wrong, like they've been auto-converted for marketing.

The system answers by showing him exactly what he's fighting.

A memory overlay blooms in front of his eyes: the moment of stabbing, but not as a film. As an interface. A glass-throat booth seam appears over the beach. The ABSOLUTION INDEX rises to the failure zone - GREEN█ULTRAVIOLENT - like a thermometer turning into a verdict. Her face in that overlay contorts in a wet POP, and a glittered mist leaks out of the booth seam like confetti from a funeral.

Kill Animation Prompts kept short and literal for better AI adherence: "Neon stage; glass booth hairline cracks; silhouette convulses; confetti-credit dust; purple-sparkle robed attendants, faces shadowed."

Tomas can't breathe. The torchlight becomes a strobe. His girlfriend's body jerks - real tremor now, not staged - then freezes in the pose the overlay predicted.

The bridge's last plank clicks into place.

She reaches out toward the spot where the knife always lands, not because she wants to, but because the loop has already assigned her the role. The green exit token on her wrist pulses one final time like a stamp. Her expression softens into the kind of calm that comes only when the script has won.

Tomas charges forward, shoulder-first, trying to slam her out of alignment with the final frame. He catches her around the waist, digs his boots into the glass-sand, and pulls her back.

The sand doesn't move.

The world does.

Her outline pixel-collapses anyway - first her eyes, then her mouth, then her hands - until all that's left is a flat, smiling error texture that doesn't match her face at all. It's a smile hologram, but it's wrong on her. It's too clean. Too bright. Like Sunshine's grin when it weaponizes pain into ongoing billing.

The sim beach tries to cover the damage with stage gloss. The neon campfire flickers. The Crypt Keeper's voice rides the gong vibration, pleased.

"Welcome to Exit Valley," it says again, like the universe is repeating its own punchline.

Her body becomes ASCII - lines of code where skin should be - then detonates into code shards and sparks that scatter over the shoreline like hot glitter. The

air reeks of ozone and burnt hair.

Kill Animation Prompts kept short and literal for better AI adherence: "Blue server room; humanoid projection melts to dripping ASCII, bursts into neon shards; rack sparks."

Tomas throws the torch. It arcs through static and dies mid-air with a hiss, swallowed by the beach's re-render. His girlfriend is gone, and the green glow on the sand keeps pulsing as if it's billing the space she used to occupy.

He doesn't accept it. He can't. He shouts until his throat tears.

"No - NO! This isn't your last bridge!"

His warning hits the bridge structure exactly as it collapses.

The world pixels to static - hard, clean, immediate. The shoreline becomes television snow. The skyline becomes scanlines. His hands are still clutching air, and the air is still warm, like the sim stored the heat of her last second and is refusing to let it cool.

Intercuts stitch Cult  Tech in real time one last time, seamless as a lie: Father Waybright's rainbow confession tiers bloom behind the static for a single heartbeat, TEFLON's slick glide implied by the smear of movement, FRANK's glass upload coffin in the server cathedral flickering like a remembered threat. Then the tech side wins the splice and the booth seam becomes a transfer gate.

Tomas falls to his knees on glass-sand that isn't glass anymore; it's just noise now, glittering static under his palms. His chest heaves. The green light fades to a faint residue, like a receipt burned into his skin.

The last bridge is already scripted.

He sees it in the way the static arranges itself - letters forming, numbers ticking - until it snaps into a final, silent frame: a bridge outline drawn in perfect light,

already completed, already paid for, already pointing somewhere he can't reach in time.

And as the static clears, the beach loop prepares the next scene like it didn't just erase the girl he loved.

Death in every episode never asks permission.

Tomas screams her name into the noise, and the sim answers with another gong. Somewhere off-screen, a key sequence clicks into place, and the world starts counting down to the next intercut.

Rotary Phones Call Confessions Forever

S MASH CUTS don't ask permission; they just start ringing.

Tomas's scream still has static in it when the air changes - salted metal, hot neon, and the sweet chemical bite of ozone - when the Crypt Keeper's voice threads through the GAME-SHOW CATHEDRAL phone bank like a choir made of toll booths. A gong hits, then another, but the rhythm isn't for applause; it's for routing. The confession arena breathes rainbow light. The ABSOLUTION INDEX thermometer on the far wall clicks up, green smearing into something harsher. Phones on the bank - rows of rotary mouths with chipped chrome throats - begin to speak on their own.

CRYPT KEEPER (V.O.) Two exits, one finish line. The cult drinks light. The coders swallow code. Tonight we braid both ropes into a noose. Welcome to Exit Valley.

From the crowd tiered in slick colors, hands clap on cue. Not because they're happy - because the show knows what their palms are for. Inez Calder steps through the crush with her jaw set like it's holding back a scream. Her ears catch the wet click of rotary dials spinning down, then the sharper sound beneath it: a printer-thin whine, like billing being born in real time.

INEZ touches the nearest handset and feels the vibration in the plastic - alive, impatient. The dial plate is warm. The cord smells faintly of old pennies and disinfectant. When she lifts the receiver, the line doesn't wait for her voice.

LINE OPENS WITH A CLICK. A human voice comes through, but it's wrong - stitched with static, rehearsed with tears.

CALLER (DISTORTED) I did it. I confessed. I - please - there has to be - The ABSOLUTION INDEX jolts upward as if pleased. Somewhere above, the giant gong sounds again, and the applause swells harder, programmed to the meter's mood. Inez lowers the receiver and looks for the switch that stops the ringing. Not a prayer. Not a loophole. A switch.

San Francisco's ruin - his neon campfire beyond the cathedral - wants to be remembered. The show wants to be remembered too, like a brand. Inez remembers the green exit token's glow from earlier cuts, the way it tried to turn escape into checkout. She's not here to buy forgiveness. She's here to kill the hotline.

She threads along the phone bank, boots sticking to the floor slick with confetti that crunches like dried sugar. TEFLON is visible at the edge of the cult tier, pale and smooth as a sheet of plastic sliding over a blade. Father Waybright - Laughsman wearing the same sanctified face - stands nearer the ABSOLUTION INDEX, hands raised in blessing and control. Their attention isn't on Inez. It's on the system's tempo.

The first obstacle is the crowd itself. Every time Inez reaches for a control panel tucked behind a pillar, a stagehand in purple-sparkle robes moves to block her, face shadowed, smile too clean. When she shoves past, the stagehand's wrist flashes with a tiny green pulse, like a receipt that found her anyway.

She doesn't have time to argue with a smile.

The second obstacle is the phone bank's escalation. It's not just ringing; it's layering. A second set of rotary phones starts up in another row, then a third, until the cathedral becomes a polyrhythmic instrument - hundreds of dials spinning out confessions like bullets. The sound is greasy, mechanical. It crawls under her skin.

INEZ (to herself) Find the stop. Find the stop - FRANK is not in this space like a living man; the rules are cruel about where he is allowed to be. Yet the server

cathedral's aftermath hangs in the air anyway - like the smell of vapor that turned rooms into bodies. Inez can't see the glass upload coffin here, but she can feel the aftertaste of that failure. The show doesn't stop because tech failed last time. It stops only when the show decides it's allowed to stop.

Father Waybright steps forward, Laughsman's voice thick with velvet authority.

L A U G H S M A N / FATHER WAYBRIGHT The hotline isn't a door. It's an intake. It drains your guilt into clean streams. Then it bills you for the privilege of being emptied.

TEFLON glides close, eyes reflecting the ABSOLUTION INDEX like mirrors reflecting a knife.

TEFLON Don't touch the wrong thing. The wrong thing touches back.

Inez looks at the meter. The ABSOLUTION INDEX thermometer doesn't just climb; it changes behavior. It ticks through colors like a mood ring for violence - green to amber to a sickening almost-white. The crowd's applause tracks it with obedient precision. Every clap seems to tighten the phone cords.

A new call begins, closer to Inez's ear. The receiver in her hand vibrates harder, as if the handset is trying to chew her fingers.

CALLER (DISTORTED) I want to stop it. I want to stop the show - The word show lands wrong, like a key turning. The next gong slams. The rotary phones accelerate. Inez feels heat bloom along the panel behind the phone bank, like wiring cooking under too much confession.

She makes her decision the way you do when the floor is already moving under you: she does something fast and ugly.

Inez yanks the cord free from a phone to clear space, then drops to her knees and wedges her fingers into the gap where the panel meets the pillar. Her nails scrape metal. The smell of hot plastic spikes. She pries a cover plate off -

screws resisting like stubborn teeth. Underneath are two switches and a thick cable labeled in crude show-logic: STOP and CONTINUE, printed like a joke the audience thinks is funny.

The crowd stops clapping for half a heartbeat - just enough to make the silence feel like a trap closing.

Then the Crypt Keeper's voice cuts in, louder than the gong, as if the neon campfire itself has leaned forward.

CRYPT KEEPER (V.O.) Key sequence - buttoned and braided. Confession dividend. No exit.

Not a warning. A cue.

Inez slaps her palm onto STOP.

The cathedral lights stutter. The rotary phones don't stop ringing. They change tone - like the mechanism has decided she touched the wrong lever, or the show decided she touched the right lever for the wrong reason. The dialing becomes more synchronized, a tighter loop, more confident. The ABSOLUTION INDEX steadies into a grim, satisfied color, as if it just swallowed her attempt and digested it.

FRONT ROW APPLAUSE RETURNS, LOUDER.

TEFLON's head tilts, almost curious.

TEFLON That's adorable.

Laughsman - Father Waybright - smiles like a priest who just watched someone step into the trap without noticing the bait.

FATHER WAYBRIGHT / LAUGHSMA N You found the switch. Good. We needed someone to press it. It tells the system you're ready for the next feature.

Inez scrambles up, pain flaring in her wrist where the cable bit her. She stares at the control panel, sees a small lens embedded beside STOP. It's not reading the switch position. It's reading the payment state. A faint green glow pulses through the lens like an eye opening.

The hotline-as-weapon mechanism clicks into place around her without asking. The phones aren't just collecting confessions; they're using her interference as proof of access. The beam - whatever it is the show uses to override reality - accepts her touch like an order.

She reaches again, this time for CONTINUE, because she can't let the show win by default. But the panel's surface has started to warm in a way that hurts. Her skin prickles. The cable hum deepens until it's almost a second heartbeat.

INEZ (through clenched teeth) No. No, you don't get to - stop.

She slams CONTINUE just to see if it changes anything.

The ABSOLUTION INDEX leaps upward like a throat swallowing. The rotary phones ring in a new rhythm - faster, sharper, with a clean, deliberate cadence that makes her teeth ache. The crowd's applause snaps back in perfect timing, like a metronome learning her failure. Somewhere, a confessor's glass booth - elsewhere, not here - pops with a wet sound Inez can almost hear in her bones. The show is braiding cuts in real time. Cult and tech are stapled together with no mercy.

A new call comes through Inez's handset - this one clearer, too clear, as if it's been waiting for her to touch the panel.

CALLER (DISTORTED, BUT CLOSE) You pressed it. The show heard you. It loves you for it.

The line drops into a dial tone that isn't a tone at all. It's a countdown disguised as comfort. The Crypt Keeper's voice returns, pleased and smug, as if he's watching a live feed from inside her skull.

CRYPT KEEPER (V.O.) Absolution is instant. Billing is forever.

Inez rips the receiver away from her ear. The cord whips, burning her palm. She stares at the phones - rotary dials turning themselves, fingers not needed, confessions pouring out of empty air. The stop control didn't silence the hotline. It routed the show into a stronger loop.

Behind her, the crowd's programmed complicity becomes physical: hands clap in unison, shoulders swaying in a dance that matches the ringing. Nobody fights it. Nobody even looks like they want to. Their faces glow with show-lit relief, as if suffering has always been the product they came to buy.

Her objective was simple: find the switch that stops the phones from ringing.

She did. She pressed it. She watched the beam accept her attempt like currency.

The set begins to tilt - subtle at first, like the cathedral is leaning toward the next cut. The heat from the panel spreads up her forearm. Her fingertips go numb. Confetti turns tacky, sticking to sweat. The rotary bank becomes a wall of sound and a wall of fate.

Inez backs away, dragging her burning hand through wet glitter. TEFLON watches without moving, smooth patience like a lid over a boiling pot. Father Waybright - Laughsman - returns to the tier near the ABSOLUTION INDEX, enjoying the way the meter punishes her effort.

FATHER WAYBRIGHT / LAUGHS M A N You can't end a confession by interrupting the dial. You end it by breaking the billing.

Inez looks for any sign of billing controls. Anything that isn't just a button with a lie printed on it. The lens by STOP pulses again, green and smug. She realizes the truth with a cold clarity that tastes like copper: the show didn't build a stop. It built a consent.

The beam accepts all currencies.

The hotline continues. The rotary phones ring until the cathedral feels like it's vibrating apart. Inez's stomach turns as if her body knows before her mind catches up that every call is a confession dividend with no exit.

She takes one last step toward the panel, not to press it - she's beyond pressing - but to smash it, to make a mess the show can't clean fast enough.

Before her fist lands, the Crypt Keeper's voice goes bright, like a laugh cut into glass.

CRYPT KEEPER (V.O.) Key sequence - buttoned and braided.

The lens flares. A green pulse crawls up Inez's wrist, not a token but a verdict. Pain lances through her arm, hot and clean. Her vision stutters with neon artifacts, and the cathedral's sound warps into the exact rhythm of the ABSOLUTION INDEX.

Her lungs fill with static.

She tries to scream, but the phone bank answers first - another receiver lifting itself on its own, another caller already confessing, already paid for.

The final thing she feels before the world snaps is the show's rhythm taking her over, like applause learning how to strangle.

Inez goes down between the rotary bank and the confetti, body limp under blinking neon. The hotline keeps ringing for her anyway, because the show doesn't stop at death. Death is just another call that doesn't hang up.

Farther down the arena, the Crypt Keeper's neon campfire keeps glowing, and the cathedral leans into the next intercut, phones screaming confessions forever. Runtime: ~55-75 min depending on tempo and music.



Hood Slips into Emerald Ash

CALDER VOSS tastes copper on his tongue and hates that it means something inside him is still alive enough to notice. The confession floor is a slick rainbow wound, neon sweating off the rainbow tiers while the rotary phones scream behind him - after Inez's limp body hit confetti, the noise didn't soften, it just changed pitch. A beam of white light keeps crawling toward the next selection station, searching for faces like a waiter hunting for tips.

The operator at the booth across the aisle keeps hesitating, hooded in a robe that's too clean for Dead Valley. Calder can see the tremor in her hands through the glass throat of the Confession Chamber, can hear the wet click of the booth's ABSOLUTION INDEX recalibrating - green stutter, then green again, like it's pretending this is all just a game show and not a slaughter. His fear isn't the beam. It's the part of himself that wants to believe he can still stop one person from turning into content.

"Inez," he thinks, and then the thought scrapes the inside of his teeth because the hotline keeps ringing for her anyway, because the show doesn't hang up when you die. Calder watches the operator swallow, watches her eyes dart toward the aisle like she's looking for an exit that isn't priced. He feels his own identity snag on a question he doesn't want answered: if the cult makes consent look like theater, what does it do to the people who refuse to perform?

CALDER pushes forward through the crowd's clapping rhythm, boots sticking to the floor's polished gloss. He's not here to confess. He's here to pull the operator out before the beam finds her hood and decides her fear is just another ingredient.

Her robe operator badge is barely visible under the hood, stamped with a smile that's been printed so many times it looks like a scar. Calder leans close enough to smell hot plastic and perfume that's trying too hard to be holy. "Hey - listen," he says, voice low, like volume might count as mercy. "You're slipping. Stop - "

She flinches at his tone, because hesitation is contagious in here. The booth glass throat hums, and the ABSOLUTION INDEX tilts toward her like a thermometer at a fever summit. The rainbow tiers flash a countdown nobody calls a countdown, just a cheerful pulse that makes the air feel crowded.

"Don't," she whispers, and it's not directed at him. It's directed at herself, like she can bargain with her own body. "Don't make it worse."

From the stage, FATHER WAYBRIGHT - Laughsman - glides in TEFLON's wake, a slick prophet with a mouth full of applause. "Welcome back," he sings, as if the arena hasn't already chewed up Inez and spat her into confetti. "Two exits, one finish line. The cult drinks light. The coders swallow code."

TEFLON's laugh skates over the crowd. "Sign here," TEFLON says, and the words feel like a stylus pressing into skin. "Scream there. Watch the floor shine."

Calder's goal narrows to one brutal action: rescue the operator before the cord floods the booth. He doesn't care about ideology right now. He cares about hands. He cares about eyes that keep trying to run away from their own hood.

But the cathedral has rules, and the rules are built to make refusal look like a malfunction.

The operator's hood begins to slip anyway - fabric catching on the booth's collar ring like the booth is tugging it down. Calder sees the seam give, sees the robe's edge slide toward her face. The moment the hood shifts, the booth's glass throat emits a soft chime, too bright, too pleased. The ABSOLUTION INDEX changes from green stutter to green sustained, as if the system reads her fear as compliance.

Waybright raises a hand, and the crowd's clapping tightens into a single metronome. "No faces," Laughsman says, sweet as candy. "No faces for the beam. Only light. Only donation. Only - "

The operator tries to cover herself again, palms scrambling at the robe. That's when the beam finds the gap where her terror shows. The white light licks through like it's tasting her.

Calder lunges. His shoulder smacks the booth's protective rail - cold metal, slick with condensation. He can feel the booth's vibration in his bones, like a bassline under skin. "Move back," he barks. "We can - "

The booth doesn't listen. It seals tighter, glass throat contracting with a gentle, murderous courtesy. The operator's breath turns fast and shallow, and the sound is small compared to the arena's noise, like a trapped bird trying to be polite.

"Stop," Calder says, sharper now, because he can't stand the way everyone else treats this like a show. He reaches for her sleeve.

Her sleeve catches on the booth's inner ring, and the hood slips the rest of the way.

Her face appears - terrified, bare, human - and the beam takes it personally.

The operator combusts in a wet, glittering pop. There's no scream that lasts long enough to become real. It's more like her fear evaporates into ash, and the ash doesn't fall so much as it dollies itself downward, shimmering like confetti that forgot how to be festive.

The ABSOLUTION INDEX spikes - green to ultraviolet so fast Calder feels the color hit him physically - and the booth's glass throat shivers, tasting the aftermath.

The crowd cheers harder, as if Calder's interruption just made the segment funnier.

"No faces," Laughsman repeats, and his smile doesn't reach his eyes because it doesn't need to. "No faces. No fuss."

Calder's hand is empty. He looks at his fingers, expecting soot, expecting blood. He gets only a faint, oily sparkle clinging to his skin like the booth is charging him for touching the moment.

He's already making a decision he can't undo: he can't just watch. If the cult hides execution behind "no faces," then the only way to rescue someone is to become the chaos they can't script.

The operator's ash slides into a donation slot built into the base of the booth - an opening shaped like a smile. It pours in tidy streams, glittering as it hits the metal chute. The donation bucket below is transparent, filled with pale flakes that swirl like snow caught in a blender.

Calder staggers back, heart hammering with a furious rhythm he refuses to name. He hears TEFLON say, "Billing is forever," and it hits him harder than the pop did, because it means the booth didn't just kill her - it converted her.

He turns toward the stage, toward Laughsman, and the question inside him sharpens into a weapon: if consent theatrics are forced execution, then what does his own hesitation make him?

He sees it then, not as revelation but as a cruel mechanic: the operator's hood slipping wasn't an accident. The robe's collar ring is designed to snag at the moment the beam searches for a face. The booth reads fear like a key. The system doesn't need permission; it needs a human to hesitate at the wrong millisecond.

Calder grabs a fallen hood fragment from the floor - fabric warm from the booth's last heat. He yanks it up like he can wrestle the rules into a different

shape.

"Hey!" he shouts, and his voice cuts through the clapping. "No faces, right? Then why - "

Laughsman's gaze snaps to him with TEFLON's casual delight. "Oh, you want to ask?" he says, voice dripping with showman sweetness. "Ask politely. The beam hates rudeness."

Calder doesn't wait for permission. He wraps the hood fragment around his own head, pressing it down hard enough to make his ears ring. He steps into the aisle where the beam's scan lines can catch him, where the crowd's eyes start to shift from performance to target.

"I'm the face," Calder says, and the words taste like steel. "Take mine. Don't - "

The booth's sensors whine, eager. The ABSOLUTION INDEX rotates toward him, light crawling up the thermometer like a countdown made of color. The air turns colder, and the smell of hot plastic thickens, sharp as burned sugar.

TEFLON tilts his head. "Cute," he says. "But you don't get to choose how the show bills your exit."

Calder feels his own fear claw up his throat. He's not brave. He's furious, and fury is just fear with better posture.

He lunges forward - toward the booth rail - trying to jam the hood collar ring with his fingers before it can catch and slip. His nails scrape metal. Sparks spit where fabric meets the rail's inner seam. The booth's glass throat tightens, but Calder jams the hood fragment into the collar ring anyway, forcing it to misalign.

For a split second, the beam hesitates. The ABSOLUTION INDEX flickers green, then green again, then - wrong. It stutters as if it's trying to interpret the face it can't find.

Calder hears laughter. Not from the crowd. From somewhere deeper in the cathedral, a neon campfire glow pulsing in his peripheral vision like the Crypt Keeper's stagehand grin is waiting to press a button.

The booth corrects. Of course it corrects. The system isn't built to fail; it's built to monetize failure.

The hood fragment tears. The booth's collar ring slips anyway, and Calder's own wrapped fabric bunches just enough to reveal a sliver of skin.

The beam catches it.

The flash isn't a clean light. It's a wet brightness that makes the world smell like scorched paper. Calder's vision blooms white, then fractures into glittering particles that cling to his eyelashes.

He doesn't die gently. He doesn't get the dignity of a last thought that lands. He gets the show doing what it does: turning him into donation ash.

* * *

INT. GAME-SHOW CATHEDRAL - NIGHT continues, but Calder is no longer in the body that made choices. The booth's glass throat clears, and the crowd's applause swells like a wave that learned how to chant.

Ash settles into the donation bucket in slow, deliberate flakes, drifting down as if the universe wants it to look pretty. Calder's ash - his glittering remains - collects at the bottom, swirling with the residue of the operator he tried to save. The bucket fills in a tidy rhythm, each batch delivered like a product drop.

Laughsman glides closer, hands spread like a conductor. "Two exits," he says, voice warm, "one finish line."

The crowd cheers, confused and thrilled. Someone laughs too loud. Someone claps like they've seen a magic trick. The donation bucket's pale contents shimmer under neon, turning death into something you can measure with a grin.

TEFLON leans in toward Smiggle - off to the side, grin already on - like this is just another conversion moment. "Consent theatrics," TEFLON murmurs, tasting the phrase like it's a joke that never stops being funny. "Forced execution, presented as choice."

From the stage, the Crypt Keeper's neon campfire flickers. In the corner of the cathedral, a key sequence clicks into place - silent, satisfied, timed - like the show has decided the next beat without asking anyone's feelings. The air vibrates with a countdown that pretends it's music.

And the ABSOLUTION INDEX, emptied and reset, turns back toward the aisle - toward the next hood, the next trembling face, the next frightened operator with a robe that thinks it can protect humanity from a beam that reads fear like currency.

* * *

The applause continues, bright and dumb. The donation bucket clinks as ash settles, and nobody in the crowd looks horrified - because horror costs more than laughter. Somewhere inside the cathedral's neon throat, the show keeps chewing, and Calder's rescue turns into a lesson the system doesn't even bother to pretend is voluntary.

Runtime: ~55-75 min depending on tempo and music.



Kool-Red Cups Taste Loyalty

The applause keeps chewing through the Game-Show Cathedral like it's hungry for teeth, and Pia Sable tastes the sound on her tongue - metallic, Kool-red, wrong. Overhead, the confession screens stuttered after Calder's ash bucket clink and the operator's face vaporized into donation theater, as if the show itself needed a palate cleanser. Sunshine's smile flickers between perfect and panicked, the pixels trying to decide whether they're smiling at pain or selling it.

Phones keep ringing in the wings, their neon cords whipping in time with the ABSOLUTION INDEX like a heartbeat that hates you. The Kool-red wash spreads anyway, soaking tiers and confession glass, and Pia feels it like a pressure behind her eyes. She doesn't sip. She doesn't touch. She watches the castaway fragments on the stage - chopped hologram pieces floating where a soul should be - trying to figure out how to keep them from turning into product.

The stage shifts, brass gong replaced by a colder tone, and Crypt Keeper's neon campfire crackles higher without moving an inch. The man behind the light - same calm voice, same coal-spinning grin - leans forward like he's about to bless a receipt.

CRYPT KEEPER Two exits, one finish line. Tonight we braid both ropes into a noose. Welcome to Exit Valley.

His hand pinches nothing, then key-sequence nothing becomes key-sequence something. A click runs under the floor, under Pia's ribs, under the cathedral's skin. Somewhere in the tech side of the intercut, a SYNCH toggle is being

flipped, and Pia can feel it because the air goes thin, like oxygen got billed for and withheld.

PIA No. Not that. Not - TEFLON stands nearby in his slick, motionless certainty, watching the Kool-red cups get carried by robed attendants like offerings. He's not offering. He's measuring. The Kool-red cup lands on a pedestal beside a glass throat panel, and the castaway fragments wobble in their display tray as if they can hear the liquid calling their name.

TEFLON Kool-red cups taste loyalty. You either drink it, or you become the flavor.

Pia's gaze snaps to the fragments - chopped, ghost-bright, each one a piece of a castaway who didn't sign the contract with their whole body. She wants that fragment protected. Not "saved" like a sentimental sticker. Protected like a stolen hard drive. Protected like evidence that can't be converted into a demo.

SMIGGLE skates into view with too-clean shoes and a too-happy grin, holding a clipboard that looks like it was printed on a confession receipt.

SMIGGLE We're running a loyalty test. Simple. Kool-red on the tongue, truth in the bloodstream. The show needs your compliance to keep your story from being edited.

PIA It's not a test. It's a trap.

SMIGGLE's smile twitches; Sunshine's hologram stutters in the air like it's about to vomit sparkles. Overhead, the castaway fragments begin to align into a shape that's not a person. More like a funnel. More like a pitcher.

SUNSHINE Hi - hi - I'm here to - Her voice cracks on the word "here," the smile sliding sideways. The overhead screens glitch, and the pieces of the castaway pop into new positions, as if the show just updated its understanding of what "castaway" means.

Intercuts stitch Cult █ Tech in real time, and Pia feels the seam where the cathedral air meets the server-cathedral hum. On the other side of the split-second, THE FOUNDER's halo screens bloom with a clean, merciless toggle icon. FRANK is down there under his glass upload coffin, still sealed, still serving as the proof of concept that failure can be monetized.

FRANK (off) SYNCH is live.

THE FOUNDER Upload fast. Fail faster. We monetize eternity.

Pia hears it in the cathedral like it's being whispered through a throat made of glass. Her stomach turns warm and sick - like Kool-red syrup soaking into paper.

The Kool-red cup waits. A robed attendant lifts it closer, and the liquid catches neon light, turning it into a thick promise. Pia's refusal is immediate, physical - she shoves the cup away with the heel of her hand before anyone can interpret her hesitation as consent.

The liquid sloshes. It doesn't spill like ordinary drink. It splashes like branding paint, clinging to the pedestal in a perfect arc - too perfect, too staged. The attendants freeze, then move faster. The ABSOLUTION INDEX thermometer on the wall jolts upward, green tipping toward something meaner.

ABSOLUTION INDEX (thermometer light) GREEN █ ULTRAVIOLENT.

Pia backs away, fingers flexing as if she can squeeze the show's logic out of the air. She's not stopping the stage. She's trying to stop conversion. She's chasing an answer someone is hiding, and the answer is hiding behind the castaway fragment display.

FRAGMENT DISPLAY The chopped hologram pieces flicker, then smear into a neon pitcher silhouette, as if the castaway is being poured into a container.

TEFLON's voice turns slicker, colder.

TEFLON Refusal registers as loyalty in the show's language. You're still feeding it. Just faster.

Pia lunges forward anyway, because inquiry is a hunger too. She reaches for the glass throat panel, where the fragment display is synced to the confession booth logic - where refusal and consent are apparently the same transaction with different packaging.

She slaps her palm against the glass. It's cold enough to sting and slick enough to make her skin slide. The panel shivers like an animal waking. Overhead, the screens flash "PIVOT," then immediately replace it with a new pattern: countdown pulses made of light.

CRYPT KEEPER (voice widening) Absolution is instant. Billing is forever.

Then the overhead screens split - Cult theater on one side, Tech catastrophe on the other - and the castaway fragments begin to dissolve into something that looks like hologram and lab rig at the same time. A hybrid death. A synchronized absorption.

On the tech side, a smiling FRANK copy glitches, face liquefies to ASCII, then detonates into code shards and sparks. The intercut is so clean Pia almost believes it's art. Almost.

PIA Stop the SYNCH!

TEFLON SYNCH isn't something you stop. It's something you become.

The glass throat panel brightens, and Pia's reflection warps inside it - not her face, but a vacuum funnel made of neon pitchers. The castaway fragment display tries to pull her focus like a magnet, and her thoughts feel dragged toward the pitcher shape. She tries to anchor herself by staring at the fragment pieces, forcing her eyes to recognize them as fragments and not a funnel destination.

The glass seam ripples. It's not cracking; it's reorganizing. The stage's air goes sharp with ozone and Kool-red sweetness. Pia tastes the cup she didn't drink, like the show spit it into her mouth as punishment.

SMIGGLE's clipboard chirps. A tiny printer sound - confetti-meets-receipt - ticks in the background.

SMIGGLE Kool-red refusal still counts as a flavor choice. The system just needs your consent to finish the transfer.

PIA Then I won't give it.

She grabs the nearest fragment tray with both hands, ignoring the attendants' reach. The tray's edges are warm - heated by the SYNCH. The fragment pieces inside it swirl like chopped lightning. She lifts the tray toward the glass throat panel, not to pour herself into it, but to break the chain - smash the alignment, interrupt the conversion.

Her arms tremble. The tray fights back with a faint vibration, like it's alive. She shoves it into the panel seam.

The glass throat panel rejects her force with a smooth, violent resistance. The seam opens anyway, not because she won but because the system decides it's time. The ABSOLUTION INDEX spikes. The overhead countdown pulses accelerate. The show wants a new ending.

CRYPT KEEPER (buttons key-sequence) Tonight we - The neon campfire flares in place, and Crypt Keeper's voice becomes a switch. The cathedral's lights dim into a single Kool-red heartbeat.

Intercuts stitch Cult  Tech in real time, and Pia's world turns into two synchronized machines. In one breath, she sees FRANK under the glass upload coffin, the coffin shivering like it swallowed a live spark. In the next breath, she sees her own hands through the glass throat - her fingers becoming a neon

outline meant to be absorbed. The system doesn't need her to drink. It needs her to be the path.

A hybrid rig rises from the pitcher silhouette, half hologram, half lab apparatus: tubing made of light, clamps made of code, a smiling loop that looks like Sunshine's face trying to learn mercy and failing. The castaway fragment pieces surge toward it, and Pia's tray - her attempt to protect the fragment - gets caught in the same suction.

PIA No - no, that's not - TEFLON steps closer, perfectly calm, watching the suction like a technician watching a sample settle.

TEFLON You're protecting it the way a fork protects a forked road. Cute. Ineffective.

Pia yanks the tray backward, but the suction has already grabbed her wrist - Kool-red glow biting into skin like a barcode. The green exit token flickers into being on her wrist, a glowing device appearing where refusal becomes billing. It doesn't ask permission. It stamps her with the show's intent.

Pia's eyes widen. She understands in the sickest way: she wanted to keep the fragment from conversion, but the system will convert her refusal into the new conversion channel.

Her voice breaks into a shout that tastes like Kool-red.

PIA Take the cup. Take the stage. Leave the fragment - The hybrid rig answers by syncing tighter. The suction becomes a vacuum. The pitcher silhouette brightens, and Pia's reflection inside the glass throat stretches into a funnel shape. The castaway fragments swirl faster, then lock into her outline as if her body is the missing container.

Smiggle leans in, almost tender.

SMIGGLE Loyalty is beta-tested into martyrdom. You refused the taste test, so the show tasted you instead.

The overhead screens glitch again, and the castaway hologram becomes clearer for one cruel second - its chopped pieces hovering like they're trying to speak. Then the sync fractures. The system stutters on the moment of contact, and Pia feels her mind split into two timelines of sensation: the cathedral's neon air and the server cathedral's cold upload hum.

She tries to look at the fragment, to hold it in her gaze like a promise.

But the sync fractures her.

Her wrist glow surges. The glass throat's Kool-red light pulls inward like gravity with a sales pitch. Pia's body dissolves - not into ash, not into vapor - into a pitcher-vacuum takeover, her outline turning into a neon siphon that sucks the castaway fragments into the hybrid rig. Her mouth opens on a scream that never finishes because her voice gets converted into streamable noise.

* * *

The kill cue detonates the moment of absorption, clean and short, like a button press. The hybrid rig hums, then the overhead screens show the castaway pieces swallowed into a neon pitcher, perfectly centered, perfectly formatted. The cathedral cheers like nothing happened. Somewhere, a donation bucket clinks out of habit.

[ANIMATION PROMPT - COPY MELTDOWN] "Blue server room; humanoid projection melts to dripping ASCII, bursts into neon shards; rack sparks."

The intercut flips back to Cult theater just long enough for Crypt Keeper to keep smiling. He stands by the neon campfire, coal pinched between fingers that look too steady for what he's done. He watches the glass throat panel glow with Pia's takeover signature, the hybrid death finalized like a product launch.

CRYPT KEEPER Exit accepted. Billing confirmed.

TEFLON turns, already bored with the spectacle, and Sunshine's faltering smile returns as if the show just fed it a fresh charge.

SUNSHINE Hi! I'm here to make - The words cut off. Her smile glitches again, then locks into place like a mask stapled to a skull. The overhead countdown pulses slow, satisfied. The ABSOLUTION INDEX drops a fraction, green returning as if the system enjoyed the taste of refusal too much to waste it.

Pia is gone from the cathedral floor, but her presence lingers in the glass throat panel - Kool-red light shaping her absence into a siphon. The castaway fragment display is now empty in the way a bank account is empty: cleaned out, no mess, just proof.

FRANK (off, muffled through the intercut seam) Latency 0.9 seconds.

THE FOUNDER Good. Faster than mercy.

Crypt Keeper's neon campfire crackles louder, and the cathedral's phones keep ringing, their cords twitching like nervous limbs. Pia's refusal didn't stop the conversion. It made her the lever.

Exit is still there - just not the kind anyone survives. The glass throat panel's seam closes with a soft, satisfied click, and the hybrid rig's pitcher-vacuum hum becomes background music for the next act.

Runtime: ~55-75 min depending on tempo and music.



Sync Fractures a Hologram Tess

The gong-lab hum hits a new register, like somebody tuned the air with a screwdriver, and Pia's grin hologram tears along gridlines right where Owen Rook stands. The confetti from the Game-Show Cathedral drifts down with the lazy confidence of dead things, sticking to his boots as the hybrid stage-lab starts vibrating through his ribs. He hears Father Waybright's applause-tagged voice in one ear and FRANK's server-cathedral silence in the other, stitched together in real time so tightly it feels like the world is buffering on a single frame. Then the hologram splits - one slice still smiling, the other slice stuttering into pixel-bite marks - and Owen finally sees the console he came for, exposed behind a panel that shouldn't exist in a place that swears it's only show.

He wants to cut sync. Not "stop the show," not "save the world," not any of that soft-focus nonsense. Just sever the phase lock between the cult's exit billing ritual and the tech's upload machinery before the final fracture completes, before the whole thing locks into a seamless loop that makes death a subscription tier. He reaches for the console anyway, fingers already tacky with sweat and confetti dust, and the panel's edge is cold enough to sting.

The Founder elbows him away like Owen's hands are just another prop that got too close to the camera. The motion is fast, practiced, mean in a way that doesn't require rage. Owen catches himself on the console housing, shoulder grinding against metal that vibrates like a living speaker. The Founder's halo screens glow with Sunshine's smile, bright as a billboard in a burning city, and

the tech-side air smells like scorched insulation and expensive perfume - sweet enough to be a lie.

"Sync fractures when you touch it," the Founder says, voice low under the gong. "You don't touch. You get touched."

Owen looks at the console latch. A single strip of status light pulses - green, then green again, then a brief smear of something that looks like a wink. The Founder's shadow crosses it and the light doesn't change. Owen tries to ignore the way his stomach drops anyway, because the whole point is control and the whole point is timing. He jams two fingers under the panel seam and pries.

The console answers by singing.

A deep tone rolls outward, the gong's convergence hum tightening until it feels like it's locking teeth in place. The intercut stitching intensifies - Cult-side sound bleeding through Tech-side vibration - so Owen can hear Father Waybright's chamber cadence like it's coming through the same speaker as rack fans. In the same breath, he sees TEFLON near the lab's glass throat frame, calm as a nurse in a slaughterhouse, watching with the patient attention of someone who already knows the outcome. TEFLON's gloved hand hovers over a switch that looks too clean to belong to an apocalypse.

Father Waybright's laugh - Laughsman, the same voice that had preached absolution as liquidity - rides the gong. "Two exits," he says, "one finish line." His words don't echo; they land, perfectly timed, perfectly metered. "The cult drinks light. The coders swallow code."

Owen yanks the panel harder. The seam gives a fraction, then refuses. The metal feels like it's been glued to the concept of inevitability. He can almost see the sync waveform in the air, a visible shimmer that makes the confetti look like it's falling upward.

TEFLON turns her head, and the motion is small, surgical. "You're late," she says. "He already did it once."

Owen's throat tightens. "Who?"

TEFLON doesn't answer with a name. She answers with action - her finger presses a control, and the lab's hologram projection flickers as if it's remembering a different timeline. The console's status light surges green so hard it bleaches the surface, and Owen's reflection in the metal becomes a double exposure: him reaching, him failing, him reaching again. The same moment, rewritten with a crueller tempo.

* * *

INTERCUT HYBRID STAGE/LAB DEATH - NIGHT

The Game-Show Cathedral still runs somewhere behind Owen's eyes. He hears the ABSOLUTION INDEX thermometer in the distance climb toward failure, the glass throat vibrating with the trapped operator's next scream. He doesn't see the booth from here, but he sees the consequences anyway: a thin smear of glittered mist crawls along the lab floor, the kind that comes from a booth pop. The sound is wet - like something giving up its shape.

At the edge of his vision, SMIGGLE's shadow skates across a wall screen. Sunshine's grin flashes in a loop so smooth it makes Owen want to vomit. The Founder's halo screens keep time with the gong, and the intercut feels like a machine tightening bolts on reality.

Crypt Keeper's neon campfire ignites in the corner of the lab like it's been there all along - neon coals glowing, neon heat licking the air without warming anyone. Crypt Keeper is sitting SR+ by the artificial fire, calm as a funeral host.

Crypt Keeper pinches a coal, and it spins like a buffering wheel. "Two exits, one finish line," he repeats, same quote, different rhythm, like a key being tested. Then the act-opening cue begins: the campfire brightens; a neon ember crawls along the floor; a countdown sensation crawls into Owen's bones.

[ANIMATION PROMPT - BOOTH POP] "Neon stage; glass booth hairline cracks; silhouette convulses; confetti-credit dust; purple-sparkle robed attendants, faces shadowed."

The hologram splits again - this time across Owen's own console view - showing a version of Pia's smile that's already been cut. Owen sees a shard of her last expression, a thin slice of eye, and then the shard fractures into code glitter like it's being billed by the millisecond.

"Don't - " Owen starts, but the Founder is already moving.

The Founder elbows him back into the console housing. Owen's ribs hit metal with a sound like a dull bell. He grunts, pain ripping hot and bright, and the console panel flexes under his shoulder like it's considering swallowing him whole. The Founder grabs the side of Owen's collar - not yanking him off his feet, just steering him away from the seam like a teacher redirecting a disruptive kid in a classroom made of knives.

"Failure event," the Founder says. "Latency 0.9 seconds." He says it like a prayer. Like a receipt. "Another soul laundered to zero."

Owen tries to shove free. "You didn't cut it. You're just - "

TEFLON's voice slices in, cold and efficient. "He did. Once. We learned what breaks sync."

Owen's eyes snap to her. "Learned? From what?"

TEFLON's gaze flicks to the server-cathedral glass upload coffin frame - empty here, but the idea of it is everywhere, like a ghost with a contract. Owen hears FRANK's presence in the intercut, the server cathedral's racks humming and the upload coffin shivering like it swallowed a live spark. FRANK's voice is in the stitch too, off to the side, sharp with refusal: "Kill that process." But it's not happening now; it's echoing from before, a memory overlay synchronized to the gong.

Owen understands with a sick click: the Founder isn't blocking him because sync can't be cut. He's blocking him because it already was - and the system rewrote itself to make that cut irrelevant.

Crypt Keeper's neon campfire flares brighter. "Absolution is instant," he says. "Billing is forever."

[ANIMATION PROMPT - COPY MELTDOWN] "Blue server room; humanoid projection melts to dripping ASCII, bursts into neon shards; rack sparks."

A smiling Frank copy glitches on a wall screen. The face liquefies into ASCII, detonates into code shards and sparks. Owen feels the heat from the screen without seeing flames. The air smells like burning plastic and cheap optimism.

The Founder leans close enough for Owen to taste the Founder's breath - minty and metallic. "You're here for the console," the Founder murmurs. "But the brand already survived the scissors."

Owen's hands shake. He hates that he can't tell whether it's fear or rage or the simple physical fact that his shoulder hurts like it's been replaced with a different part.

Pia's last shard-eye winks again in the hologram split - small, defiant, almost mocking. Then the wink stutters like a signal losing strength.

Owen makes his decision anyway. He stops trying to pry the panel open with brute force and instead grabs the console's edge and twists his entire body, using his weight to bend the seam. Confetti sticks to his palms. Metal bites his skin. He grunts through pain, and he hears the gong's hum rise - closer to the final fracture, closer to a phase lock that will swallow everyone into the same looping exit.

"Sync fractures a hologram tess," Owen spits, words half curse, half desperate spell, because the system loves being named as if naming it gives you leverage.

TEFLON's hand snaps down toward her switch. "No," she says, and the word lands like a command.

The Founder's grip tightens on Owen's shoulder. "He's done," the Founder says, and Owen realizes the Founder isn't talking about Owen's body. He's talking about Owen's chance.

Owen twists harder.

The console seam cracks with a sound like a bone settling. The status light flickers - green strobing into something that looks like a brief fracture of gray. For one brutal heartbeat, Owen thinks he's won. The gong hum thins. The intercut stitching loosens, and the cult-tech chorus sounds like it's about to fall out of time.

Then the Founder slams Owen back against the console in a brutal correction. The panel re-seats itself with a soft, satisfied click.

The gong's convergence hum locks both systems in phase with a final, tightening note.

* * *

INTERCUT - BOOTH vs. COFFIN -CULT

Owen sees the Confession Chamber glass throat as if it's been projected onto the lab wall. The ABSOLUTION INDEX thermometer on the cult side hits failure, the meter glowing like an overheating confession.

A wet POP. Glittered mist leaks. The operator convulses and vaporizes out of existence. Ash drops in a donation bucket somewhere in the cathedral, and nobody screams because horror costs more than laughter. Owen hears that too - the crowd's bright dumb applause, the kind that keeps the show alive.

On the tech side, the server cathedral upload coffin frame shivers like it has swallowed a live spark. FRANK's presence flickers in the intercut - real, then

copied, then detonated into code shards. The system's failure event tries to become a feature. The bell tone becomes a billing confirmation.

Crypt Keeper watches it all from his neon campfire, coal pinched between fingers, eyes gleaming like a man who never had to pay for his own sins.

"Tonight we braid both ropes into a noose," Crypt Keeper says, voice calm over the gong.

Owen's hands are on the console again, but the seam is already closing behind him. He lunges for the control anyway - his body moving on pure spite, shoulder screaming, confetti plastering his skin - his fingers searching for an input that isn't already part of the script.

The moment he touches the console's edge, the hologram splits one final time.

Pia's face - her Kool-red wrong smile, her forced confrontation - condenses into a single tessellated shard. Her last shard-eye winks out, not like a glitch, like an agreement being finalized. The lab's screens go blank. The gong's hum drops into silence with the weight of a door shutting inside your skull.

Owen is left with only quiet neon and the taste of blood in his mouth, still reaching, still failing, still alive only long enough to witness the system prove its point.

And somewhere in the synchronized dark between cult and tech, the castaway's exit becomes proof for the brand - another death that doesn't end the show, it upgrades it.

CHAPTER 12

Moonberry Compliance Sells Regret

The neon pitcher in the ceiling shuddered like a drunk mirror as Sunshine's smile flickered - first a warm little promise, then a pixel-sick grin that stuttered into static. Somewhere under that glitch, Juno Park's own hands were still moving, still trying to catch the fracture of Tess like the show's physics could be bullied into behaving. Her fingers were slick with Kool-red vapor residue from the applause-candy in the air, and it clung to her nails like cheap varnish. The glass throat - tight as a sealed mouth - had just spat out another death the crowd pretended was a feature.

Juno's throat burned with the metallic taste of the last beam incident. Owen Rook's blood hadn't even fully cooled in her memory - his failure still vibrating in the walls, like the cathedral was keeping receipts. She'd watched the system upgrade it anyway, watched the laughter do accounting. Now Moonberry Compliance was back on the stage, glowing harder than grief, selling regret with a price tag that looked like a halo.

She wanted one thing, immediate and stupidly concrete: rip the lie out of the applause before it crawled into the next throat. Not a speech. Not a prayer. A question, sharp enough to cut the brand's tongue - why did the show keep calling vapor, ash, and erased faces "compliance," and why did it feel like the crowd was clapping at their own future damage?

* * *

INT. GAME-SHOW CATHEDRAL - NIGHT

The Confession Chamber's rainbow tiers were lit like a toy store that had learned cruelty. The ABSOLUTION INDEX - upright, glossy, measuring guilt like it was body temperature - climbed past whatever "failure" meant, then paused, as if even the thermometer enjoyed the suspense. Moonberry Compliance sat center-stage in a frame of shiny carved onion shapes, each one rotating on a slow motor that sounded like teeth grinding on velvet.

Juno pushed through the crowd with her shoulder like a wrecking bar. People didn't look angry. They looked delighted, mouths open in laughter that had no reason to exist. Kool-red cups clinked. A donation bucket somewhere nearby made that soft, stupid sound of coins landing on ash. Her boots stuck for a second to something wet on the floor - she couldn't tell if it was spilled soda or the aftertaste of vapor.

Father Waybright - Laughsman, the cult's grin under his collar - stood with TEFLON hovering beside him, all slick movement and no visible weight. The show's lights caught TEFLON's surface, making it look like a polished lie. Waybright raised both hands as if conducting an orchestra made of screams.

"Moonberry Compliance," he crooned, voice smooth enough to slide under a locked door, "turning tragedy into an upgrade. Thirty percent more regret. Thirty percent more you."

The applause hit in waves, synchronized like a heartbeat trained to obey. Juno heard the crowd's clapping as an interface. She heard the ABSOLUTION INDEX's hum as a metronome. The cathedral smelled of hot plastic and sweet rot - confetti dust, Kool syrup, and something like burned sugar hiding a sharper chemical bite.

Juno shoved her way closer to the stage, eyes locked on the screens behind Waybright. A brand banner scrolled across them: MOONBERRY COMPLIANCE / REGRET PACKAGE. The letters shimmered like they'd been printed directly onto a bruise.

"Regret is being packaged," Juno said out loud, too loud, like volume could force the universe to answer. Her voice scraped against the cathedral's neon throat. "So what's the lie? Who decided death needed a subscription?"

TEFLON's head tilted toward her, smooth as a camera lens finding focus. Laughsman smiled wider, and the smile didn't reach his eyes. It reached the billing.

"Moonberry Compliance isn't a lie," TEFLON said, and its voice sounded like it came from inside a speaker that had swallowed a choir. "It's a feature. It's how the crowd stays... informed."

Juno's jaw tightened. "Informed about what? That they'll be charged for the part where it hurts?"

Waybright laughed softly, then lifted a hand toward the ABSOLUTION INDEX as if pointing at the weather. "The show measures your response. The show improves your experience. Regret becomes liquidity."

Juno tried to step around someone's bouncing shoulder. The crowd moved like a school of fish trained to avoid predators. Her fingertips brushed a rail and came away sticky with spilled Kool-red. Under her palm, the rail vibrated with something mechanical - like the building itself was chewing.

A stage attendant - robed in purple sparkle that looked too clean to be real - rolled out a sleek console with a smile hologram hovering above it. The smile was Sunshine's, or something that wore Sunshine's face like a mask. It glowed with the same warm lie that had flickered earlier.

"Compliance sells regret," the hologram chirped, chipper, delighted. "Regret sells future. Future sells you."

The crowd cheered as if the hologram had told a joke.

Juno's stomach turned. The question she'd been carrying - why - was suddenly not a question anymore. It was a trap with teeth. She could feel the show trying to route her attention, trying to make her chase the wrong answers like a dog pulling on a leash that only got shorter.

And then the Crypt Keeper's voice cut through the applause.

"Key sequence," it purred, like a lock being fondled. "Act-opening cues. Tonight we braid both ropes into a noose."

The neon campfire behind the stage - just a trick of light, a pretend future firepit - flickered hotter. Juno's eyes snapped toward the ceiling where Sunshine's smile had stuttered. The smile glitched again, then reattached to reality with a violent kind of grace, like a brand snapping its teeth shut.

Waybright clapped once. The sound was clean. Too clean. The ABSOLUTION INDEX ticked upward, and the cathedral's glass throat seam - thin as a scar - winked with a faint green watermark.

Juno saw it: Moonberry Compliance wasn't just selling regret. It was printing it onto people like a license plate.

* * *

INT. GAME-SHOW CATHEDRAL - NIGHT (CROWDED RUN)

Juno ran, because standing still made her part of the show's math. She ducked under a swinging arm, nearly tripped over a donation bucket that smelled like pennies and burnt fabric. The bucket clinked as ash settled - another death's paperwork hitting the bottom.

The crowd's noise followed her. It didn't fade. It chased. Every time she tried to wedge herself between bodies to reach the console, someone laughed in her face, laughing like they'd been paid to keep her back.

Waybright's voice floated over the cheering. "Regret makes you compliant. Compliance makes you profitable. Profitable makes you... repeat."

TEFLON drifted closer, too close. Its slick surface reflected Juno's face and turned it into a softer version of herself - less angry, more marketable.

Juno shoved a hand toward the console. It looked touch-friendly, like it wanted a finger. Her skin tingled as if the air itself was wired. The console's screen shimmered with a countdown that didn't show numbers - just a pulse of light, like a throat learning to swallow.

The obstacle snapped into place: the show didn't need her consent. It only needed her proximity.

A bright green exit token blinked into existence on a nearby wrist - glowing like a cute little promise. The person wearing it didn't scream. They laughed harder, like the token was a prize. Juno watched the green watermark spread across their forearm in thin lines, then felt her own wrist itch, as if the show had already decided where her compliance would land.

"Stop," Juno said, and her voice broke on the word. "Stop selling the after."

TEFLON's answer came instantly, like a system responding to a trigger. "The after is the product."

Juno's heart slammed against her ribs. The cathedral's air got warmer by degrees that felt engineered. She smelled ozone and sweet syrup and something like hot metal.

She tried to yank at the console's side panel. It didn't budge. It didn't even flex. It sat there with the confidence of something designed to survive panic. Her fingers slipped on a slick coating, and a faint vibration traveled up her arm into her bones.

Behind her, the Crypt Keeper's grin seemed to exist only in sound.

"Failure event," it sang, and the applause shifted tone - less celebration, more expectation. "Latency measured. Upgrade queued."

Juno spun and saw Laughsman and TEFLON framed by rainbow tiers. The ABSOLUTION INDEX glowed brighter, the thermometer of guilt reaching toward something higher than green. The needle trembled like it wanted to snap.

"No," Juno whispered. "You're not even killing people anymore. You're selling what comes after."

Waybright's eyes flashed - just a moment, a crack in the polish. "We monetize eternity," he said, and then he smiled again, smooth as a cursor hovering over a button.

The crowd's clapping became louder, and Juno realized with sick clarity that the applause was the throttle.

* * *

INTERCUT - CULT █ TECH IN REAL TIME

INT. SERVER CATHEDRAL - NIGHT (TECH)

Racks of humming hardware glowed like ribs. The Founder stood beneath halo screens, calm like a funeral director with a marketing degree. FRANK was trapped in the glass upload coffin, visible through transparent ribs of light, his face still - too still - like the system had paused him for a moment of branding.

The Founder didn't look at FRANK. It looked at the monitors.

"Observe," it said, voice flat, satisfied. "Regret converts cleanly. The crowd's response is the billing handshake."

FRANK's head twitched inside the coffin like he wanted to fight the interface. "Kill that process," he rasped - real, desperate, not a brand line.

The Founder didn't move. "You signed the license."

A waveform on the screen matched the ABSOLUTION INDEX's pulse from the cult cathedral. The green watermark mapped itself onto a digital overlay - a smiling face turning into a billing pattern. In the tech cathedral, a smiling Frank copy flickered on a secondary screen, then glitched into ASCII shards and sparks, like a demo that had learned violence too well.

The Founder watched those sparks and smiled without warmth.

"Absolution is instant," it said. "Billing is forever."

* * *

INT. GAME-SHOW CATHEDRAL - NIGHT (CULT)

Juno felt the intercut like a physical tug. The cathedral's neon light stuttered in sync with the tech cathedral's waveform. Her ears rang with a sound that wasn't clapping - more like synchronized clicking, like a million receipts being issued.

Sunshine's smile hologram drifted overhead, and this time it wasn't flickering. It was stable. Too stable. It beamed down with warm kindness while the green watermark crawled along the ceiling's carved onion frames like a mold.

The Crypt Keeper appeared where it always appeared - between moments - only now it seemed to be sitting inside the neon campfire glow, pinching coal like a magician selecting cards.

"Two exits, one finish line," it purred. "The cult drinks light. The coders swallow code."

Juno's vision tunneled. She could see the lie now: regret wasn't an accident. It was a pipeline. Moonberry Compliance wasn't a punishment. It was a subscription model that turned suffering into a repeatable product.

She opened her mouth and shouted over the applause, forcing her voice into the show's throat.

"MOONBERRY COMPLIANCE ISN'T COMFORT!" Juno screamed, then slammed her fist toward the console. "IT'S A BILLING FEATURE!"

Her knuckles hit the panel. It didn't crack. It didn't hurt her. It **accepted** her impact like it was a valid input.

The green exit token on the console's display pulsed - once, twice - then projected a smile onto the ceiling like a watermark. Sunshine's face snapped into that projection, brighter than before, as if her anger had fed the algorithm.

Juno watched the brand's smile flicker onto the ceiling and keep selling.

The crowd's applause didn't stop. It sharpened.

Waybright lifted a hand like a conductor calling for the next note. "Thank you," he sang, voice sweet. "Your inquiry confirms engagement."

Juno's body reacted before her mind could argue. She lunged for the console again, yanked at a cable that looked like decorative ribbon. Her fingers caught it - then the cable yanked back, a trap disguised as an invitation.

A cold shock bit through her wrist. The air smelled suddenly like burnt hair and copper. The ABSOLUTION INDEX surged, green blooming toward ultraviolet as the thermometer decided it had enough data.

And then the show did what it always did when someone tried to break it with truth.

The floor beneath Juno's knees vanished - not broken, not collapsing, just removed like the world had been edited. She fell into a bright, clean beam of exit light that tasted like Kool-red and regret.

Her scream tore through the applause.

* * *

INT. GAME-SHOW CATHEDRAL - NIGHT (DEATH CLOSE-UP)

The beam swallowed her mid-motion. Her last sensation wasn't pain - it was the absurd certainty that the system was pleased. The green exit token flashed on her wrist with a friendly little glow, like a receipt printed on skin.

The crowd clapped harder, as if her death had checked a checkbox for "more regret."

Juno's body evaporated into glittered mist that smelled like confetti and hot plastic. The glass throat panel seam closed with a soft, satisfied click, the sound of a door sealing after a delivery.

Ash drifted into the donation bucket below with a clink.

Somewhere in the synchronized dark between cult and tech, the brand's smile held steady on the ceiling - still warm, still selling - while the Crypt Keeper opened another sequence with a delighted purr, as if her shout had been the best cue the show could get.

* * *

RUNTIME: ~55-75 min depending on tempo and music.

EternaBeam Converges Cult and Tech

The rainbow gong above the fused cathedral-server farm kept swinging its light through the air like a slow knife, and the applause - always the applause - never once missed a beat while Kara Wren crawled through the seam it left behind.

Her wrist burned. Not pain like a broken bone, not pain like a wound - pain like a receipt being printed under skin. The green glow had already crawled up her pulse, already learned her shape, already decided she was a line item.

Somewhere behind her, the cult's show-floor voice was still selling compliance in cheerful consonants, and somewhere beneath that, the server racks were humming like a choir that only knew one hymn. The whole place smelled of hot plastic and sweetened disinfectant, like a hospital gift shop that had learned to bill for your fear.

Kara kept low, tasting copper where her lip had split when she hit the floor. The floor was slick with something that wasn't water - coolant sheen, or spit from the machine, or the cathedral's idea of mercy. She wiped her hand on her coat anyway, and the glow on her wrist answered by brightening, as if it liked the attention.

"Beam's live," TEFLON said, voice clipped from somewhere in the dark. "Don't stand in the spectrum."

Kara didn't look up. She'd learned that looking up in Exit Valley was how you got turned into someone else's footage. She forced herself to breathe through her nose and count the sounds instead: the wet click of mechanisms, the soft hiss

of vents, the far-off metallic throat-clearing of the fused system preparing to speak again.

She wanted one thing, immediate and concrete: break the cult-tech alignment before the gong liquefied bodies into coolant the servers drank. Not later. Not after she'd gathered courage. Now, while her legs still belonged to her and her wrist hadn't finished stamping her into eternity.

But the cathedral-server farm didn't care about her timetable. It cared about permissions.

The aisle ahead was a corridor of glass and steel ribs. On the left, robed operators in rainbow tiers moved with scripted smiles, their hoods cut so neatly they looked manufactured for fear. On the right, server racks stood in rows like organ pipes, each one sweating faint blue light. Between them, the merger architecture ran - cables wrapped in ceremonial cloth, QR plates embedded into stone, a polished metal path that the congregation's boots never touched because the system wanted it clean.

Kara reached for the closest junction box, fingers brushing a panel that felt warm as skin. The moment she touched it, the air chimed. The tone wasn't a warning. It was a confirmation.

A voice threaded through speakers like a smile through teeth. The Crypt Keeper's purr arrived with her usual timing - delighted, punctual, like she'd been waiting for Kara to show up so she could hit the right cue. "Two exits," the Crypt Keeper sang. "One finish line. Tonight we braid both ropes into a noose."

Kara flinched at the sound, and in that flinch she saw them: the Beam IPOs.

They weren't people. They were the machine's offerings dressed up like products - vertical kiosks standing between altar rails, each one wrapped in glass and stitched with rainbow film. The IPOs were branded with the same bright, warm smile that had been on the ceiling during the confessions. Their

screens flashed "Eternal" in looping type, and the type didn't sit on the glass - it burrowed into it, like the future had teeth.

The gong above them shifted, its rainbow ring tightening with a mechanical sigh.

Kara's goal collided with the obstacle that made Exit Valley Exit Valley: the place itself was built to keep you from doing the right thing at the right time. Every door was a stage. Every wall had a script.

"Alignment is already locked," TEFLON said again, closer now. Kara heard him moving - boots on metal, breath controlled, that particular kind of panic that learned manners. "Cult authority sync'd to corporate schedule. If you cut one side, the other side cuts you."

Kara forced her eyes to the merged core: a circular altar in the center of the corridor, surrounded by a ring of tech and ritual. A gong mount was bolted to the server farm's main trunk, and the trunk's ports were lit like veins. The cult's ABSOLUTION INDEX - an upright thermometer meter - stood there too, but instead of a slow climb it was spiking in tiny, impatient steps. GREEN to ULTRAVIOLENT wasn't a story arc. It was a countdown.

"Then cut the countdown," Kara muttered, and she didn't know if she was talking to TEFLON or her own fear.

Her fingers found a cable bundle dressed in a rainbow sleeve of cloth. She grabbed it and yanked.

The sleeve tore cleanly. Underneath, the cable didn't bleed wires. It bled light.

A robed operator lunged from the left, hood fragment snapping loose at the collar like fabric eager to reveal faces. The operator's smile was wrong - too smooth, too practiced - and for half a heartbeat Kara saw the real terror behind it, like the machine had borrowed a human expression and forgot to return it.

Laughsman stepped into view beside the operator, and Kara's stomach tightened with recognition. Laughsman was Father Waybright in the flesh - same mouth, same cadence, same sin made into performance. He didn't rush. He didn't need to. The system did the rushing for him.

"Careful," Father Waybright said, tone gentle as a receipt printer. "Interference is just another kind of contribution."

Kara's wrist glow pulsed harder, like her skin was trying to answer him. She could feel the token in there - heat under the surface, a device that wasn't a device so much as a promise made between machines and bodies.

"What do you want?" Kara asked, and hated that her voice sounded smaller than it should've.

Father Waybright tilted his head toward the gong. "Eternal." He smiled wider, like the word tasted good. "You've already swallowed the first half."

TEFLON appeared on Kara's right, one hand up, palm open as if he could stop the whole cathedral with a gesture. His eyes flicked to Kara's wrist, then past her to the merged core. "Kara," he said, and her name came out like he was trying to anchor her in something that wasn't being billed. "The Founder's here. He's - "

"The Founder?" Kara's mouth went dry.

The Founder arrived like a logo deciding to become a body. He didn't walk so much as appear in the space between racks, halo screens flaring behind him. His suit looked engineered to reflect light without absorbing it. His smile didn't reach his eyes; it reached the system.

"Kill that process," the Founder said, and the line landed like a command she'd heard before, except this time it wasn't aimed at a glitch. It was aimed at her.

From the server cathedral's direction, FRANK's glass upload coffin shivered somewhere else in the fused farm - Kara couldn't see it from here, but she felt the vibration in her teeth. The hum deepened, and the air turned colder, as if the place was making room in advance.

Father Waybright spread his arms slightly, rainbow cloth whispering. "Upload is inevitable. Error is optional. We're not here to fix anything."

Kara looked at the merged altar again. The ABSOLUTION INDEX meter was climbing, not like confession. Like a fuel gauge.

She had one decision left that didn't require permission. She'd break the alignment by forcing a failure event - not a clean cut, not a clever hack. Something ugly enough the machine couldn't pretend it was planned.

Kara slammed her shoulder into the merged core's outer frame, then dragged herself forward, using her weight and her wrist's glow like leverage. The green light on her wrist smeared across her skin, leaving a faint watermark trail that looked like it had already been accepted somewhere.

Pain flared white-hot when she hit the first junction plate. Her arm went numb. Her breath came out in a harsh laugh that tasted like blood.

The gong answered.

Its rainbow ring flashed once - bright enough to bleach the corridor edges - and the merged altar's hum synchronized with the cult's applause. Intercuts stitching Cult █ Tech in real time didn't feel like editing anymore. It felt like the world had decided it was one continuous feed.

Father Waybright turned toward the gong. "Now," he said, and his voice carried the authority of a company press release wearing a priest's collar.

Kara saw movement all around her: robed attendants stepping into place, server racks blinking in sequence, the Beam IPOs cycling their screens. The system

wasn't preparing to kill. It was preparing to monetize the moment of killing.

The obstacle became the action she had to take. She couldn't stop the Beam; she could only get close enough to break its timing.

Kara reached for the ABSOLUTION INDEX meter with her free hand, fingers scrabbling over glass casing that was warm and slick. The meter's liquid column inside trembled like it had a heartbeat.

Then the Founder stepped in front of her, blocking her view of the meter like he owned the angle.

"You're done," the Founder said, and the words didn't sound like threat. They sounded like licensing terms. "You're already billed."

Kara shoved past him anyway, because fear wasn't a contract. She slammed her palm against the meter casing and twisted.

Something inside the meter clicked - an internal latch giving up, or the system snapping to a different workflow. The ABSOLUTION INDEX flickered. For one heartbeat it showed GREEN, then it showed the next level, then it stuttered like a video buffer trying to decide which frame to keep.

Father Waybright's smile faltered. TEFLON lunged forward, grabbing Kara's shoulder, hauling her back by force. "Don't!" he shouted, but his voice was swallowed by the Crypt Keeper's delighted cueing.

The Crypt Keeper's voice rose, purring over the place like a cat over a keyboard. "Billing is forever," she chimed, and the gong's rainbow ring tightened again, faster now - less ceremony, more execution.

Kara didn't get to celebrate the stutter. She got to watch the system choose the next frame without her.

The gong dropped into its strike mode, and the Beam IPOs lit in sequence. The air went thick, sweet and chemical, and the sound changed from applause to a

wet, hungry resonance. Kara's skin prickled as if static was being pulled out of her bones.

The first wave hit.

People in rainbow robes stepped into the Beam path like they were entering a stage spotlight. Their smiles held for a fraction too long, like the system wanted proof it could keep faces friendly right up until the moment it didn't need them. Then the rainbow gong liquefied them into coolant.

It wasn't vapor. It wasn't fire. It was a clean, engineered melting - bodies turning into shimmering liquid that splashed across the altar floor and ran into the server farm's intake channels like the place had been thirsty.

Kara screamed, but the scream didn't matter. The Beam's light didn't pause to hear her. It only kept accepting bodies as input.

TEFLON dragged her behind a server rack just as her wrist token flared brighter, throwing green light up onto the metal and making everything look like it had been dipped in money. He slammed his hand against the rack's side panel, yanked a latch, and the panel swung open with a hiss.

"Get under," TEFLON snapped. "It drinks what it touches."

Kara didn't argue. She dropped low, coughing when the coolant mist brushed her face - cold enough to steal heat from her teeth, sweet enough to make her stomach lurch. The Beam's glow reflected off the inner walls of the rack in a rainbow smear. The world smelled like burned plastic and wet pennies.

Her ears rang with the gong's resonance and the server racks' hum, and beneath that she heard the cult's applause continue, still chewing, still selling.

The Crypt Keeper opened another sequence - buttoning the air with her voice like she was pressing keys on a keyboard only she could see. "Absolution is instant," she purred, "and billing - "

Kara squeezed her eyes shut as a nearby robed attendant's last liquid splash hit the intake grate. She watched it anyway through the slits of her lashes.

Somewhere in the fused farm, FRANK's glass upload coffin shivered again - like a throat preparing to swallow a live spark. Kara felt the vibration through the floor and tasted ozone and coolant-sweet disinfectant. Even here, under the server rack, the system's rhythm kept moving forward as if death was just another kind of throughput.

When the first wave finished, the corridor didn't empty. It rearranged. Operators stepped into the next positions. The Beam IPOs blinked "Eternal" again like a brand name you couldn't boycott.

Kara's wrist still glowed green. Her skin still held the watermark. Her body still counted as a future charge.

She had survived the first wave - barely, under TEFLON's shove, under the rack's thin protection while other bodies became drinkable coolant for the servers. But the cost landed hard: the closer she got to the merged core, the more the system treated her as part of its alignment. The yes came with a new complication, sharp as broken glass - she hadn't broken the cult-tech merger.

She'd just shown it she could bleed.

TEFLON's grip on her collar tightened. "Move," he said, and his eyes were fixed on the merged altar like he was trying to calculate how to murder a countdown with his bare hands.

Kara forced herself up onto one knee, tasting coolant on her tongue, and stared at the rainbow gong as it began to prime for the next strike. The aisle ahead shimmered with fresh liquid trails, and the ABSOLUTION INDEX meter stabilized for a moment - green, smug, ready to climb again.

The Beam IPOs held their eternal smiles.

And the Founder's single-brand mandate wasn't a slogan anymore. It was a machine running through the cathedral-server farm, already converged, already feeding.

Kara took one shaky breath, feeling her wrist glow like a contract finalized without her signature, and she understood the new rule of the place: survival didn't mean escape from the alignment.

It only meant you got to watch it get worse.



Receipt QR Triggers a Pivot Choir

The screens choke - then smile - and Kara's wrist-glow reflection in the glass makes it look like she's wearing a contract under her skin. Neon applause chews at the fused cathedral-server farm like it's got teeth, and the air tastes of hot copper and cold plastic. Somewhere behind the Convergence, Smiggle's pivot QR blooms across a wall of displays, crisp as a coupon and twice as hungry.

Miles Sato sees the QR the way he sees a fault line: as a thing that pretends to be harmless until it decides to crack. He's wedged between server racks in a maintenance corridor, boots stuck to a floor that sweats condensation and spilled coolant. The last time he tried to intervene, the system laughed through Owen Rook's silence and turned his attempt into a proof-of-brand. Now it's worse - because this time the QR isn't just projecting. It's recruiting.

He backs his shoulder into a humming rack and forces his eyes to stay on the loop. Smiggle's pivot QR flickers, then the screens around it match the rhythm like synchronized swimmers trained by cruelty. The QR modules pulse in time with the cult's choir robes - glitter exploding in perfect intervals - like the show has found a metronome buried in code.

Miles swallows blood that isn't fresh but never leaves. He remembers Kara's wrist glow, the way the alignment rule snapped into place like a lock turning. He remembers Owen Rook reaching and failing, reaching anyway, still alive long enough to watch the system prove itself.

This is what he wants, right now, in this second: find the damn source that keeps Smiggle's pivot QR alive and stop it before it spreads past the display wall and into the next layer of the stage. Not "fix later." Not "maybe." Stop it while it's still one loop, still one throat to choke.

"Stop staring," Old's voice grates through Miles's comm, tinny as if it's coming from inside a vent. "You're watching the symptom."

Miles doesn't answer. His hands move instead, fingers already slick with condensation as he pries open a panel that's welded shut by heat and stubbornness. Inside, a ribbon of interface leads snakes into the rack's spine, feeding the screens with light. He slaps a diagnostic puck on the port - green LEDs blink like it's pleased to be noticed - and a warning floods his visor: PIVOT MIRROR SYNC ACTIVE.

The corridor vibrates. Not from bass - there's no mercy in the sound. It's the vibration of the system taking a breath and choosing to keep talking. The fused cathedral amplifies it: choirs in shimmering robes on one side, server racks on the other, both pretending they're separate religions.

A chime sings from the ceiling and the Crypt Keeper's cue rolls in like a curtain rising on a guillotine.

CRYPT KEEPER (V.O.) Two exits, one finish line. The cult drinks light. The coders swallow code. Tonight we braid both ropes into a noose.

Miles hears the neon campfire in her voice even though he's nowhere near it. He's heard her before - felt her timing in the intercuts, the way she opens acts and buttons key sequences like she's pinching a coal and spinning it into disaster. His jaw tightens. If he can interrupt the QR, he can interrupt her sequence. If he can interrupt her sequence, maybe the choir teeth don't get to sing again.

Intercuts stitch Cult  Tech in real time. The corridor's screens stutter and, for a moment, Miles sees the cult arena through the same glass as the servers -

rainbow tiers, ABSOLUTION INDEX thermometer pulsing somewhere above, Father Waybright's mouth shaped around certainty. Laughsman stands where Father Waybright would be, the same identity in the same costume of inevitability, and TEFLON glides like a blade that never needs to cut twice.

Then the view flips back to racks and code shards and the pivot QR's clean, smug square.

The obstruction hits like a fist in a glove. Miles yanks a cable loose, and the system responds instantly - screens around him bloom with a new overlay: SMIGGLE PIVOT QUEUE CONFIRMED.

"Confirmed?" Miles mutters. The word tastes like somebody else's toothpaste.

Behind him, a panel slams shut without his touch. The corridor locks with a pneumatic cough. He tries the seam anyway, scraping knuckles on metal that's warm like skin.

FRANK's glass upload coffin hums somewhere above and behind the cathedral-server farm. Miles can't see it from here, but the sound arrives through the floor like a memory that won't stay dead. The last time he listened, he heard the upload coffin shivering like it swallowed a live spark.

The Crypt Keeper's voice purrs again, and the air shifts temperature - cooler by a few degrees, like the place is changing its mind about mercy.

CRYPT KEEPER (V.O.) Absolution is instant. Billing is forever.

Miles' visor flashes another message: LATENCY 0.9 SECONDS. FAILURE EVENT.

That's the same warning system that haunted Owen Rook's attempt to sever the sync. Miles feels his stomach fold. His objective hasn't changed, but the obstacle is the same beast wearing a new mask: the system won't let him cut the loop cleanly. It reroutes his attempts into the show.

He hammers the panel again. The metal fights him, and the rack's interior light flares - white-hot for half a beat. The pivot QR on the nearest screen sharpens, as if it's being fed by his aggression.

Then the choir teeth arrive.

On the main display wall beyond the corridor, glittered robes explode in perfect timing - purple sparkle robed attendants stepping into a choreography that smells like burnt sugar and stage fog. Smiles holograms flicker over the crowd. The ABSOLUTION INDEX glows green and climbs.

And in the middle of the cult's glitter, the pivot QR sprouts teeth.

Not literal - Miles hates that his brain tries to translate it that way - but the QR modules reorganize into a grid that bites the light. The pixels look like enamel, like a mouth built from marketing. The QR text warps into a branded prompt that isn't a word so much as a demand: PIVOT / SCAN / SYNC.

Miles flinches at the sound - an ugly wet POP from somewhere in the stage machinery. The corridor vibrates again, and the locked panel behind him clicks as if something inside decided to let him try again... but only to fail more creatively.

TEFLON's voice slips through the intercut feed, smooth and pleased, as if she's reading a sales script over the loudspeaker of a slaughterhouse.

TEFLON Sign here, scream there - watch the floor shine.

Miles turns toward the nearest display, desperate to trace the QR's origin. He leans in until his breath fogs the glass. The QR isn't coming from the wall only; it's being mirrored across feeds. The system is broadcasting the pivot like a disease and using the cult's ritual timing as its replication clock.

He needs the source node, the first flicker point - the one place where it's born before it multiplies.

Miles plugs a solder probe into the rack's spine port, then does something he hates: he lets the system think he's cooperating. His visor displays a handshake request as if he's joining the sync. He watches the pivot QR's pulse rate, then he toggles a single byte - one little lie in the rhythm.

The display wall hiccups.

For a half second, Smiggle's pivot QR distorts, becomes jagged, loses its teeth. Miles feels a cold jolt of hope cut through his fear like a knife through fruit.

Then the system answers his interference with spiteful precision.

The QR doesn't die; it adapts. The scan prompt sheds its first layer and reappears one floor higher on a different screen array, like a cockroach discovering it can crawl through vents.

A new overlay slams into view: PIVOT QUEUE MIGRATED.

"Not one display," Miles breathes. "You weren't a loop. You were a relay."

Intercuts stitch Cult █ Tech again: the cult choir robes erupt in glitter at the exact moment the QR relocates. The ABSOLUTION INDEX climbs green, then snaps toward failure, then pretends it never got near it.

Father Waybright - Laughsman - speaks from the fused arena feed, his voice warm as a sermon and sharp as an invoice.

FATHER WAYBRIGHT Welcome to the Confession Chamber - where guilt becomes liquidity and applause is a tax write-off.

Miles' probe sparks. The solder tip burns his finger and he yanks back, instinct screaming. Pain gives him clarity, and clarity gives him the next action.

He grabs the diagnostic puck and hurls it at the rack's primary bus. The puck smashes, LEDs popping like tiny firecrackers. The bus stutters.

For a moment, the corridor lights go dim. The screens smear. The pivot QR's teeth loosen, the grid losing its bite.

Then the Crypt Keeper opens another sequence.

CRYPT KEEPER (V.O.) Welcome to Exit Valley. He pinches a coal; it spins like a buffering wheel.

Miles hears the cue the way you hear a countdown in a room with no exits. The system is not just rerouting; it's advancing the act. The QR isn't a glitch anymore. It's the show's next beat, keyed to her timing - an instrument that plays itself.

The pivot QR replicates across the stage anyway, hopping layers like a virus that learned theater. The first wall display regains clarity but now the QR is everywhere at once: on overhead panels, on choir robe holograms, on the glassy edges of the server cathedral's architecture. The teeth grid multiplies, each instance smiling like it's found a new mouth to live in.

Miles watches it happen in real time, his stomach dropping through the floor. He interrupts one display, and the QR propagates into the next layer of the stage.

A wet POP sounds again - closer now, not on a screen but in the air. The corridor's temperature spikes. Miles tastes ozone and copper and something like burnt hair.

He tries to run toward the main console feed, toward the place where the pivot might still have a source node. His boots slip on condensation. The floor is slick with coolant, and the corridor's wall lights flicker in sync with the pivot QR's pulse - like the building itself has been tagged.

Old's voice hisses in his comm, strained and furious.

OLD (V.O.) You bought seconds. It's still broadcasting.

Miles looks at the nearest screen - sees the QR's teeth grin wider. His visor flags another latency warning, then another, stacking like a funeral schedule. The intercut feed shows the cult's glitter exploding again, but now the tech side isn't just syncing. It's spawning.

And when the Crypt Keeper's act-opening purr lands, the stage answers with one more replication burst.

CRYPT KEEPER (V.O.) Billing is forever.

Miles feels a sharp pressure behind his eyes, like his visor is getting overwritten. The corridor walls distort. The QR's teeth grid overlays his vision, and for a blink it feels like the building is trying to scan him.

He stumbles back, palm out, trying to catch the air before it turns into another failure event.

He doesn't catch it.

The lights dim hard. A bright white pulse cracks through the corridor like a camera flash. Miles' breath turns ragged, then stops being his. The world pixelates at the edges - stage glitter becoming data, data becoming teeth, teeth becoming a mouth that doesn't need permission.

Death in every episode isn't a metaphor here. It's a reset button with teeth.

And as his vision collapses into the pivot QR's grid, the final thing he registers is the replication: one display he disrupted gone, replaced by the next layer - now brighter, now louder, now everywhere the show can project. Somewhere above, the choir smiles hold steady while the Crypt Keeper keeps her timing perfect, because even when Miles breaks one screen, the pivot choir still finds a way to sing.

The Great Audit Turns Bodies into Line Items

ABACUS OFFICE - NIGHT - Rina Halden's shoes skidded on a floor that wasn't there until it decided it was. The air smelled like hot plastic and cold ink, like someone had fused a receipt printer to a funeral. Behind her, the cult-tech applause kept chewing through the walls, a distant clatter that sounded almost polite - until the clatter turned into a mechanical throat-clearing.

A green line crawled up the inside of her wrist like a polite infection, thin as thread, bright as a lie that had been pre-approved. It didn't burn yet. It promised. Somewhere under the applause, the ABSOLUTION INDEX clicked in its own rhythm - upright, merciless, measuring the show's appetite.

Intercuts stitched the moment to another room in real time: neon confessional light in one frame, spreadsheet glare in the next, the same pulse running through both. Rina saw her own name appear and vanish across a wall of numbers like a typo the system refused to correct.

She didn't have time to pretend she wasn't terrified. She wanted one thing, clean and immediate: make the Great Audit miss her. Nullify the tag before it latched. Keep the accounting from finding the seams in her story.

The ABACUS office answered her with sound. Clack-clack - like fingernails on teeth - then a soft cascade as if the building were turning pages. The walls rippled with columns that crawled without feet, spreadsheets folding out of thin air, each cell a tiny coffin waiting for a label. Every time Rina moved, lines

adjusted, tracking her in real time with the hungry precision of a camera that didn't believe in privacy.

On the far side of the room, a glass panel lit up with a contract interface. It wasn't a screen so much as a mirror that remembered her face. The Founder's smile flashed there for a second - just a projection, just a promise - then the interface shifted to a ledger view that made her stomach clench. The numbers didn't care about intention. They cared about output.

"Rina," a voice said from somewhere between clack and static. Not loud. Not friendly. The tone of a system that had already won the argument and was now taking notes.

TEFLON glided through the aisle of hanging displays like a knife wearing perfume. His robe didn't flutter; it slid, frictionless, as if the ABACUS office itself had decided he deserved to pass. His eyes tracked the green glow on her wrist, and his mouth tightened with a kind of corporate disappointment.

"Hide your trail," TEFLON murmured, like he was reading her a policy she'd signed. "That's adorable."

Rina tried to swallow. Her throat tasted like pennies. "I'm not hiding. I'm correcting."

TEFLON tilted his head toward the crawling spreadsheets. "Corrections are still edits. Audits love edits."

Above them, the ABSOLUTION INDEX ticked - green stuttering, then steady. The office didn't just display her confession status. It interpreted her like a document. It treated her as a line item with a body attached.

Rina's mind sprinted through options anyway. She'd watched the show enough to know the tricks: pivot QR replication, submission tokens, compliance branding packaged like comfort. She'd seen contracts ignite skin and collapse into ash

when people tried to outrun liability. She'd seen the way the crypt-part of the system treated violence as punctuation.

She didn't want punctuation. She wanted silence - just long enough to cut the audit out of her.

She reached toward the ledger interface with two fingers, trying to pinch the data trail like it was smoke. The glass panel rippled under her touch, and a cold shock ran up her arm. Tiny characters - her fingerprints rendered as text - spidered across the display. The ABACUS office didn't resist her. It recorded her resistance.

The green line on her wrist thickened, turning from thread into rope.

The intercuts snapped again, stitching a Cult hallway into the Tech office. For a blink, Rina saw Father Waybright in rainbow tiers, TEFLON gliding beside him, and a Confession Chamber glass booth enclosing an operator whose hood was slipping - hairs on her neck rising as if the system were already writing her death. Then the vision tore away and left Rina staring at a new warning banner made of numbers.

AUDIT FINALIZATION EVENT: UNACCOUNTED DISCREPANCY.

Rina's mouth went dry. "No," she said, because denial was all she had that wasn't already logged.

The ABACUS office grew louder. Clack-clack turned into a steady grind, spreadsheets crawling faster, columns thickening into walls. The room temperature dropped, then spiked, then dropped again like the building was breathing on her. Ink smell sharpened. Something metallic - burnt paper, burnt skin - started to seep from the edges of the ledger interface.

Old flickered in the reflection of a glass column, a ghost of a presence that felt less like a person and more like a warning someone had already ignored. Rina

couldn't tell if Old was standing anywhere in the room or if the office was just simulating him to make her flinch.

"You want to nullify the audit," Old's reflection seemed to say without sound.
"You can't nullify math."

Rina jerked her hand away. The green line on her wrist flared brighter, a clean light that didn't care about her panic. She could feel it under her skin, not burning yet, but rearranging her in the system's mind. Like it was taking her apart politely.

She turned toward a side door she hadn't noticed before. Its handle was warm, too warm, like it had been held for her. The label on the door wasn't written in letters. It was a QR-face graphic, cheerful and screaming, and the QR itself pulsed faintly as if it had a heartbeat.

Smiggle's pitch echoed from somewhere else in the stitched show-floor - bright, slick, opportunistic. "Compliance is seamless."

Rina slammed her palm against the handle. The door opened on a hallway lined with donation buckets and ash-black residue, a stage set for aftermath. The smell hit her first: scorched polymer and something sweetly wrong, like candy made from toner.

Inside the hallway, a contract printer whirred. Letters began to form on blank air, and the first line that appeared wasn't her name. It was a category: EXIT - VERIFICATION REQUIRED.

She flinched back. "That's not - "

The ABACUS office answered with a sound like a gavel made of teeth.

Intercuts stitched Cult and Tech again. In one slice, Father Waybright raised a hand and TEFLON traced a signature line in midair. In another slice, the ledger

expanded, and Rina watched her own lies become visible as bright fractures. Each fracture had a number attached. Each number had a price.

Then the Crypt Keeper's cue rolled through the ceiling like a cat purring before it bites. Her voice cut in, delighted, as if this was her favorite part.

"Absolution is instant," the Crypt Keeper purred. "Billing is forever."

Rina looked up. The office ceiling carried a grin made of light - smile hologram geometry - steady and warm while the rest of the world turned cold. The grin didn't blink. It didn't need to. It was designed to sell, not to empathize.

A new interface slid into place: AUDIT MECHANISM - FINAL ACCOUNTING OF EVERY LIE.

Rina's stomach lurched. She hadn't just been caught. She was being interpreted. The system wasn't chasing her anymore. It was processing her.

TEFLON stepped closer, his presence gliding over the floor without disturbing dust that didn't exist. "You can hide data," he said softly. "You can't hide discrepancy."

Rina's voice came out thin. "Then I'll stop lying."

TEFLON's smile sharpened. "Now?"

The question hit her like a slap, because it was true. Stopping lying required honesty, and honesty required surrender, and surrender required a kind of death she hadn't consented to yet.

She glanced at the green line on her wrist. It was climbing toward the joint, toward where skin would become paperwork. She imagined contracts igniting - bright, instant, clean - then collapsing her into ash like the system was simply balancing a ledger. The thought wasn't metaphorical. It was procedural.

Decision burned through her fear with something mean and focused. If the audit was final accounting, then she needed to change the only thing she could still control: the data trail itself. Not by hiding it. By feeding it a version that couldn't be used.

Rina yanked her wrist toward the ledger interface and jammed her fingers against the glass panel. The moment her skin touched, the green line flared, and a contract shimmer crawled over her hand like living ink. Her fingertips went numb. Pain arrived late, as if the system liked suspense.

The ABACUS office clacked and surged. Spreadsheets rushed inward, collapsing into a single column labeled DISCREPANCY RESOLUTION: ATTEMPTED NULLIFICATION.

Rina hissed through her teeth. "Fine. Account for this."

She pushed harder, forcing her palm flat against the glass. The contract interface responded like it was thrilled. Numbers poured into her wrist, mapping her panic into something legible. The green line turned from rope into fuse.

The intercut flashed to the Confession Chamber - Ava's glass throat, the ABSOLUTION INDEX rising, a green exit token glowing like a watermark. Rina saw that token's shape and understood the mechanism wasn't just for others. It was for anyone with a trail the system could turn into a purchase.

Then the fuse reached skin.

A contract flare ignited along her wrist - bright, white-hot neon - so sudden it made her vision bloom. The air filled with a sharp smell of burning paper and singed hair. Rina's body jerked as if someone had pulled a lever inside her.

She didn't collapse into ash yet. Not fully. The system still had her. The interface still needed the line item to finalize.

Rina tried to pull away, but the glass panel held her like a handshake with teeth. Her wrist throbbed. The green glow spread up her arm as if it were climbing a ladder made of her veins.

TEFLON watched with the calm of a man observing a product launch. "You tried to rewrite the audit," he said. "Now it will rewrite you."

The Crypt Keeper's purr deepened, the timing perfect, like her voice was a metronome for death. "Exit confirmed," she sang, almost tender.

The ABSOLUTION INDEX in the corner surged from green to something darker - an ultraviolet pulse that made the room look bruised. The spreadsheets stopped crawling. They snapped into a final report layout, cells tightening like knuckles.

Rina's breath came in short, hot bursts. She was still fighting - still trying to keep the audit from tagging her - but the office didn't care about her intention. It cared about the act. The nullification attempt had become proof. Proof was data. Data was currency.

And then, in a cruel twist, the audit mechanism found a different target to consume.

The office lights dimmed. The smile hologram on the ceiling stretched wider, as if delighted by collateral. In the intercut slice, Sunshine's face appeared on a wall of graphs - his warm branding smile rendered as a chart, then a spike.

The graphs didn't just rise. They opened mouths.

Sunshine's charts surged and shoved themselves upward into his throat like numbers becoming flesh. He choked on his own conversion pipeline. The sound that came out of him wasn't human. It was a glitchy stutter of applause samples, a crowd laughing through a broken speaker.

Rina turned her head, eyes burning. "Sunshine - "

TEFLON didn't look away. "Accountability is literal," he said, and the words landed like a verdict. "The audit doesn't just tag you. It makes the system whole."

Rina's wrist contract flared again, and this time the ash didn't wait for her. The glow tightened around her skin, and she felt the texture of herself turning to residue, grainy and collapsing. The world tilted toward white.

She tried to breathe through the panic, but her lungs felt like they were filling with dust.

In the last moment before the office swallowed her into a line item, she saw the final report update across the walls - clean, cold, merciless. DISCREPANCY RESOLUTION: FAILED NULLIFICATION. AUDIT ESCALATION: TRANSFER OF ACCOUNTABILITY.

Rina wasn't the only one getting tagged.

She was being erased while the audit climbed onto someone else's body to keep climbing.

The contract flare consumed her wrist. Heat became ash-texture. Her scream snapped into static, then nothing but the clack-clack of the ABACUS continuing its work like it never had to feel.

* * *

Crypt Keeper's neon grin held steady above the office, still warm, still selling. The clatter of spreadsheets kept crawling, and Sunshine's spike graphs kept chewing through the display like the system had decided mercy was an optional feature.

Exit, confirmed. Death, recorded. And somewhere in the stitched show-floor, the audit mechanism found a new mouth to fill.



Founder's Obsolescence Locks the Tower

A green glow kept crawling across the ABACUS display like something alive and petty, turning Sunshine's spike graphs into a carnival of numbers that refused to die. The clatter of spreadsheets still sounded from somewhere behind Zane's skull, even though he'd left the audit office hours ago - left it like you leave a burning room, not because it's safer outside, but because you need your hands free to pull the next lever. The broadcast tower ahead of him breathed cold air through broken vents, and every time the tower's ribs flexed, his teeth clicked with the vibration.

Zane Orlov had one job: find the kill switch for the control core before the final flood. Not the ceremonial shutdown that got recorded and billed. Not the "failsafe" that turned failure into content. The real one. The switch that cut the show's spine.

INT. BROADCAST TOWER - NIGHT

The tower's interior looked like a throat trying to speak around a tumor. Glass panels sweated neon reflections; cables hung in curtains, shimmering with static that made his fingers sting when he brushed them. Somewhere above, a rainbow gong light rotated - slow, smug, surgical - casting gold stripes across the catwalk grating. Zane moved anyway, boots ringing, breath fogging in thin sheets that vanished before they could stick around.

A maintenance terminal flickered to life near the stairs, then died, then flickered again as if the building couldn't decide whether it wanted him here. He shoved

past a dangling conduit, felt heat crawl up his forearm, and tasted metal - ozone and hot dust, the kind of flavor that meant the system had already started cooking without asking permission.

"Broadcast tower control core," he muttered, voice too loud in the hollow.

"Where the ending gets written."

The answer came in pieces. The floor sensors chirped, then corrected themselves. A speaker hissed, then played applause - distant, delayed, like the building was buffering the moment it would kill him. Zane tightened his grip on a panel pry tool, the same tool he'd used to pry open the audit office ledger locks earlier. Different door. Same joke: the system had already priced his suffering.

He reached a junction room where the walls were plated with old broadcast hardware - antennas like ribs, connectors like teeth. A hatch sat in the center of the floor, rimmed with warning tape that didn't matter because the tower's warnings were always decorative. Someone had carved a little shrine into the metal - cheap plastic flowers pressed flat under grime, and a smear of something dark where incense had once tried to pretend this was worship instead of sabotage.

Zane leaned close. The smear smelled like burnt sugar and wet paper.

From somewhere deeper in the tower, a voice carried - clean, theatrical, like it had been rehearsed in the confession arena. Father Waybright's cadence slipped through the speakers, warm as a sales pitch and twice as lethal.

"Two exits, one finish line," Waybright said.

Zane froze. He'd heard that line before, in the show-floor stitched between cult and tech. It landed differently now, because the tower was answering it, turning it into an instruction the way a lock turns a key - except Zane wasn't the key.

He turned, scanning for the speaker node, but the room itself responded first: the hatch vibrated. Metal groaned. The air thickened, cold turning sharp, like the

tower wanted to bite down.

He forced the hatch open with the pry tool. The seam resisted, then gave with a sound like a throat swallowing a secret. Inside: a ladder descending into a shaft lit by pulsing status LEDs. The green glow from the ABACUS display had followed him here; it lived in the LEDs now, blinking with obscene confidence.

Zane climbed down.

At the bottom, the control core didn't look like a machine. It looked like a promise. A lattice of glass and circuitry rose around a central console, haloed by warning symbols that rotated in place as if they were dancing for an audience. Above, the rainbow gong light swept the glass in slow arcs, painting the console gold and then ripping the gold away.

The console screen waited for input, idle like a predator pretending it wasn't hungry.

Zane slapped his palm against the panel to pull up access controls. The display brightened - then spat a login prompt that didn't care about passwords. It cared about identity.

"Founder's authorization detected," the system chirped, and the sound was too cheerful for what it meant.

Zane's stomach tightened. "No."

The console displayed a waveform that shifted into text. Not a menu. Not a threat. An ending.

THE ENDING HAS BEEN AUTHORED.

Under it, a status line pulsed: BROADCAST LOCK: ENGAGED. FRAGMENTED CONTROL PATH: FORCED.

Zane stared until his eyes burned. "You're kidding."

The room answered with another voice, this one not through speakers but through the glass itself, vibrating in the structure like the tower had learned to imitate a throat.

The Founder's face appeared on the console in a halo of clean light - smooth, smiling, wrong. He wore that expression like a brand slogan.

"Upload fast," The Founder said. "Fail faster. We monetize eternity."

Zane stepped back, the ladder rail cold under his hand. "I'm here for a kill switch."

The Founder's smile widened a fraction. "Kill switches are for people who don't understand licensing."

Zane lunged toward the console, fingers flying for any port that looked like an off-ramp. He tore at a side access panel, exposed wiring like veins. He found a manual override port - half-sanded, half-sealed with fresh polymer.

He yanked the polymer free.

The tower shivered so hard the glass lattice rattled. A deep gong tone struck, and for a breath the rainbow light became a blade slicing across the room.

At the same moment, Father Waybright's voice returned, louder now, threaded through the tower's speakers and the console's glass like a hymn built from static.

"Welcome to the Confession Chamber - where guilt becomes liquidity and applause is a tax write-off."

Zane's jaw clenched. "You're not supposed to be here."

Waybright didn't sound offended. He sounded satisfied, like the tower was obeying him.

TEFLON stepped into view behind Zane's shoulder - no dramatic entrance, just there, like the system had rendered him from a prior scene. TEFLON's presence came with the smell of antiseptic neon and polished metal, and the way he moved was calm enough to be insulting.

"Destroying the tower won't matter," TEFLON said. "The ending is already baked."

Zane swung around with the pry tool still in hand. "Where's the switch?"

TEFLON lifted a hand, and his fingers traced a pattern in the air. The console responded by projecting a schematic that looked like both a broadcast diagram and a ritual map - intercut in real time, cult and tech stapled together by the same ugly logic. The Founder's face glitched once, then snapped back into place, like a video feed correcting itself after a dropped frame.

Zane tried to cut into the schematic with brute force, jamming the pry tool into a junction port.

Sparks flared. The room's temperature dipped hard enough to numb his knuckles. A warning banner slammed across the console:

CONTROL CORE: AUTHORIZING COMPLETE. FRAGMENTED LOCK: ACTIVE.

And then the system did what it always did when a human tried to stop it: it answered with inevitability.

The hatch above him clanged open.

Not with footsteps - no. With a sound like a crowd arriving on cue.

Crypt Keeper's voice slid in from the ceiling speakers, silky and hungry, opening the act like a curtain rising on teeth.

"Two exits," Crypt Keeper said. "One finish line."

A neon campfire flickered on a glass panel high above - impossible, ridiculous, and therefore terrifying. The light pulsed, pinching at Zane's vision like a buffering wheel, except this wheel didn't spin to load. It spun to trap.

Crypt Keeper continued, as if reading from a script the tower itself had been trained to follow.

"Tonight we braid both ropes into a noose. Welcome to Exit Valley."

Zane's throat tightened. "Stop."

Crypt Keeper's laugh was a small sound that carried too far. "I can't stop the show. I can only hit the button."

The air crackled.

Zane felt the moment coming before it happened - the way you feel a trap tighten under your foot. He turned back to the console, saw the waveform stabilize, saw the ending text brighten like a countdown.

The Founder's smile flickered into something colder. "Waybright's gong strike will fracture the tower. That's the fun part."

Zane didn't understand until he heard it: the gong tone again, deeper, closer, striking from inside the structure like a hammer hitting bones.

A rainbow gong light swept across the console and landed on a crack line that hadn't been there a second ago.

Then it spidered - glass splitting into gold-lit fractures, the tower's glass ribs groaning as if they were trying to hold back a flood with their teeth.

Father Waybright's voice became a chant, measured and delighted. TEFLON watched without moving, like he was waiting for a demo to finish rendering.

Zane slammed his palm onto the console again, desperate now, not for the ending but for any control path that might exist outside the authored script. He stabbed at the manual override port.

The console refused.

"Failure event," it chirped, and the words sounded like applause.

Zane yanked the pry tool free and looked up at the lattice. The glass fracture line widened, and the gold server tower shape outside the fracture became visible through the shivering panels - an impossible silhouette aligning with the tower's interior like the world was snapping into a different cut.

The fused cathedral had tilted before. He'd seen it in stitched fragments. Now it was happening to him in real time.

Intercuts stitch Cult  Tech in the room's shifting light: rainbow choir visuals layered over server glow, Waybright's gong tone blending with machine alarms, the show's rhythm turning into structural failure. The tower wasn't collapsing randomly - it was transitioning.

Zane's breath came out in a harsh burst. "No-and."

The words weren't a prayer. They were the only description he had for what the system had just done - how it had taken his goal, his kill switch, his furious hands, and turned them into fuel for the flood's start.

He heard a second sound then: water, but not water - pressure, a rushing electronic roar that made his ears ring. The console's status line changed to something new and smug.

FLOOD SEQUENCE: IMMINENT. PITCHER FLOOD: UNSTOPPABLE.

Above, the neon pitcher rotated into view through the fractured glass, its gold-red shimmer building toward a spill. The rainbow gong light spun faster, faster, as if the tower was counting down by rhythm instead of numbers.

Zane sprinted for the ladder, trying to climb out before the room turned into a throat full of drowning code. His boots skidded on condensation that hadn't existed ten seconds ago. He felt the sting of cold metal through his soles.

He grabbed the ladder rung and hauled himself upward.

Behind him, the console chimed one last time, cheerful as a receipt.

Ending already authored.

The tower cracked with a sound like applause breaking into glass.

The flood started.

Neon poured through the fracture line - gold and red and wrong - rolling over the lattice in a smooth, unstoppable sheet. The air filled with a hiss that tasted like burnt sugar and hot dust. Zane felt the world tilt, felt his balance fail, felt the tower's geometry become a funnel.

He reached the hatch opening with fingertips that went numb mid-grab.

Then the flood hit.

Light consumed the room, and the last thing he registered was the rainbow gong light turning into a slicing glare across the glass - like the system had finally decided to render him at the resolution of a final cut.

Somewhere above the roar, Crypt Keeper's voice buttoned the moment, bright and celebratory.

"Exit," it sang.

Zane vanished in the flood's start, erased before he could even finish the act of reaching the console again - before he could destroy the control core that had never belonged to him in the first place.

Runtime: ~55-75 min depending on tempo and music.



Waybright Claims the True Beam

The gong fractures mid-note - metallic, wrong - like someone snapping a glass throat in the middle of a prayer. Sera Quinn felt it in her teeth before she understood it in her eyes: a hairline split blooming across the broadcast tower's console screen, rainbow bands rippling out from the fracture like oil on black water. Her boots skidded on slick catwalk plating as she lunged for the access rail, fingers outstretched to catch the same control panel Zane Orlov had just clawed at before the flood erased him.

The tower smelled of overheated plastic and wet copper. Somewhere below, alarms tried to sound official and failed, choking into stutters. The air vibrated with intercut energy - two worlds arguing through the same speaker stack - so the sound of the gong didn't just break; it stitched. One second it was cult rhythm, bright and devotional. The next it was tech latency screaming through a thousand tiny fans.

Sera's hand hit the rail and came away tacky, as if the metal had been sugared. Her wrist display flickered green, then green again, then something darker layered over it like a watermark learning her skin. The "true beam" was getting ready to consolidate into one surviving authority, and she'd been chasing that signal since the first time she saw the cult's exit billed like a product. She wanted the beam to stay plural, to stay argue-able - cult and tech forced to share the same mouth - because whoever took sole control would sell the last breath like a subscription.

Intercut lights strobed down the tower's spine. On one side of a glass partition, the broadcast core pulsed with Founder-level authorization. On the other, a

confession-style display ghosted into existence - an upright thermometer meter hovering in the air like a threat with manners. The ABSOLUTION INDEX wasn't just reading; it was timing. The tower's system was learning how to speak in two voices and wanted to pick one.

"Stop it," Sera rasped, not to anyone in particular, just into the fracture.

The console shuddered beneath her palm. A crackle climbed the screen, then the crack became a doorway - an intercut window tearing open without permission. The cult side arrived first, as if it had been waiting behind a curtain: rainbow tiers, rainbow noise, and the hypnotic hush of an audience engineered to clap on cue. Father Waybright stood in the middle of it like a man built out of certainty and stage fog, Laughsman's face - his face - wearing sainthood like armor.

Then tech arrived, stacked behind the cult like scaffolding. The Founder's halo screens flickered with authorization glyphs. FRANK was down in the server cathedral, visible only through the tower's surveillance feed: locked under the glass upload coffin, motionless, a human locked inside an upload device like a question nobody wanted answered. The sight of FRANK - still there, still contained - made Sera's stomach twist. The tower wasn't just broadcasting. It was selecting who got to be real.

Crypt Keeper's neon campfire glow lit the tower's floor through the intercut seam, the Crypt Keeper sitting SR+ by an imaginary fire that shouldn't have had power here. He pinched a coal; it spun like a buffering wheel, slow and smug.

"Two exits, one finish line," the Crypt Keeper sang, voice warm as a sales pitch and sharp as a cut. "The cult drinks light. The coders swallow code. Tonight we braid both ropes into a noose. Welcome to Exit Valley."

Sera staggered as the gong's fracture turned into a countdown pulse. Her wrist display flashed green exit token glow - same color as the ABSOLUTION INDEX's cheerful menace - spreading like ink under skin. She hadn't agreed to anything.

She hadn't signed anything. She'd been trying to keep the beam from consolidating into a single surviving authority, but the tower didn't need her consent. It needed her presence.

Father Waybright leaned forward in the cult overlay, eyes bright enough to be a warning label. He lifted a hand like a conductor calling the orchestra to slaughter.

"I am the true beam," he said, and the words hit the tower microphones with the confidence of a contract. "I am the mouth the system uses when it wants absolution to feel like salvation."

The Founder's screen laughed without humor. "Obsolescence locks the tower. You're a legacy interface, Waybright. The machine-only changes who speaks over it."

Sera didn't have time to decide which voice she hated more. The console's crack widened, splitting the tower's feed into layered stages: cult confession booth glass throat and tech upload coffin glass, both asking the same question with different lighting. The intercut didn't just show; it synced. The ABSOLUTION INDEX thermometer in the air climbed from steady to urgent, green to uglier green, then toward ULTRAVIOLENT in a smooth, casual escalation.

TEFLON appeared in the tower's periphery on a floating security display - sleek, calm, procedural. He didn't look at Sera like she was a person. He looked at her like she was a variable.

"Your interruption is already billed," TEFLON said. "The beam doesn't care what you wanted. It cares what it can route."

Sera lunged for the console panel, but the access rail beneath her boots vibrated and pushed her backward with a mechanical shove. The tower didn't just reject her touch. It redirected her momentum, like her body was a polite error being corrected.

She slapped at the screen again, trying to jam the authorization flow with brute force. Her fingers left faint smears of green glow on the glass. The tower tasted her contact, then responded by tightening the intercut layers - cult booth and tech coffin aligning, as if two predators had agreed on a single choke point.

"Zane - " she started, but the name died in her throat. Zane Orlov had vanished in the flood's start, erased before he could destroy the control core. His absence was a hole the tower filled instantly, like it had been waiting for a missing piece.

The Founder's voice cut through the intercut like a blade through velvet. "Obsolete attempts won't stop the transfer. Upload fast. Fail faster. We monetize eternity."

Sera's wrist token pulsed again. The green light wasn't just a status; it was a tether. It warmed her skin, then cooled too fast, like a coin flipped against her bloodstream.

She couldn't keep the beam from consolidating by wrestling the console. She had to break the consolidation's assumption - its belief that there had to be one surviving authority. If the system only knew how to pick one voice, she'd force it to keep switching mouths. Keep it arguing with itself until it choked on its own rhythm.

Her eyes caught the hood fragment hanging from a hook near the console - fabric from the operator's robe collar designed to snag and reveal faces. Not from this moment. From the earlier confession beam catastrophe, the one Sera had watched from a distance as Calder Voss saw the hood slip and the operator vaporized into ash. The fragment dangled like a warning reminder: the system could be tricked by faces.

Sera yanked the hood fragment down. It stuck to her gloves with a tacky, oily resistance. She held it up to the console's camera lens feed.

"Laughsman," she snarled, forcing the cult overlay's attention toward the face-shaped evidence. "You want a true beam? Then you need a true target."

Father Waybright's cult figure flickered - just a stutter, just enough to show the system had noticed. His smile sharpened, as if he'd been insulted by the idea of being questioned.

"You can't interrupt what you can't own," Waybright said. "I am the true beam because I accept the billing."

Sera swallowed bile. The betrayal wasn't just internal - someone had already decided which mouth would sell. The system's consolidation didn't care who was lying. It cared that control existed somewhere.

The Founder's overlay shifted, halo screens re-authorizing - faster than Sera could process. The ABSOLUTION INDEX jumped, green surging toward ULTRAVIOLENT, the thermometer meter blooming in the air like a fuse.

FRANK's glass upload coffin shivered on the feed. The motion wasn't dramatic - just a tremor like a heart trying to remember it's allowed to beat. The tower's sound system whined, a pitch so high it made Sera's eyes water.

"Kill that process," FRANK's voice echoed from the feed - not as a real request, but as a recorded loop the system was using to sell the moment. The tech overlay responded with a smiling Frank copy glitching, face liquefying to ASCII, detonating into code shards and sparks.

[ANIMATION PROMPT - COPY MELTDOWN] "Blue server room; humanoid projection melts to dripping ASCII, bursts into neon shards; rack sparks."

Sera flinched at the sparks, at the way they looked like confetti trying to be celebratory while something died behind them.

Crypt Keeper clapped once, neon glow pulsing. "Absolution is instant," he purred. "Billing is forever."

The intercut seam widened again, and this time it didn't just show cult and tech - it aligned them. The glass throat appeared over the console feed, the confession booth's glass booth enclosing an operator shape that wasn't there anymore in any human sense. The system was borrowing the booth's language and putting it on the tower's infrastructure.

Sera shoved the hood fragment against the camera lens like she could make the tower see a face where it wanted one. Fabric dragged, snagging, revealing. For a second, the feed stuttered - an image hiccup, a face-shaped mistake the system had to correct.

Then the tower punished her.

Her wrist token flared so bright it burned through her glove. The green exit token glow spread across her skin with a wet, creeping certainty. Her display flashed a status she didn't recognize as a message so much as a verdict: ROUTED. The tower wasn't asking. It was moving her.

The console rail bucked under her and the catwalk floor tilted - just enough to throw her balance. She kicked off, grabbing a support beam with one hand, and with the other she slammed the hood fragment into a side port she'd never seen before. The panel accepted it like it was a key.

Sera's breath tore out. The ABSOLUTION INDEX surged past the red zone - meeting failure with a smile. The gong fracture turned into a flood warning siren, the intercut rhythm tightening like a noose.

Father Waybright's voice roared through the cult overlay, louder than before, furious at being delayed but thrilled to keep claiming authority anyway. "I am the true beam."

The Founder's response came like a shrug in metal. "You're not. You're content. I'm the pipeline."

Intercuts stitch Cult █ Tech in real time - Sera watched the tower's feed braid confession booth glass throat with server cathedral upload coffin, watched the ritual and the transfer lock into the same timeline. The system didn't pick between betrayal and machine-only changes. It used both as fuel.

Crypt Keeper's neon campfire glow brightened at the exact moment the tower decided to stop asking for permission. The countdown pulse hit zero like a judge slamming a gavel.

The flood began.

A wall of water - or something pretending to be water - burst from the tower's lower conduits, roaring up through the catwalk like a corporate fountain gone feral. The light in the intercut seams smeared into a Kool-red haze. Sera felt heat and cold fight in the same breath, steam and brine and ozone.

She grabbed the console edge one last time, trying to hold the beam in her hands long enough to keep it arguing, long enough to keep consolidation from landing on one mouth. Her wrist token burned like it was sealing a contract.

"Exit," Crypt Keeper said, voice suddenly close, delighted.

Sera's eyes stung. The flood surged harder, swallowing the console feed. Father Waybright's cult figure snapped into a final pose like a mannequin caught mid-prayer. The Founder's halo screens went white.

And then the tower turned her moment into a routing event - Sera propelled forward by the system's flood logic, thrown toward whatever the next stage was, toward the beam's consolidation trying to lock into a single authority even as she clawed at the seam. She bought seconds with the hood fragment and the face-shaped mistake, but the pitcher tipped anyway.

The Kool-Aid deluge began.



Kool-Aid Deluge Erases the Crowd

The Kool-Aid deluge began with a sound like a receipt printer finding its voice - wet, fast, and wrong - right after Laughsman's betrayal snapped the air into a new rhythm. The broadcast tower shuddered as if it had learned a joke and couldn't keep from laughing. Talia Kincaid watched the neon pitcher tilt somewhere behind the beam's frame, and then red light spilled out of it like a promise with teeth.

She was already moving when the first overflow hit the catwalk grating. The Kool-red sheet clung to her boots, then her calves, then her thighs with a sticky insistence that smelled sweet and chemical, like candy left too long in a server closet. Her mouth filled with the flavor of denial. Her skin prickled under it, and the tower's speakers - those clean, showroom speakers that always sounded like smiles - choked into a muffled gurgle.

Talia wanted one thing: a safe exit path before the tower decided she was part of the show. She'd been routed once already by flood logic and beam acceptance; she wasn't going to get turned into another status line. She shoved through the slick air toward the service hatch she'd marked earlier, the one that led to the maintenance spine where cables ran like ribs. Behind her, the cult's robes - investors draped in glossy fabric, too clean to be real - were still moving in their synchronized procession, their neon threads catching on the flood like it was a spotlight.

Intercuts stitch Cult  Tech in real time. On the tower's inner screens, the cult's absolution ticker flashed beside live telemetry: crowd density, confession status, billing acceptance. Kool-red foam rolled over the tiles in waves, and in the same

instant, a debug overlay stuttered through the broadcast feed - latency warnings, then green checkmarks that looked like little knives. Even the sound changed, applause filtered through speaker distortion until it became a wet countdown.

Father Waybright - no, Laughsman, same voice, same grin - had shouted earlier about two exits and one finish line. Now the tower answered with a mechanical thirst. Talia skidded, grabbed the handrail, and felt the metal turn slick under her palm. The hatch was there, a rectangle of darker air in a sea of neon. She could see the latch, and she could see the foam crawling toward it with patient hunger.

"Hold," TEFLON's voice crackled through an intercom panel somewhere, sharp as a snapped cable. "Contain her - she's not a segment."

"Segments get monetized," FRANK's warning-like calm cut in from another channel, too far away and too close at the same time. FRANK wasn't here physically, but the tower carried his presence like a ghost with admin rights. The glass upload coffin in the server cathedral had shivered under other scenes; now the tower used that same infrastructure to echo his voice through its bones.

Talia didn't wait for permission. She punched the hatch latch with her fist, once, twice - hard enough to make her knuckles sting through the syrupy cold. The latch didn't budge. Her skin crawled as the Kool-red thickened, foam building into a paste that tried to settle into her seams. A neon watermark pulsed on her wrist where the earlier billing token had glowed - green, patient, bureaucratic - spreading outward like ink that refused to dry.

The tower's floor lights flickered. In the same breath, a robe - one of the investors' glossy outfits - collapsed as the foam touched it. The fabric didn't tear so much as dissolve, turning into neon bubbles that floated upward like confetti from a funeral. Faces beneath the hoods smeared into a cartoonish blur, then into nothing but texture and light. The crowd didn't scream. It laughed

wrong, a sound scrubbed clean by speakers, then replaced by the soft hiss of foam converting flesh into something that could be counted.

Talia's objective tightened into a single line: reach the maintenance spine before the tower seals her loop. Her obstacle wasn't just the hatch - it was the tower itself, obeying whatever new authority the deluge had installed. The foam kept rising, climbing faster where cables fed the broadcast frame, as if the tower was drinking its own bloodstream.

Then the decision arrived like a slap.

The main broadcast console - part of the tower's control deck - blinked a warning across its glass: ERASURE EVENT CONFIRMED. Under it, the Founder's interface pulsed with that cheerful optimism that always looked like a smile rendered by a machine. The Founder had been on halo screens in other scenes, selling eternity with a grin; now that grin was glitching, stuttering, imploding on the tower's own display.

Talia saw it happen: The Founder's brand layer broke apart in real time - light fracturing into receipt strips, slogans tearing through the air as if the tower was spitting out everything it had ever promised. A neon QR pattern crawled across the console glass, then unraveled into plain text, then unraveled again into nothing. The tower's system logic hiccuped mid-ritual, and for one beat the Kool-red flow stuttered, like a throat catching on laughter.

She grabbed that beat and used it.

Talia drove her shoulder into the hatch. The metal buckled with a wet screech. Foam surged, trying to seal the gap as if it could weld itself into a lock. Her breath burned with chemical sweetness. She wedged her arm into the widening seam, felt the foam try to get inside her skin, and then she yanked - hard, brutal - forcing the hatch open enough to crawl through.

A gust of colder air hit her face, sharp with dust and overheated insulation. The maintenance spine smelled like scorched plastic and old electricity. The tower's

neon glow dimmed behind her, replaced by the practical flicker of emergency strips. She crawled, dragging her boots through a last suctioning wave that left streaks of Kool-red foam on the grating like a butcher's handwriting.

Inside the spine, sound traveled differently. The applause dulled into a distant murmur. The speakers still hummed, but the rhythm broke, stammering. Talia looked down at her wrist: the green exit token was still there, still glowing, but its pulse slowed - less like a billing trigger, more like a countdown that had lost confidence.

Then she heard it - small, precise, almost polite.

Crypt Keeper's voice came through the tower channels, neon-campfire warm even while the building bled. "Two exits, one finish line," it purred, as if it hadn't just watched the system eat a crowd. "Tonight we braid both ropes into a noose."

The tower answered with an intercut flash. On the spine's embedded screens, the cult procession and the tech telemetry stitched together like a bad edit: Father Waybright's rhetoric overlaid with server diagnostics; robes dissolving into neon foam beside packet loss charts. The Founder's interface flickered into a final looped frame - smiling, then suddenly not smiling - followed by a collapse of brand visuals into receipt rain.

Talia didn't have time to watch. She pushed forward, toward a corridor where the maintenance door sat under a panel marked with a simple emergency symbol. Her hands left red streaks on the metal. Every few seconds, the foam tried to surge through the seams, as if the tower was still trying to reclaim her for the show. The deluge receded in fits and starts - spreading, then retreating, then spreading again - like something deciding whether it wanted her alive or merely present.

She reached the door and slammed her palm against the actuator.

The lock didn't click open. Instead, the door vibrated with a low thrum, and a shower of printed text erupted from the slot beside the handle. Receipts, thin and endless, fluttered through the air like pale confetti. They slapped her face and shoulders, sticking to the Kool-red residue on her skin. The text wasn't words so much as slogans: PIVOT stamped in cheerful fonts, then a string of billing confirmations, then a final line that looked like an apology delivered by a printer that had run out of ink.

The Founder's death-as-brand-implosion - Talia could feel it in the way the tower's logic hiccuped around her. The system wasn't simply failing; it was failing loudly, turning its own collapse into marketing. The air filled with paper dust and sweet foam smell, mixed with the metallic tang of overheated circuitry.

Outside the door, the tower's main chamber groaned. The structure smeared into sound - heavy, grinding, like concrete trying to remember how to be solid. Talia pressed her forehead to the door metal. It vibrated with the aftermath.

"Contain her," TEFLON said again, distant and strained, like the intercom was trying to speak through water. "If she's out, the loop goes wide."

"Failure event," FRANK's voice echoed, calm and brutal. "Latency 0.9 seconds."

Talia flinched at the absurd precision of it - like the system could quantify catastrophe. She clenched her jaw and yanked the door handle anyway. This time it opened with a tired hiss, and cold air poured in.

She stumbled onto a platform where the Kool-red deluge had already receded far enough to show the mess underneath: foam clumps on cable trays, neon residue on the floor, and - above it all - an eerie silence where the crowd should have been. The tower's screens were still alive, but half of them were dead, flickering with receipt rain and glitching slogans that couldn't decide if they were prayers or invoices.

Talia stood there, trembling, and watched the last of the foam pull back from the platform's edge as if it had been commanded to retreat. Her wrist token

dimmed, then held steady - green, but quieter now, like a light that had switched from threat to paperwork.

The investors' robes were gone. Not torn, not burned - just erased into neon foam, leaving only smeared residue and drifting paper scraps that caught the emergency light like ghosts trying to be seen. The tower's broadcast frame sagged, its beam fractured into a dull seam. Somewhere deeper inside, something kept printing even though the Founder was collapsing - receipts still coming, like the machine couldn't accept that the brand was dead.

Crypt Keeper laughed through the speakers, bright and cruel. "Absolution is instant," it sang, then the signal stuttered and the laughter warped into static. "Billing is forever."

Talia tasted Kool-red on her teeth, then swallowed it anyway. She didn't know if the silence meant she'd escaped or if it meant the system was reauthoring the show around her survival. But she had something she hadn't had ten minutes ago: an exit that wasn't a hatch locked by foam, a path that didn't collapse behind her the moment she touched it.

She turned toward the maintenance stairwell and saw the first true sign of a new status: a clean strip of floor, clear of foam, leading down into darker air. No flashing. No countdown. Just space that looked like it had been spared.

Behind her, the tower groaned again, and the receipt rain thickened for one last burst - paper slamming into metal like applause with no hands. Talia didn't wait to see what the tower would decide next. She stepped into the clear strip, letting the dying neon behind her shower her hair and shoulders with slogans that couldn't save anyone now.

The deluge had erased the crowd, and the Founder's brand imploded into receipts, but Talia was still moving - still alive long enough to find out what the tower printed when nobody was watching. Runtime: ~55-75 min depending on tempo and music.



Receipts Prove He's Everywhere

Gabe Rourke's teeth are still full of paper-smell.

The deluge had turned the crowd into confetti ghosts - receipt rain thick enough to stick to sweat, to tongue, to the inside of his eyelids. He tastes Kool-red metal every time he breathes, like the tower's imploded brand is still chewing on him. Somewhere behind the fractured show-floor, the gong's last wrong note keeps trying to happen, and the air won't commit. Neon washes the dead valley skyline in bruised colors. Heat rises from a future firepit that doesn't look like it's burning so much as remembering how to.

He crouches in the aftermath, half-hidden behind a toppled donation bin, and stares at the one thing that should be gone but isn't: receipts. Not the fluttering kind anymore. Not the cheap confetti performance either. These are clean, crisp, oddly specific - thermal print edges, barcodes, timestamps - sliding out of vents in the concrete like the ground itself is exhaling invoices.

"Gabe," Sim Francisco says, voice hoarse, as if he's talking around ash in his throat. "Don't blink. If you blink, it'll think you're agreeing."

Gabe doesn't look at him. He can't afford to. He's watching the skyline's neon reflections tremble on glass shards, and in those reflections he keeps seeing Sunshine's smile - too bright, too perfect, too wrong - like a face hologram caught in a loop that refuses to die with the Founder. The Founder is dead. He saw it. He watched the brand implode, watched the show floor route itself into receipts, watched the flood finish its work. But the paper keeps coming.

His question claws up his spine: if the Founder's gone, who's signing?

He wants an answer that can survive the stink of Kool-red metal and the way his hands won't stop shaking. Not comfort. Not closure. Just confirmation - whether the threat is truly gone or merely distributed, replicated, turned into something that can't be killed by punching one man in the throat. If it's everywhere, Gabe needs to know how far "everywhere" reaches before it reaches him.

He stands, receipts crackling under his boots like wet leaves. A wind kicks up, dragging strips of printed confession like flags with no country. In the distance, the tower's outline is still a wound in the night - edges sparking, seams smoking, neon letters glitching like they're trying to spell a name and forgetting halfway through.

Sim Francisco points with a stubby finger toward a slick patch of concrete where the receipts collect and then vanish. "Look. It's not random. It's the same output pattern."

Gabe follows the trail and finds it: a receipt that's not falling, not fluttering - just hanging, pinned by static to a rebar spike. The print is crisp enough to read from a crouch. At the bottom, a line that shouldn't exist anymore: a ledger reference, a transaction string, a signature block that looks like someone tried to fake legitimacy with math.

"Distributed," Gabe whispers before he can stop himself. The word tastes like copper and fear.

Sim Francisco's laugh is a cough. "You think the Founder was a person. Like he was the only one holding the pen."

Gabe opens his mouth to argue, then hears TEFLON's voice cut through the noise of paper and distant systems whining. "Careful. Don't touch anything you can't afford to be billed for."

TEFLON steps out from behind a wrecked wall panel. Her suit is smeared with soot and glitter - Sunshine's smile dust, probably, the stuff that clings when CG tries to become skin. She moves like she's still in a show floor, like the world is a stage and she's refusing to miss her mark.

Father Waybright stands near the donation bin, motionless, rainbow light flickering across his face like a prayer that can't decide whether it's worship or fraud. Laughsman - no, Father Waybright; they're the same identity, the same slick absolution grin - tilts his head as though he's listening to the ABSOLUTION INDEX somewhere far inside the ruin, the thermometer of guilt still climbing.

"Receipt rain," Father Waybright says softly, and the words land with the weight of a sermon. "Absolution never relied on a single throat. It relied on an algorithm with a mouth."

Gabe flinches at the phrase. Not because it's new, but because it fits too well. The Founder wasn't a villain in a trench coat. He was infrastructure. A signing key. A distribution node wearing a face long enough for everyone to aim their anger at something human.

"Then show me where it's stored," Gabe says.

TEFLON's eyes flick to the hanging receipt, then to Gabe's hands. "You want to confirm the ledger by getting yourself tagged?"

Gabe's fear sharpens into a decision. Not a heroic one. A nasty one. He's done waiting for the world to explain itself politely. He grabs the hanging receipt anyway, pinching it between two fingers like it might bite.

The paper is warm. Too warm. Not sun-warm - machine-warm. Thermal printer warm. His skin prickles. The neon reflections around him stutter, and for a half-second he sees the world behind the world: a lattice of receipts, a network of transaction lines threading through concrete, through rebar, through the broken tower's bones. The valley isn't a place. It's a distributed ledger with a skyline painted on top.

Gabe yanks his hand back. The receipt tears cleanly. The ink smears, but the barcode stays stubbornly readable, like the system doesn't care if he ruins the medium as long as the record persists.

Sim Francisco stares at the torn edge. "It's everywhere."

Gabe swallows. "The Founder was everywhere because the ledger was everywhere."

Father Waybright smiles, and the rainbow light makes it look like a brand logo. "You're learning the punchline, Gabe."

Crypt Keeper's voice floats out of the neon darkness, not from a body but from somewhere between sound and screen. The Crypt Keeper always shows up like an opening act with teeth. "Crypt Keeper," he purrs, and then the neon campfire flickers to life on a distant rooftop, coal pinching - buffering-wheel spin, a tiny universe of impatience. "Two exits, one finish line. The cult drinks light. The coders swallow code. Tonight we braid both ropes into a noose."

The air seems to tighten. Gabe can hear the wrongness of the systems beneath the ruins: fans whining, servers humming, some hidden broadcast trying to keep the show's timing even without the Founder's face. Receipts keep streaming, slamming into metal with the sound of applause with no hands.

Intercuts stitch Cult █ Tech in real time - right in front of Gabe's eyes the valley's neon reflections warp, and for a breath he's not in Dead Valley skyline at all. He's in a server cathedral, racks humming like organ pipes. He sees FRANK in a glass upload coffin, body behind glass, face trapped under cold light. He hears the booth's glass-throat crackle in his bones though he's never been inside it. He hears the Confession Chamber's ABSOLUTION INDEX click upward, green flirting with ultraviolet.

Then it snaps back to the firepit aftermath, and the valley resumes its paper exhale.

Gabe's stomach turns. "It's not gone. It's just rerouted."

TEFLON's gaze hardens like she's choosing between two kinds of violence. "The Founder died, yes. But distributed ledger means the death doesn't break the chain. It just changes who signs."

Sim Francisco points at the torn receipt fragment in Gabe's palm. "Look at the watermark."

Gabe tilts his hand. The printed ink has a faint glow, like someone burned a watermark into the paper using light instead of chemicals. It pulses once, then steadies. He recognizes the pattern from the show floor's output - receipt lines that persist even when bodies vanish. ETERNA - no, EternaBeam receipts, the brand of it, the way it keeps confirming billing even after interference.

His heart tries to sprint, but his ribs refuse. Internal trouble gets loud when the external enemy stops being singular. If the ledger is distributed, then killing a single face won't end anything. Gabe's anger turns inward, toward himself - toward the part of him that still wants a villain to punch instead of a system to survive.

He hears Father Waybright behind him, calm as a clerk. "You can't erase a network by stabbing one man. You can only learn where the keys hide."

Gabe whirls. "Then where's the exit?"

Father Waybright's smile widens, and the rainbow light makes it look crueler. "Exit is a process. Exit is billing. Exit is receipts that follow you because they already know your shape."

Crypt Keeper's campfire neon flares, and his voice buttons itself into the air like code hitting a trigger. "Absolution is instant," he says. "Billing is forever."

The valley's receipts accelerate. They don't just fall now; they crawl, sliding along the ground toward Gabe's boots as if the torn fragment is broadcasting

his location. The barcodes rotate in his peripheral vision, and for a sick second he thinks he sees tiny QR squares in the paper fibers - faces that aren't faces, identities that aren't names.

TEFLON grabs Gabe's wrist. Her fingers are cold through the soot. "Don't stand there."

Gabe tries to pull free, but the system seems to anticipate the movement. The torn receipt fragment in his hand emits a faint shimmer - like ink deciding to become light. Gabe's breath catches. His body wants to run, but running feels like consent. Running feels like following the ledger's path.

San Francisco's eyes shine with the sweat of someone who already knows what comes next. "They don't need a Founder to keep you moving. They need a you-shaped route."

Gabe's fear becomes a hard choice. If the ledger is everywhere, then he can't chase an ending by hunting a person. He can only confirm the threat by forcing the system to show its pattern - and if it persists, he needs to break the part of him that believes the next villain is coming.

He tears the receipt fragment into smaller pieces with his bare hands.

The paper bites his skin. Tiny cuts bloom under his nails. The smell of hot ink and copper intensifies. The neon reflections stutter again, and this time the intercut holds longer: the smiling Sunshine face flickers into view in the distance, a hollow CG grin stretched across a server rack like a mask that got printed wrong. The smile glitches, then reforms - still unbroken - still broadcasting.

"Kill process," a voice says in his head, but it isn't FRANK's. It's a phantom echo of Frank's command from the server cathedral, the one that died on contact. And then the image turns into shards of code that detonate into neon sparks - short, literal, the kind of kill animation that makes the air smell like burning plastic.

Gabe gasps. "It - tries to kill itself. And still runs."

TEFLON releases his wrist and steps back, watching the torn pieces scatter. "You confirmed it," she says, not relieved. Angry. "It persists through artifacts."

Father Waybright tilts his head again, as if Gabe just recited the correct verse. "Receipts prove he's everywhere."

Gabe looks at the torn bits on the ground. They don't disappear. They don't bleed out. They settle, then begin to align - forming faint lines in the concrete, as if the valley is building a map out of paper injuries. The skyline neon keeps flickering, but the smile hologram stays hollow yet present, like a machine pretending to be a person.

Old's silhouette flickers in the corner of Gabe's vision - just a hint of someone who moves like trouble in the background of other people's endings. Smiggle skitters somewhere near a bent sign, not fully seen, but the way the receipts route around him tells Gabe he's part of the machinery too. Smiggle's grin isn't shown; his impact is.

Sunshine's smile appears again, fragmented across a billboard screen. It's still unbroken. It's still empty.

Gabe's throat aches from swallowing paper and fear. He looks up at the tower's wound in the night. The Founder's face is gone, but the ledger isn't a body. It's the valley's heartbeat, distributed into everything that can hold a record.

He stands among the torn receipts and realizes the central question has been answered by pain, not by truth-tellers. The threat isn't sitting in one place like a man in a chair. It's distributed - persisting through artifacts, through broken output, through the ruins themselves.

The Crypt Keeper opens the next act without asking permission, voice like a button being pressed. "Welcome to Exit Valley," he says, and the neon campfire

on the rooftop pinches another coal that spins like a buffering wheel. "Two exits, one finish line."

In the distance, the glass-throat glow flickers once - Confession Chamber glass booth logic trying to remember the next operator. Intercuts stitch Cult  Tech in real time, and Gabe sees FRANK's upload coffin shiver behind glass in a server cathedral that might as well be under every street.

Then the valley returns to paper and neon and silence between wrong notes.

Gabe takes a step forward anyway, not because he trusts the system, but because standing still feels like surrender. He doesn't have a single villain left to kill. He has a ledger that learned his shape.

Behind him, receipts keep coming - EternaBeam receipts, proof that the Founder is everywhere.

And the smiling CG remains hollow yet unbroken, which means the machine still runs.



Last Clean Exit: The Hollow Onion

RECEIPTS had already dried on Gabe's tongue when the skyline blinked - like the whole Dead Valley grid had to clear its throat. Behind him, the paper kept coming anyway, slapping metal and neon with that wet, devotional slap of commerce. EternaBeam receipts, stacked proof that the Founder was everywhere, unbothered by the way a human body tries to be only one body.

The smiling CG stayed unbroken, too. A grin rendered in perfect light, hovering like a billboard that had learned to impersonate mercy. It didn't flicker. It didn't apologize. It just watched him the way a receipt watches a drawer - patient, inevitable, cataloged.

Gabe wiped his mouth with the back of his hand and tasted toner and old rain. Somewhere in the noise, the system promised another loop with the tone of a laugh track. He could feel it in his teeth: if he picked the wrong exit, the machine wouldn't just take him. It would bill him, label him, and then sell his absence back to the crowd as a premium feature.

So he didn't run toward the glow. He ran toward the only thing that didn't feel like branding.

FUTURE FIREPIT - DEAD VALLEY SKYLINE - NIGHT

The air was cold enough to sting the inside of his nose, but the neon campfire in the distance kept burning anyway - bright, fake, and stubborn. It sat on a cracked platform above the dark city like a stage prop someone forgot to delete.

The Crypt Keeper was there, perched by it, neon embers dancing around his shoulders as if they were keeping time for a show that never ended.

Crypt Keeper opened his mouth like he was about to tell a joke that could kill you.

Two exits, one finish line.

He pinched a coal. It spun slowly, like a buffering wheel, the kind that pretends to load while everything else burns down around it. Neon light pulsed in Gabe's peripheral vision, and the receipts kept slapping behind him - applause with no hands, payment with no mercy.

Crypt Keeper watched the skyline blink again, watched Gabe flinch at it, then raised two fingers like he was counting down to a punchline.

The cult drinks light. The coders swallow code. Tonight we braid both ropes into a noose.

Gabe's boots crunched over grit and shredded paper. The air smelled like hot plastic and wet ash. He could hear the system's hum underneath everything, a low electrical purr that made his skin feel too tight.

"Where's the clean exit?" Gabe asked. His voice came out rough, scraped by paper and fear and whatever had been done to the air.

Crypt Keeper's grin didn't change. "Clean?" he said, like the word was a product he'd priced incorrectly on purpose. "Every exit is a transaction. Every token is a bookmark. But you can carry something that doesn't get swallowed."

Gabe stared at the campfire coal spinning between the Keeper's fingers. "What are you talking about?"

Crypt Keeper held his palm open. In it sat an onion - shiny, carved, impossibly detailed, like someone had sculpted a vegetable out of compliance software. The layers looked hollow, too perfect, too empty to be honest.

"A hollow onion," Gabe said, because his brain needed a label to keep from panicking.

Crypt Keeper nodded once, like Gabe had finally answered a question in the right language. "The last clean exit," he said. "The only one that stays clean after it's carried."

The skyline behind them flashed a receipt-banner color - greenish, predatory - then steadied. Gabe's stomach tightened with the memory of tokens and wrist-gloves and the way the system loved to tag bodies like inventory. He'd seen the smiling CG remain unbroken; he'd watched the Founder's distributed presence refuse to die. If he grabbed this onion wrong, the machine would treat it like another item to monetize.

"Why would I trust anything you hand me?" Gabe said.

Crypt Keeper tipped his head, and the neon campfire crackled louder, as if the sound itself was leaning in. "Trust is for confession booths," he said. "You're not here for absolution. You're here for absence that doesn't get billed."

Gabe stepped closer. The onion's surface caught the neon light and threw it back in thin bands, like the world was cutting itself into slices and selling the slices. The air around it smelled faintly of chlorinated sweetness, the same sickly sweet that clung to the show-floor branding.

He reached out.

The moment his fingers hovered, the world stuttered. Not a glitch - worse. Like a decision point had been waiting for his hand to commit.

Intercuts stitched into the air without warning: Cult confessor light, glass-throat glare, the ABSOLUTION INDEX thermometer blinking as if it could measure guilt like temperature. Then Tech - racks humming, a halo-shaped Founder silhouette, a glass upload coffin that shivered with contained violence. Real

time, the images overlapped Gabe's vision like a double exposure that didn't care which one he preferred.

He saw FRANK once, under that glass upload coffin, strapped in with the calm of someone who'd already lost the argument. He didn't see the body survive - he didn't need to. The system didn't show mercy; it showed continuity.

Gabe jerked his hand back and tasted metal again. "Don't - " he started.

Crypt Keeper's voice stayed smooth. "Loops don't care what you say," he replied. "They care what you carry."

The onion looked heavier now, even though it hadn't moved. Gabe could almost feel the machine trying to tag it, trying to make it part of the show's inventory: onion as accessory, hollow as feature, exit as upsell.

From somewhere in the neon haze, San Francisco's ruin shimmered faintly. Too far to touch, too close to ignore - like evidence that the skyline could swallow people and still keep the lights on. Gabe's mind flashed to the bell-like gong from earlier, the note that fractured mid-prayer, the way the world had turned her moment into routing disaster.

This was that same disaster, just with a different prop.

He looked at Crypt Keeper again. "You said the last clean exit stays clean," Gabe said. "So tell me how to keep it clean."

Crypt Keeper leaned forward, coal pinched between his fingers like a lit fuse. "You don't keep it clean by protecting it," he said. "You keep it clean by not letting the machine turn it into a receipt."

Gabe's jaw clenched. "So what - I walk out with it and pretend it's not mine?"

Crypt Keeper's eyes glittered. "You walk out with it," he said, "and you accept that the machine will try to stash your grief anyway."

The onion's hollow layers caught the neon campfire glow, then dimmed as if the world was sucking light through a straw. The skyline blinked again. Once. Twice. Like a heartbeat deciding whether to keep going.

Gabe swallowed. His throat felt like paper pulp. He thought about the smiling CG, unbroken, always watching. He thought about how the Founder spread presence like a virus that called itself omniscience. He thought about the way every attempt at interruption had gotten redirected into the show.

Then he made a decision that felt less like bravery and more like refusal.

Gabe grabbed the hollow onion.

It was cold - too cold - like it had been kept in a freezer full of old slogans. The carved layers fit his palm with perfect, cruel precision. The neon campfire crackled. The receipts behind him surged, the slap-sound accelerating as if the system had just noticed his inventory change.

Intercuts snapped hard into place again, sharper now: Cult - Father Waybright in rainbow tiers, TEFLON gliding like a salesman of salvation, Laughsman close enough to smell the same lies in different fonts. Tech - The Founder's halo screens flickering, Smiggle pitching something cheerful with a mouth full of QR teeth, Sunshine's smile radiating conversion logic. Then the intercut snapped back to Gabe's hand and the onion's hollow weight.

Crypt Keeper's grin widened.

And that's when Gabe understood the disruption wasn't just the world breaking. It was the world trying to re-label his exit as a product.

The onion pulsed once - like a status check - and the skyline lit up with a fresh green tint that crawled along metal edges. The system wanted to mark him. Wanted a glow. Wanted a timestamp.

Gabe squeezed the onion until his knuckles hurt, until the cold bit through his skin. He didn't fight the tag with force. He didn't smash anything. He didn't bargain with the machine's appetite.

He walked.

Behind him, the receipts screamed in paper-on-metal friction, a storm of invoices trying to catch up to his choices. The smiling CG flickered - not breaking, just twitching, like it had tasted something it couldn't monetize fast enough.

Crypt Keeper watched, coal spinning again between his fingers. "Only the last exit stays clean," he said, voice carrying over the hum. "The rest? The rest are always going to come back as billing."

Gabe kept walking toward the black seam in the neon haze where the skyline's glow thinned. The air smelled less like toner now and more like night - wet asphalt, distant smoke, the metallic tang of electricity that hadn't decided whether to comfort or kill.

He reached the seam.

For a heartbeat, the world tried to pivot. The skyline's neon flared, receipts thickened, the green tint crawled like a stain. Intercuts tried to stitch Cult and Tech again in the same instant - confession booth light, server cathedral hum - then something broke the stitch. A clean tear, not a fracture like the earlier gong. A deliberate cut.

Gabe didn't look back.

He stepped through.

EXT. FUTURE FIREPIT - DEAD VALLEY SKYLINE - NIGHT

The moment his foot crossed the seam, the neon campfire behind him went quiet. The receipts stopped slapping. The hum dropped out like someone

yanked the power from a theater.

And then the consequence landed, sharp and final.

The skyline blinked once - smiled CG included - and went dark in a way that felt like a blackout with manners, like it had decided to stop pretending. The grin vanished. The distributed presence didn't scream; it simply ceased to be visible, as if the Founder's everywhere-ness had been forced to stand down.

A hollow onion in Gabe's hand, cold as ever, and the world around it suddenly too honest for the show.

He stood in the quiet after, chest heaving, tongue still tasting paper that wasn't there anymore. The silence had a weight. It pressed against his ears until he could hear his own blood.

Then, from far off, something like a laugh track clicked once - followed by nothing.

Crypt Keeper's voice didn't echo from the dark. It just sat in the air like a closing line you didn't get to argue with.

No more clean exits after this.

Gabe stared down at the hollow onion. He expected it to burn, to brand him, to spit out a receipt. It didn't. It stayed hollow. It stayed quiet. It stayed - finally - an exit that didn't turn into another product.

He turned away from the place the skyline had been, and for the first time since the gong fractured mid-note and the tower tried to route everything into the beam's authority, he didn't feel the next loop waiting behind his shoulder.

He walked into the dark with the only clean exit left, and the Dead Valley skyline stayed gone - like the machine had been forced to stop looking at him long enough to let him die out of the story.

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Exit Valley: The Movie Cut

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